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A dark, atmospheric illustration in a noir style. It depicts a detective in silhouette, wearing a trench coat and hat, walking down a city street. In the background, a tall building with a distinctive tower is visible. To the left, a person is seen climbing a fire escape. A street sign with a stylized 'M' is on the right. The overall mood is gritty and mysterious.

HOW TO DRAW
NOIR COMICS

The Art and Technique of Visual Storytelling

SHAWN MARTINBROUGH

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How to draw noir comics
: the art and technique
2007.

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HOW TO DRAW NOIR COMICS



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HOW TO DRAW NOIR COMICS

The Art and Technique of
Visual Storytelling

by

Shawn Martinbrough

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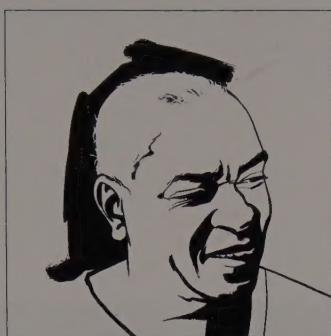
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DEDICATION



To my mom and dad, for being such good parents and taking the time to see, nurture, and always support my talent.



To my sister, who constantly strives to see the world we live in and to make a difference.



To my grandmothers, who always inspire me with their wealth of knowledge and dignity.



To Joseph Phillip Illidge, who suggested I do this book, and Jackie Ching, for getting it approved.



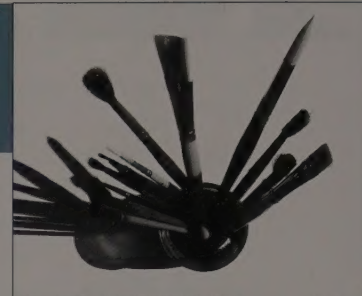
And to Sabriya Ellis, who always challenges me to do more.

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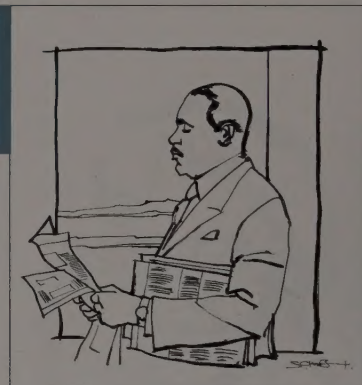
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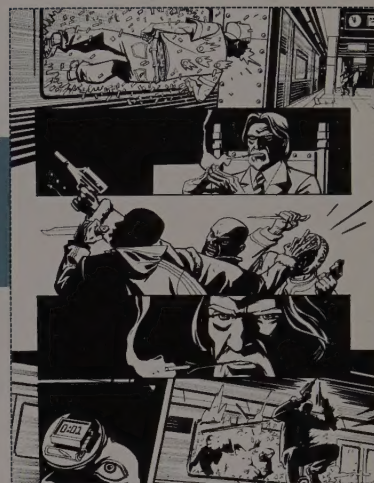
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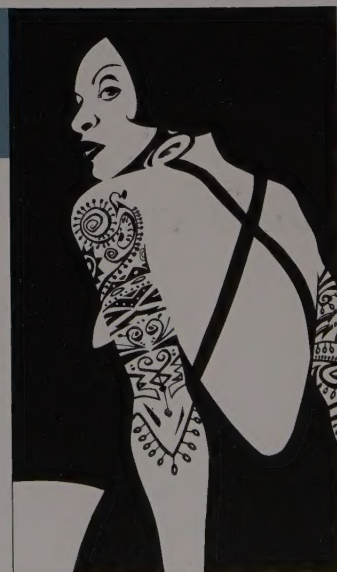
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FOREWORD

Shawn and I met because a very, very wise man wanted to make Batman something greater than he had ever been before.

The wise man was named Denny O'Neil, and his dream was to take Detective Comics, the venerable workhorse publication of DC Comics and original home of Batman, and, perhaps for the first time in modern memory, make the word *detective* one that readers took seriously. To do this, he had a plan. He had a writer who could punch out fiction so hard-boiled its yolk was green and an artist who could make a rose garden in spring feel as ominous as a deserted back alley during the hour of the wolf.

I was the writer. Shawn Martinbrough was the artist.

I can't speak to the success of my own work; I remain, to this day, my own worst critic, and honestly, even with these many years gone, I can't evaluate my work with any sense of objectivity. But I can talk about Shawn Martinbrough.

Hell yeah, I can talk about Shawn Martinbrough.

No one had seen Batman the way Shawn showed us Batman. No one had drawn Gotham the way Shawn drew Gotham. Artists had captured the danger before, certainly, the sense of lurking despair, even the feel of urban decay. But none had taken all of those elements and wedded them so effortlessly with all the other things that embodied the Batman mythos: for every dark alley, the glittering chandeliers of a five-star restaurant; for the living shadow that was the Dark Knight, the disarming charm and suave grace that was Bruce Wayne.

It wasn't that Shawn made Gotham come alive—that had been done before. Shawn made Gotham noir, and in my humble opinion, no one has managed to do it since. No one has even come close.

The fact is that Shawn Martinbrough draws the way I dream at night that I write.

If that's hard to parse, let me rephrase: what Shawn does with shadow and light, with pencil and ink, I have struggled all of my adult life to do with words. Knowing what I know about the creation of art, about its demands on the artist, I know that Shawn has struggled, too. Mastery of anything is never easy; it requires hours that become days that become years of effort and discipline. It requires the heavy self-evaluation that comes from repeated exposure to criticism. It requires incredible strength of will and blunt-force trauma, stubbornness, and perseverance in the face of ignorance, incompetence, and plain ole jealousy.

It requires devotion and real, honest commitment, the kind that comes from near obsessive desire. To master anything demands more than a simple dilettante's love. It's easy to love movies; it's something else to make lasting cinema.

Shawn Martinbrough has put in his hours, he has exercised the discipline, he has maintained his passion, and he is a master. It is fittingly, then, that what he offers here is a master's course. The lessons contained herein are not for the newly initiated, for the artist who still has fresh ink drying on his or her knuckles. Shawn's course is doctorate level, and that he delivers his teaching with such deceptive clarity and seeming simplicity only speaks more to his skill as both an artist and a communicator. The resulting work is the rarest kind of teaching text: one that illuminates while inspiring. Which, frankly, isn't that surprising at all.

Cast the right shadow, cut the correct silhouette, reveal only the detail needed—these are the tropes of the form, be it in film, literature, or art. The essence of noir, after all, is the precise application of light.

Shawn Martinbrough is a master of its manipulation.
Read, and be illuminated.



Greg Rucka
New York City
February, 2007



PREFACE

Black is my favorite color.

Although there is a debate on whether black and white are actual colors—such as red, yellow, or blue—to me black is the most vibrant. When applied, black is undeniably striking. It defines, it punctuates, it makes a statement.

The French word for the color black is *noir*. Over time, noir has come to reflect a mood, a tone, and, most appropriately, a style. Suggestive of danger or violence, film noir is characterized by low-key lighting in a bleak urban setting with corrupt, cynical characters. In my approach, the word *noir* simply celebrates the color black; it is not confined to a specific genre.

When applied to an art form such as comic books, the noir style is evident from the classic works of Milton Caniff and Alex Toth to the contemporary works of Frank Miller and Mike Mignola. Growing up as an aspiring artist, these illustrators inspired me to push the visual boundaries of the comic book page. A lover of film, I incorporated the visual approach of highly stylized noir films into my comic work. Dramatic lighting, interesting cinematic angles, and emotional moments are key in every panel I create. Perhaps my technique is reflective of noir style...or just my love of the color black.

When my friend Joe Illidge, who worked for Watson-Guptyll at the time, suggested I write a book about my style, I was very excited about the idea. However, once it was approved and I became responsible for producing the art and, more importantly, the manuscript for this book, I got intimidated.

If you ask me about art and my likes and dislikes, I can talk your ear off, but to sit down and translate my thoughts into a comprehensive text? That can be tough. Then I realized that this is just another form of storytelling, and that made the process so much easier.

In the following chapters, I will explain how to apply a noir esthetic to your storytelling.

Remember, art is an expression that is so subjective and personal that all I can do is share with you the insights and knowledge I have accumulated through my years as an artist. Art is an ongoing learning process, and I am continually seeking to develop my craft.

Hopefully I will inspire you to see this gray world in which we live in black and white.

Shawn Martinbrough
Illustrator/Director

Chapter 1

THE TOOLS

During my freshman year at the Fiorello LaGuardia High School of Music and Art in New York City, I was given lengthy lists of art materials to buy for my various art classes. My first experience with a large art supply store was at Pearl Paint on Canal Street in Chinatown. Pearl Paint has multiple floors with hundreds of different brands of paint, brushes, pens, etc. to choose from, and if I was not told specifically which brands to buy, I would have gone crazy trying to work out which were the best.

It's true that the selection of tools can seem intimidating, but there's no need to be overwhelmed. Remember, the tools with which one chooses to create vary from person to person. Also, expensive does not always mean better. I can only relate to you what works for me, so what follows are a few suggestions to guide you on your way, but obviously, choose whatever brushes, erasers, whiteout, ink, or paper work best for you.

Over time, you will develop your favorites.



PENCILS

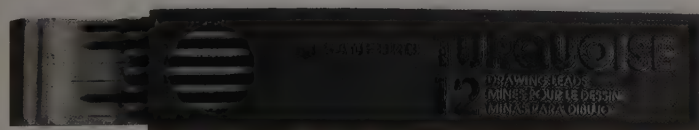
Sometimes I draw in ink, but traditionally I start my drawings in pencil and then ink over the pencil lines.

Years ago I graduated from using regular art pencils to using a technical pencil. A technical pencil is typically metal and uses removable leads.

I use a Koh-I-Noor Technigraph 5611 with Sanford Turquoise HB leads. You can choose the type of technical pencil and lead you wish to use.

The leads vary from soft to hard. I prefer using a technical pencil because of the consistency of the line it produces when sharpened. Also, the pencil itself does not wear down with use, only the lead. Once the lead has been used, you simply replace it. The Sanford leads I use come in packs of twelve, so they last a while.

If you are planning to ink over your pencil drawing, it might be best to use a softer lead. Softer leads are easier to erase and create less of a groove on the art board. The harder leads make a deeper impression, so they are harder to remove.



Graphite pencils are always great to sketch with. However, it is problematic to ink over graphite, since the graphite does not permeate the art board significantly.

INK



If you are going to apply the noir style, ink will be your life blood. You will use a ton of it.

Over the years I have searched for the perfect type of ink and have worked with many different brands. In the end, the ink you choose depends on your particular taste.

I want an ink that is permanent and will retain its opacity when it is applied to the art board. For me, permanency is the desired quality when using ink. Permanent ink means that if it is exposed to water, the ink will not run. The opacity refers to the ink retaining its thickness and rich, dark quality. It can be frustrating to draw with a type of ink that requires several coats to achieve a pure black look. When applied, many inks appear as a dark gray. Fortunately, if you are producing work that has been commissioned, the company will adjust your ink in

the production stage so that the line is pure black when it is printed.

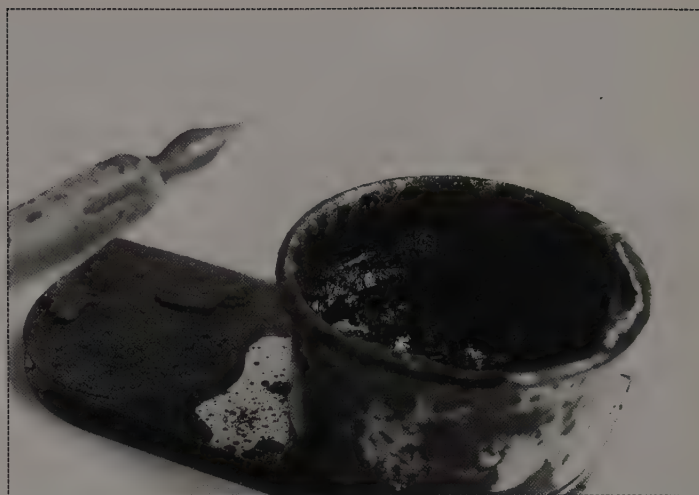
I prefer my original work to be camera-ready or pure black and white to the naked eye.

If you have ever viewed artwork done with faded ink, you can see how it detracts from the power of the image, especially when displayed under bright light.

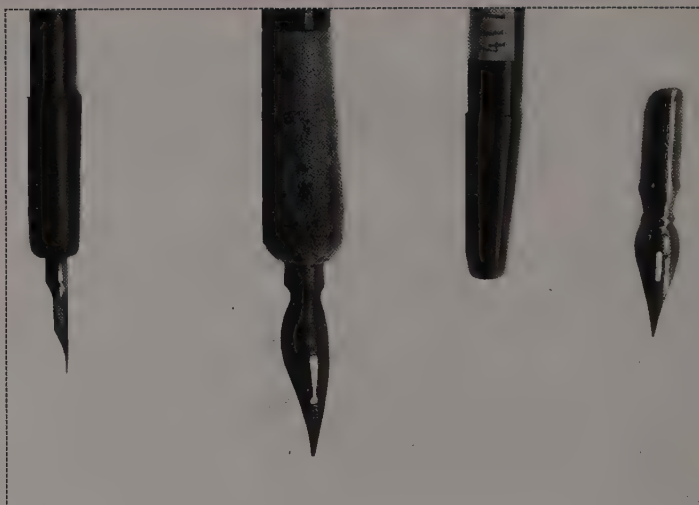
After you have finished inking your work, it is customary to use an eraser to remove any pencil lines that are visible. Depending on the consistency of the ink, it might fade when you erase, so I look for a brand of ink that is most resistant to fading.

Thickness is another consideration when choosing an ink. Most inks are made to be used with a crowquill, technical pen, or brush. However, some inks are thicker than others. Thicker inks tend to clog refillable technical pens, which is why I stopped using them years ago. The constant cleaning process became frustrating to me. Thicker ink can also clog crowquills' nibs. For this reason, you should rinse your crowquills after each use and not allow your ink to sit for extended periods of time between use. The constant exposure to air will cause it to thicken. I make a point of pouring unused ink back into its container when I am finished drawing.

My current favorite brand of ink is Rapidograph Black India Universal. This comes in small plastic tubes, designed for use with refillable technical pens, but it works well for use with a crowquill.



CROWQUILLS



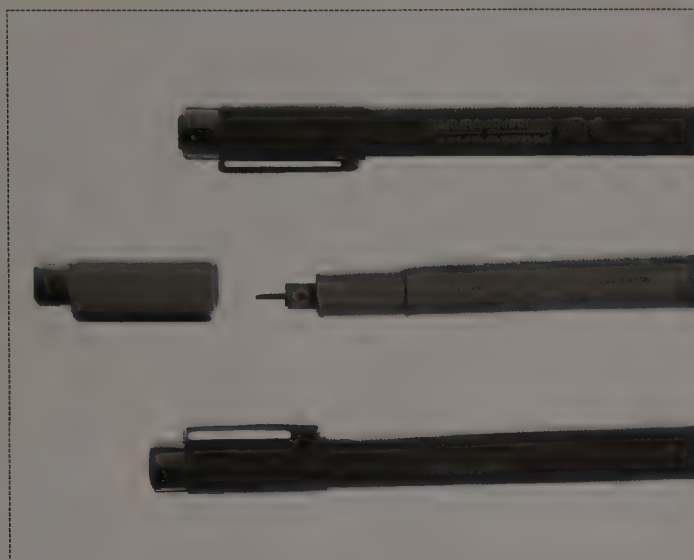
Crowquills come in numerous shapes and sizes. After using these for years, I settled on a medium range crowquill. Crowquills come in two pieces. The "nib" and the "stem." You can select different nibs for different stems, and each nib will create a different line width. With continuous use, the nibs wear down and the line it creates will become less sharp/fine. My nibs tend to last for about two to three months before I lose the degree of sharp line I desire. For best results, rinse your crowquill after you have finished using it. Then wipe the wet nib on a rag. I use an old towel or T-shirt. If you don't rinse the crowquill after

INK WELL

These are small containers that are used to hold the ink when in use. You pour the ink into the well, dip your crowquill or brush into the ink, and draw.

usage, the ink will dry and form a coat on the nib. This will limit its flexibility and give you a less refined line. More important, it will not last as long.

TECHNICAL PENS



Technical pens are very convenient because you do not have to worry about cleaning them. They are very effective for creating smooth and consistent lines. When you draw an object like a building, a car, or a computer, it is good to be able to draw even lines. Unless your goal or style is more of a freehand approach, I recommend using a technical pen for certain things.

I always try out new brands of pens. Currently, I am working with Sakura/Microperm and Micron pens. As with brushes, it is good to have several different sized pen points. I have three to four pens of each brand with different widths.

I swear by Sharpie markers. Sharpies are great because they are permanent and cheap, and the black lines that they produce are reasonably opaque. I usually work with the Sharpie fine point, which I use for drawing panel borders and general



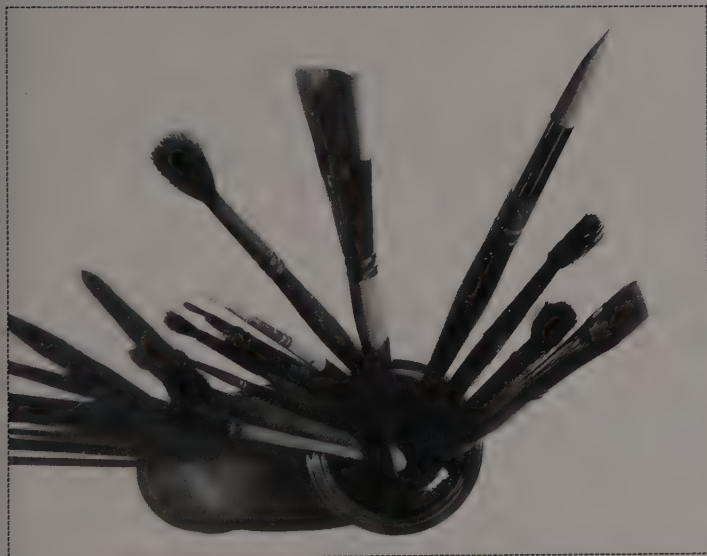
lines in the panels. When you first purchase a Sharpie, the point will be sharp. After repeated use, the marker point will wear down to a blunt tip. When it is sharp, I will use the pen to create general, semi-fine lines. Once it wears down, I will use the blunt tip for very basic, thicker lines and to block in solid black shapes. I like my panel borders to be a bit thicker, so the blunt tip comes in handy to achieve that look.

Sharpie also makes an Ultra Fine Point marker. I use this to create finer, more fade-resistant lines. The main drawback I can see with Sharpies and other types of markers is that the ink they use will “bleed” on the paper. “Bleeding” is a term for when the ink spreads after coming in contact with the paper. Imagine the effect of a drop of water on a paper towel. This reaction can be attributed to the texture of the paper you choose. With Sharpies, the bleeding is minimal, but I still notice it.

Technical pens designed for artists tend to bleed less, but there are exceptions. When you visit your local art supply store, go to the technical pen section. You will notice that the store has provided a roll of scrap paper right next to all the pens. You can use this to test the quality and nature of the pen before you purchase it.

BRUSHES

One can be very selective about brushes, according to one's taste. In my experience, the biggest problem with using brushes over an extended period of time is that the hairs of the brush split. When this happens you will not be able to control the quality of your brush line. Typically, the more expensive the brush, the more resistant it is to splitting, but this is not a guarantee. I have had brushes that were pricey last for a very short amount of time, and I have had inexpensive to downright cheap brushes last me for years. It really depends on the individual brush.



THE RINSE JAR AND WIPING RAG

As with the crowquill, you can help maintain the quality of your brushes by regularly cleaning them. In regards to a preferred size of brush, I suggest owning a variety of small, medium, and large brushes. The small allows for the finest of lines, while the medium is usually the most versatile of my brushes, allowing for both fine lines and thicker lines. The large brush is

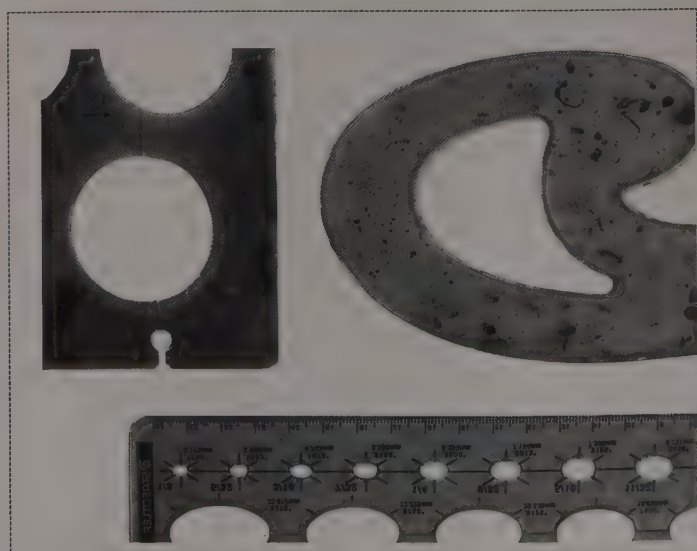


usually used for "blocking"—that is, filling in large spaces or shapes with black.

After using your brushes with ink, you must rinse them with water to maintain them. You can use anything as a rinse jar—an old can or jar will do. It is not worth buying—just look around your house. The temperature of the water does not matter. If you have spent hours at your art table drawing (and believe me, you will), it will end up being room temperature anyway.

Well, this is self-explanatory, but please do not pay for a wiping rag. As I said before, use an old towel or T-shirt.

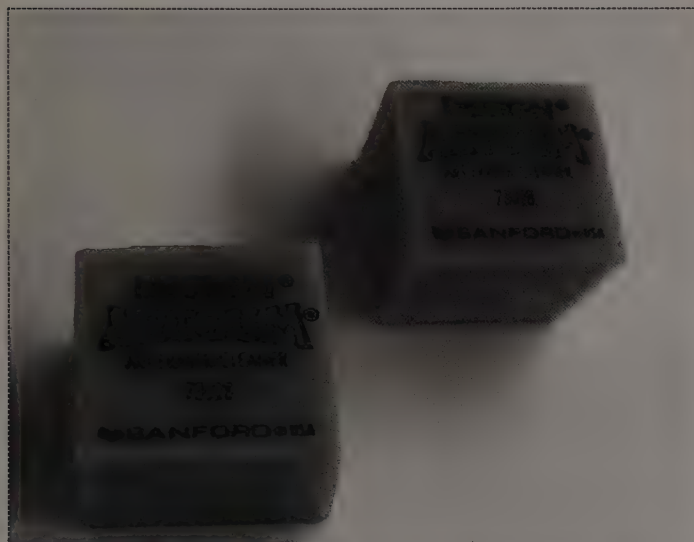
RULERS



A straightforward necessity. It is good to have a number of different sizes, so it is easier to manage when you are working on a page. A French curve is a must.

ERASER AND WIPING BRUSH

When you start to draw, erasing becomes a fact of life. A gum-based eraser is the most conducive to erasing pencil lines from a page after you have inked it. It removes excess lines without damaging the



board. Art gum erasers come in different sizes, which are a plus to have on your art table. A kneaded eraser is also good for removing subtle and less harsh lines. I also recommend using an eraser pen. These are great and very effective for erasing small specific areas of your drawing.

I use a Pentel Clic Eraser. When the eraser runs out, you simply refill it. I have finer-sized eraser pens as well for those tiny areas.

A wiping brush makes life a lot easier and is very gentle when used on art board. Just make sure that your ink work is dry before you use it to remove any pencil lines.

WHITEOUT

Whiteout is usually seen as a correction tool. If you draw an accidental or stray line and need to fix it, you can use whiteout. Whiteout comes in a variety of forms. If you go to an art supply store, you will see that whiteout primarily comes in jars. For some unknown reason, these little jars can be quite expensive, but paying for pricey supplies comes with being an artist.

Whiteout also comes in the form of pens. If you have trouble finding them at an art supply store, you can usually find whiteout pens at office supply chains. If you use the kind from a jar, you will need a brush. Just as you choose a type of brush to draw in black ink, you need to choose a brush to apply whiteout. Once you have finished your drawing and applied all of the blacks, you can go back in and further enhance the form by using white. Often, white is used to establish highlights or details on a subject or object. As with applying black ink, the size of the brush will determine the type of line you can create.

You also need to maintain the brushes you use

THE ART BOARD

with white ink the same way you do with black ink. If the brushes are not rinsed thoroughly in water, the ink will dry and harden between the hairs of the brush. After a while, you will lose the fluidity of the brush, and your ability to create smooth lines will be diminished.

In addition to using the brush to apply white, I also prefer to use a correction pen. These are very easy to use and require no maintenance. They can create a smooth and consistent white line. These pens, depending on their width, can also create a broken, streaming line that creates a convincing rain effect.



Once you get a job in the comic book industry, you will need to choose what type of paper or art board to work on. If you work for DC or Marvel comics they will provide you with their own brand of art boards. They come in two different types: a smooth "Plate" finish or a rough "Kid" finish, and each has its own advantages. Whichever you choose depends on your particular style and preference.

I usually work on smooth boards. The smooth texture facilitates clean, fine lines. It is very conducive to drawing with a crowquill or technical pen, allowing them to glide evenly across the page. The rough textured board is great for looser, more expressive styles of drawing. It works better for creating the dry brush effect whether you use black or white ink. I also find erasing pencil lines to be a little easier with the rough finish. Many of the illustrations in this book were drawn on rough textured art boards.

Chapter 2

THE BASICS



Here is a good example of cropping for effect. Cropping can always make for a more interesting design, and I believe its subtlety gives the figure life. It seems like the viewer has caught the unsuspecting subject in the middle of an act. Here I start with a contour approach (above) to establish the figure and the design. Then I establish which areas will be black and which will be white. As I block in the shapes, I am not concerned with details. The final version (opposite) is where I add details by using texture and different line weights.

A well-known artist once said to me, "Learn how to draw before you start to stylize your work."

This is probably one of the best pieces of advice I have ever been given. As an artist, you must know how to draw the human figure and have an understanding of perspective before you start getting fancy. All the slick line work, shadows, and action lines might impress your friends, but when you show your portfolio to a seasoned professional, it is a whole different story. They see through the fluff.

Since the essence of this book is showing you how to apply a style, I am not going to go into the basics of drawing. You should already know how to draw before you experiment with different techniques. In every drawing class, you are taught to draw using a very simple contour line. Some may find this boring, but it is essential for understanding form. It forces you to draw what you see.



DRAWING FROM LIFE

I definitely recommend drawing from life. If you cannot get a model or friend to pose for you, taking a photo from a magazine and drawing from that is the next best thing. It gives you the best understanding of how the human figure works, how clothes drape over the body, etc.

For most of us, when drawing from our imagination, we tend to fall back on styles of other artists that we admire. Some of you might copy artists that you really enjoy. This is not good for a simple reason: chances are, the artist you admire and imitate has an artist he or she admires and imitates. So your favorite artist is copying someone else's copy. Once you copy them, you are a copying a copy of a copy...see where I am going with this?

In short, copy life or copy photos.

PHOTOGRAPHY

Step 1: Buy yourself a camera.

Step 2: Shoot in black and white.

Step 3: Take a lot of photos.

Photography is a great tool for practicing your skill at creating interesting compositions. These are what you should be striving for in your sequential storytelling, because after all, your job is to visually elevate the script that you have been given.

When you take shots with your camera, capturing the personality of the figure is important. However, your ability to capture the personality of a car or building is just as key. Practice shooting "still lives." These are compositions of inanimate objects such as plants, tables, and chairs—basically, things

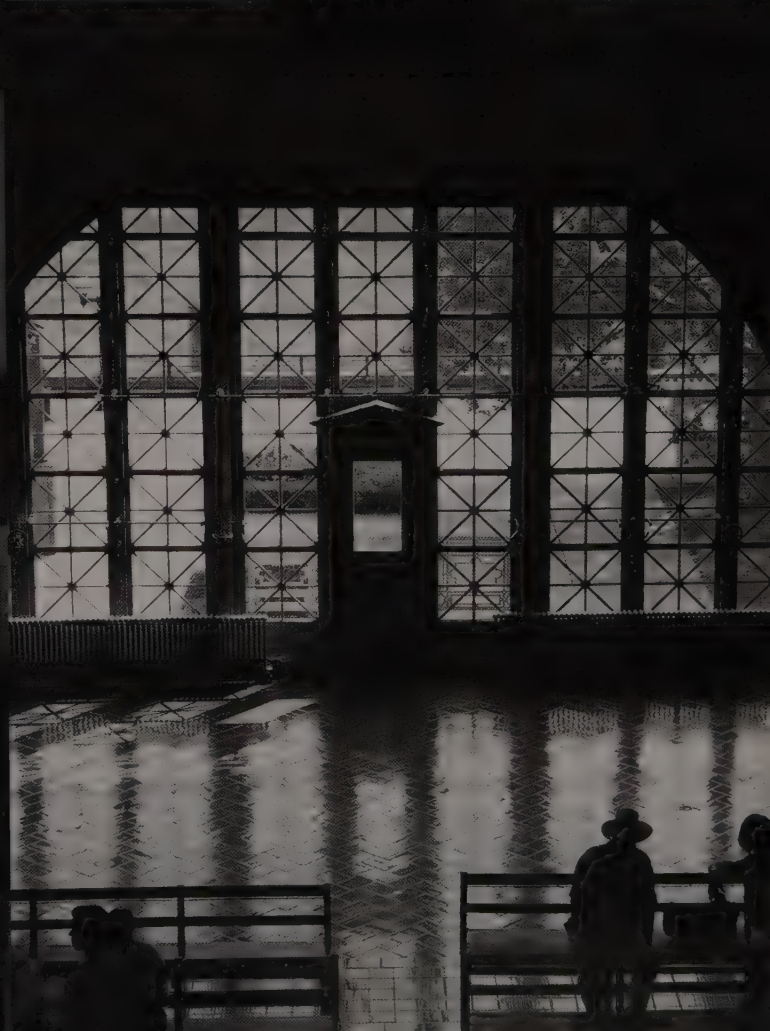
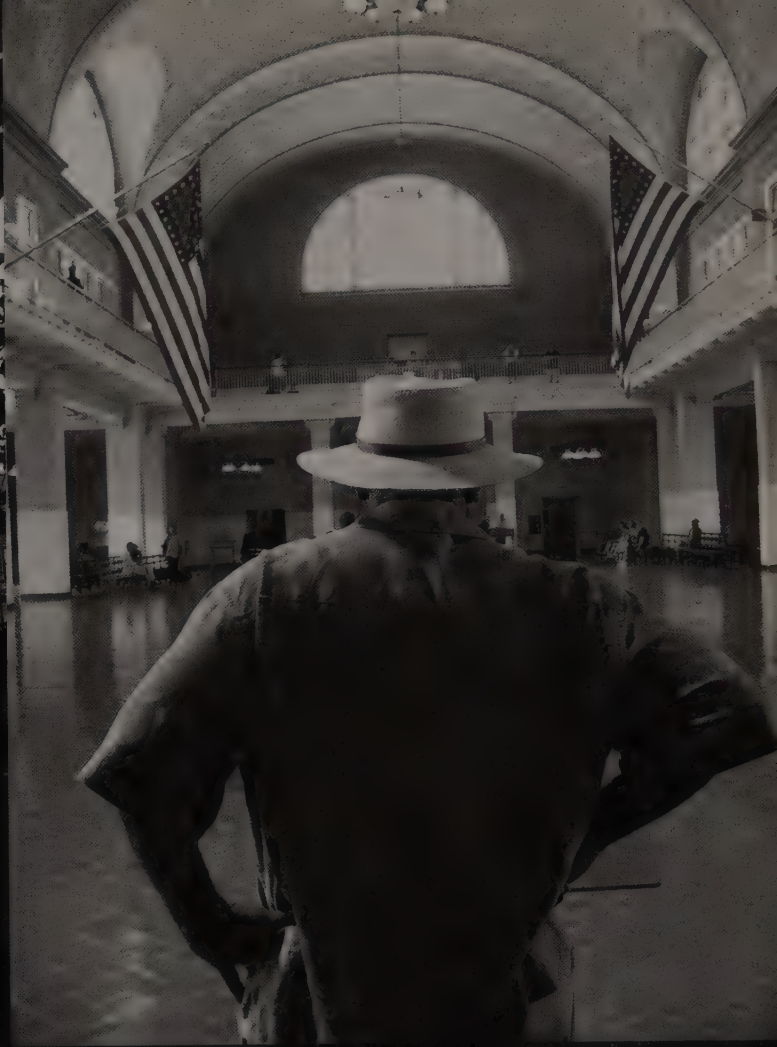


are that are not alive.

As the photographer, it is your job to use the camera and your eye to capture objects in interesting ways. Every composition will have three basic elements: a foreground, a middle ground, and a background.

A foreground subject refers to an object that is closest to the viewer. A subject in the middle ground refers to an object that is not as close as the foreground but also not as far away as the background—i.e., in between the two. The background refers to everything else that occupies the frame in the distance. I will go into further detail in a later chapter about how to maximize these elements to your advantage as a storyteller. For now, I want increase your awareness of these elements so that when you shoot photographs you use them to help compose interesting shots.

I recommend shooting in black and white because this format forces your eye to focus on dark and light, together the foundation of the noir style. Fortunately, today it is much easier and affordable to shoot in black and white. Most digital cameras have a setting that allows for black and white, and if you do not like the photos, you can simply erase them. Years ago, 35 mm was the standard film format, and black-and-white film was more expensive than color. It was also harder to find in stores that did not specialize in photography equipment. While some digital cameras come extremely close to the quality of good



old-fashioned film stock, I can still tell the difference. But for our needs, shooting with a digital camera is fine.

As a photographer, sunlight is your friend. You do not need to create it, only to manipulate it. Sometimes, you have to chase it.

Go outside with your camera on a sunny day and pay attention to how the light works. Study how light illuminates and reflects and how it creates shadows. Pay close attention to how objects in the distance or background seem lighter than those closer to you. Look at how the light strikes an object and how shadows are cast from one form to another. Understanding how light works is key to working in a noir style. Practicing your compositions and lighting with a camera really gives you an advantage when you start visualizing your script.

IT'S ALL IN THE LINE

I first entered the comic book industry as a painter. I did painted illustrations for Marvel's EPIC line for their Hellraiser line of books. Next, I illustrated my first graphic novel, called *Blockbuster*, also for Marvel. Then I started to get work as an inker. I collaborated with friend and fellow artist John Paul Leon for the next few years. He drew the stories, and I would ink over his incredibly rich pencil lines. Over the next five years I worked with John and other really talented artists at Milestone Media and DC Comics.

Working as an inker was very beneficial for me. It really helped me hone my understanding of line weight and the importance of light and dark. It echoed what I was taught back in art school—that good old contour line technique. What makes a drawing effective is the weight of the lines used.

It is the contrast of thick to thin.



I selected this portrait of Thurgood Marshall because of its contrast. The light source is entirely from one direction, which casts the other side of his face in shadow. Here you can see the shadows that are created by different planes and forms of the human face. My line weight varies, ranging from thin to thick. There are virtually no extraneous lines, so each line serves a very important purpose in defining the form.

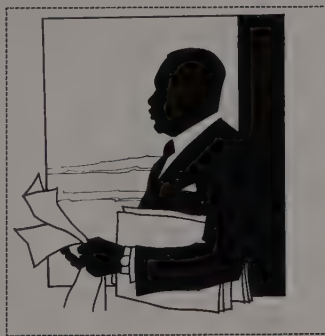
Using line to capture the gesture of your subject is essential to making something seem believable. It is very helpful to me to do a sketch or two before working on the final piece. This allows me to get a better understanding of the figure. It also forces me to see what is really important in regards to its shape and form.

I recommend using a brush to do a quick study of the figure or composition of the illustration. (Markers work well also.) You will not get sidetracked with detailing and shading. Instead, it will force you

to understand the figure as a whole and capture the energy of its movement. Many times my initial brush sketches will have more energy than the final illustration.

Again, you will not get sidetracked with line weight or shading and you will just concentrate on the form. An interesting tip I learned from a Disney animator was this: "If you strip away all of the detail and look at the outline of what you're drawing, is the shape interesting?"

It was a great point.



With this piece (above) I am creating a composition around the main figure. When you design an image, you should always be aware of your lines and shapes and how they interact with each other. In the simple line study, you can clearly see the placement of vertical shapes against horizontal ones. Once I decide which areas to black out, or "spot the blacks" (see chapter 6), you will see the contrast of line against solid shape. When designing a composition, it is important to see and arrange the basic shapes in an interesting way before you pay attention to the details.

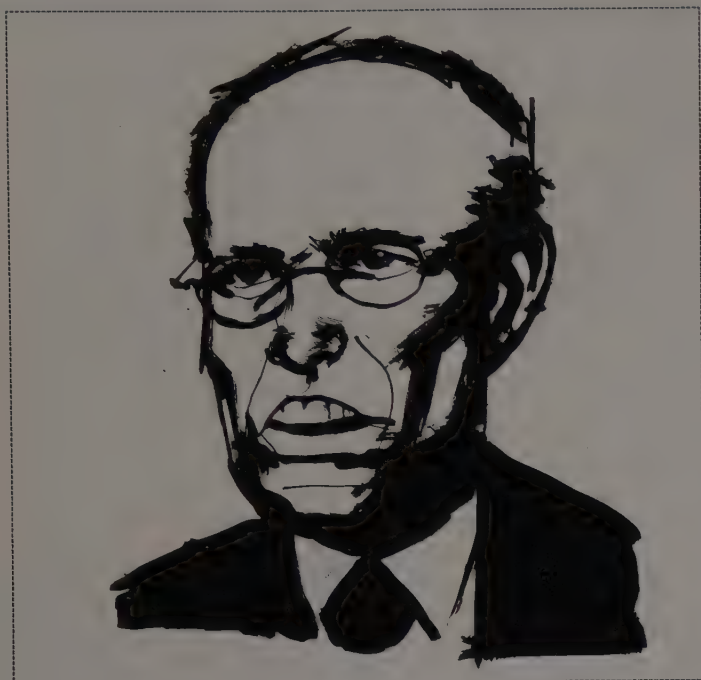
THE BRUSH STROKE

Like the crowquill, the brush is great for creating variance in line. The brush is also very effective for creating texture, and texture is yet another tool to help bring your drawing to life. A brush technique I find very effective is "dry brush." Dry brush can be achieved by dipping the brush in ink, wiping off the excess, and then creating strokes on the page. As the brush forms the stroke, the ink will "break," creating a texture. When working in black and white, dry brush creates a medium tone, which gives the image more depth.

This piece (below) is a good representation of using texture to convey an emotional state. It is done almost entirely in brush, which adds to its "rawness."



PORTRAITS



Portraits are fun and good exercises in capturing the likeness of your subject. Now, in addition to juggling the chores of line weight and shape, you have to capture the likeness of an individual.

The Rudy Giuliani piece is an interesting example of capturing a likeness. The image on the left was created first. It was a rough stab at getting his prominent features down. I actually like this version, but it was a bit extreme and probably would not pass muster with your typical mainstream editor or reader. I had to pull it back a ways. Once I got the basic likeness of the former mayor of New York down, I was able to produce a more refined portrait. In the final drawing, there is more line variance, with thinner

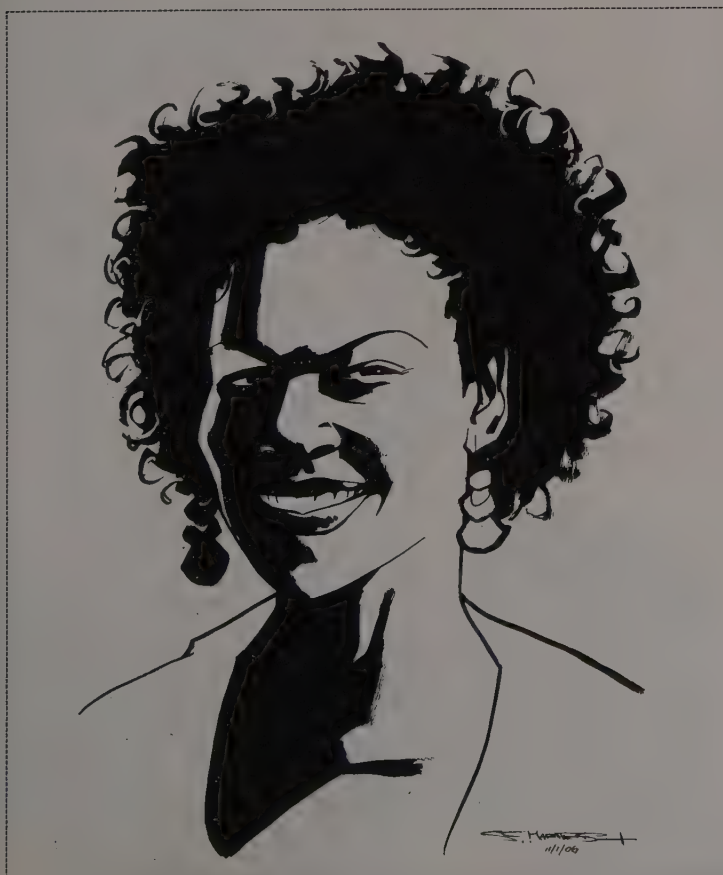
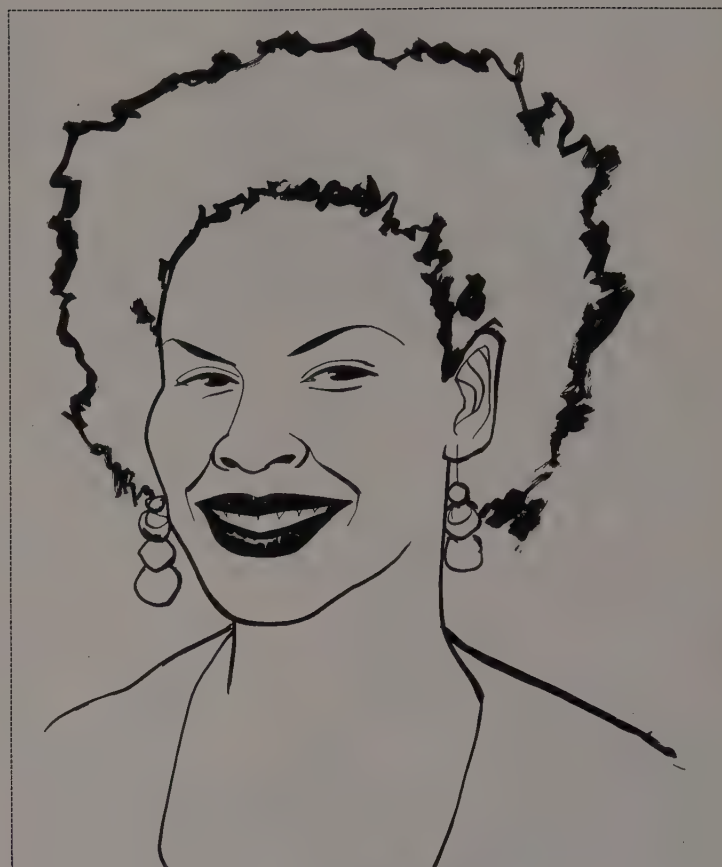


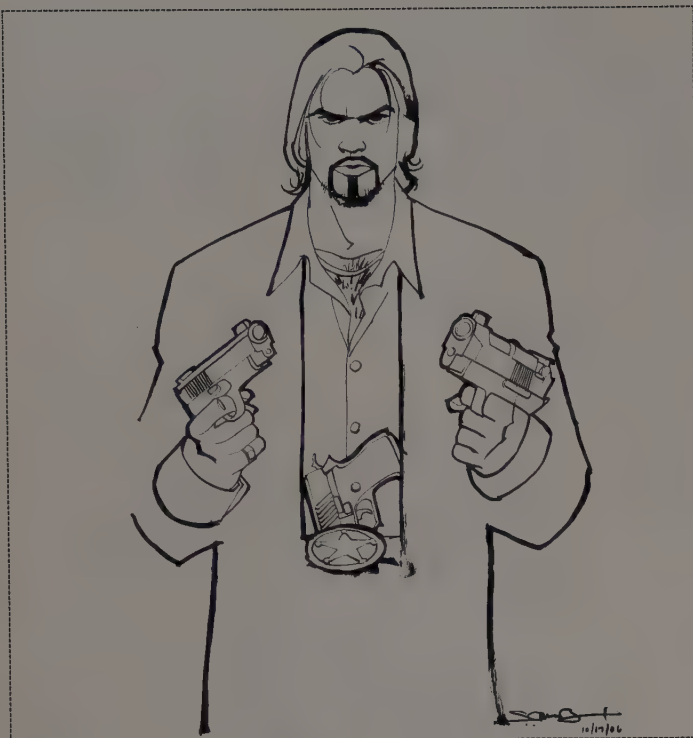
lines contrasting thicker strokes. I utilized the basics of contour drawing by using simple lines to describe the form. By changing the line weight and using a hint of brush stroke for his hair I was able to give the portrait more depth without overworking the drawing.

In these various portraits you can see the contour approach applied. In many cases one continuous line creates the basic shape of the face. A thicker line is used to establish weight, and thinner lines are added to create detail.

Sabriya

I used different tools for each one of these three studies: crowquill, brush, and marker. In the final (below), I combined brush and crowquill and really defined the form on her face by using shadow.





Victor

For the initial drawing (top), I used both brush and a crowquill. There are virtually no solid blacks on this form. Here the variance of line weight is very apparent, again contrasting the thin lines, which act as accents and detail, with thicker lines, which provide weight.

Angela

In this piece, I merged the thick and thin line technique with solid blacks. I even went a bit more graphic in my rendering of the brick wall, subtracting or losing lines that would complete a form. Why? More on that in the next chapter.



The Two Bushes

With the Bushes, I got a little tighter in my drawing, especially with George W. Bush's face.



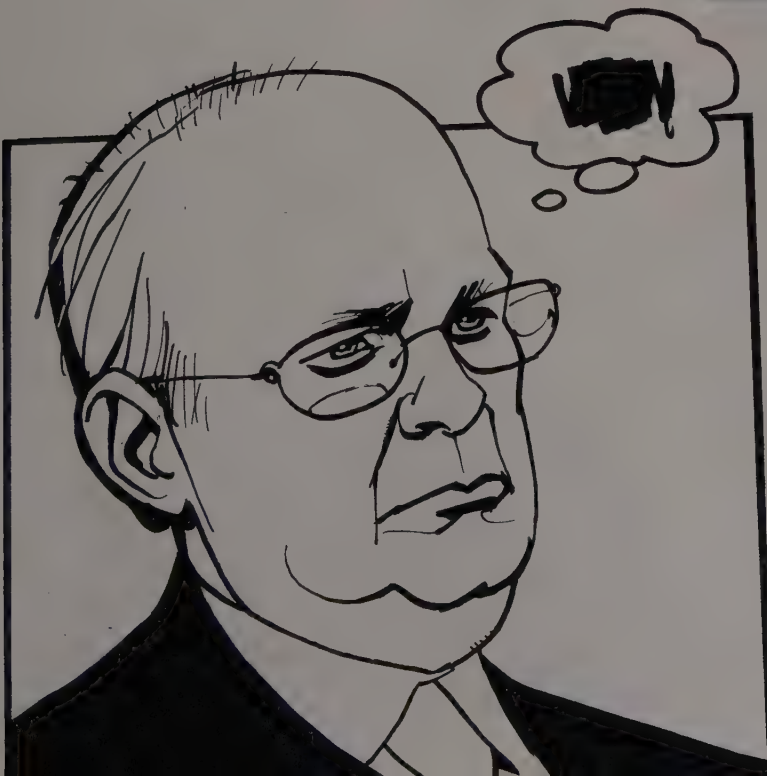
Donald Trump

A combination of simple contour lines and heavy brush strokes is used to create the distinct facial likeness and hairstyle of Donald Trump in this portrait.



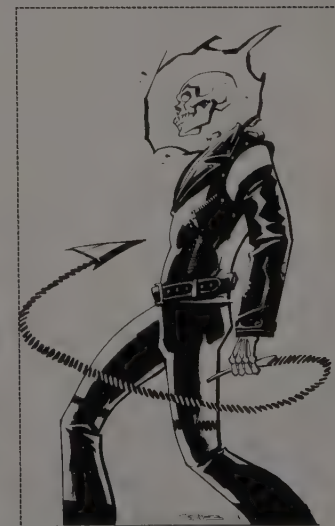
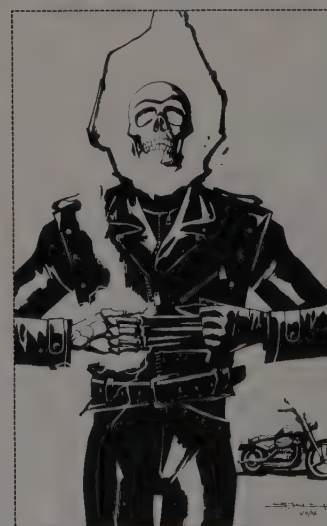
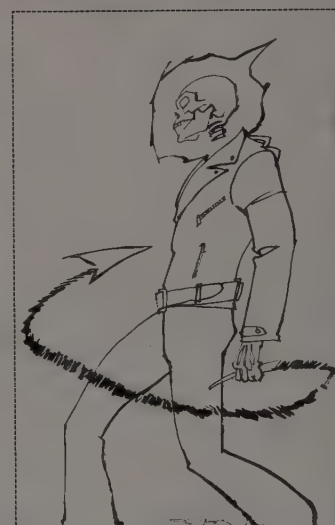
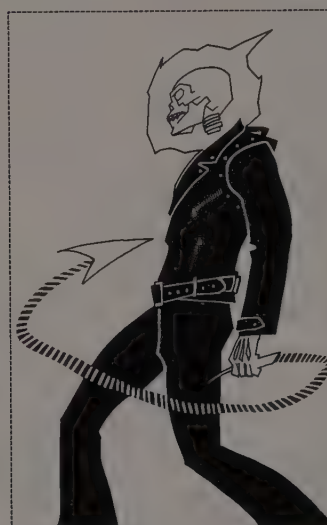
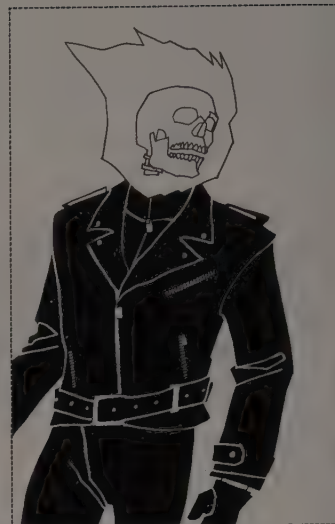
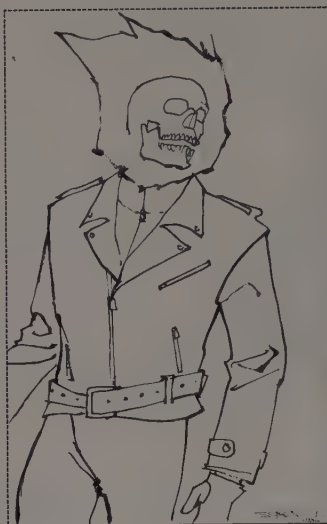
Karl Rove

This portrait of Rove relies more on the contour approach, since there are no shadows on his face, only varying line weight defining the form. I "broke the panel border," or extended his head beyond the panel frame, which is another technique that can be applied to the design of your panel layout.



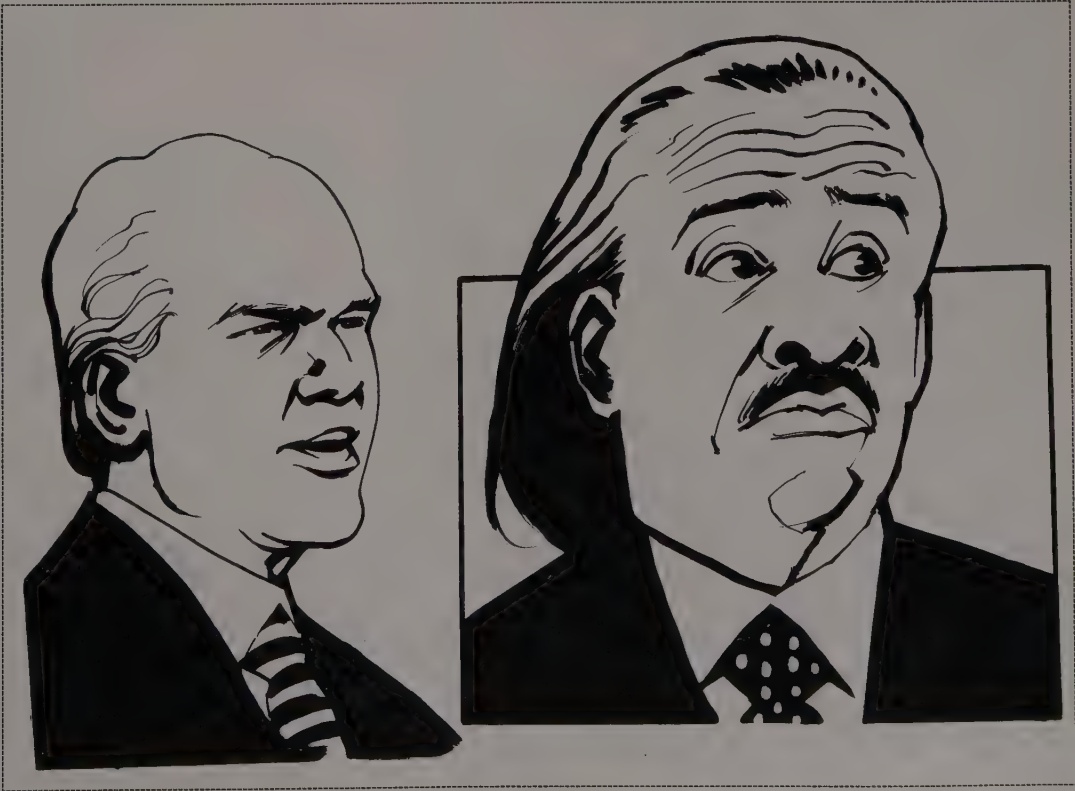
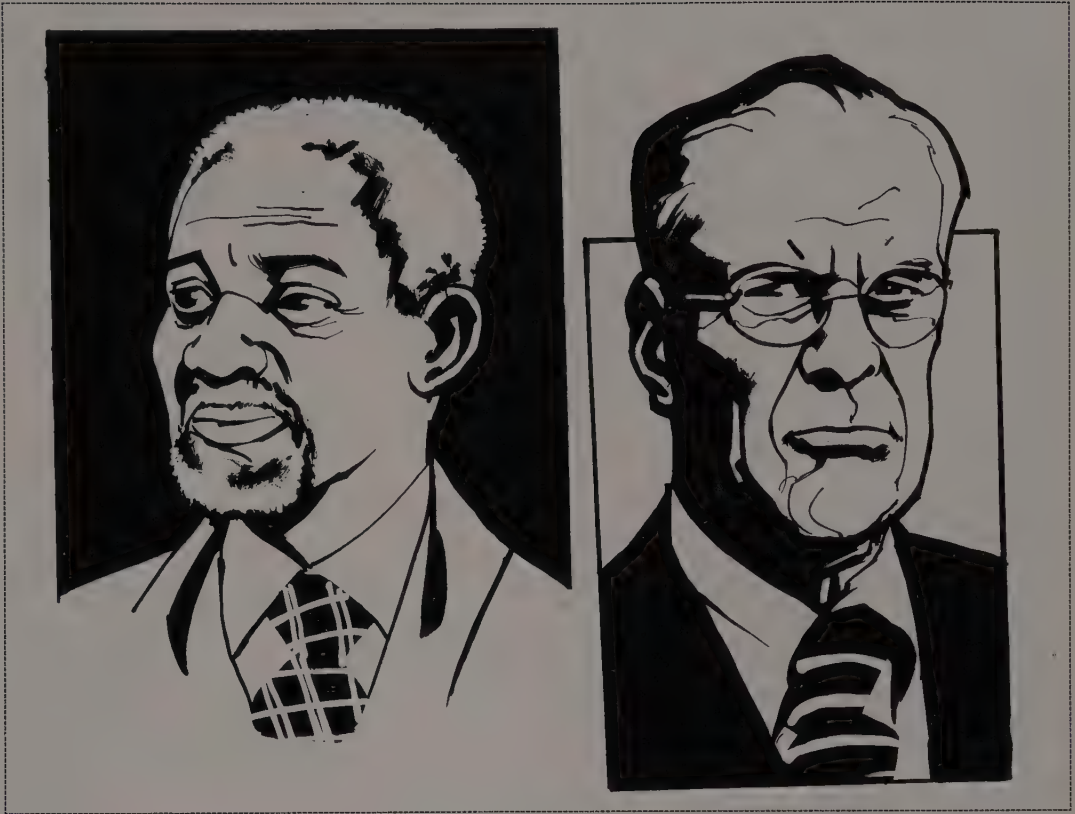
Ghost Rider

These are character design sketches I did of the Marvel character Ghost Rider. I was mainly playing around with capturing his gestures and the look and feel of his trademark flaming skull. I used brush for the flame and the texture of his leather outfit.





These portraits of (clockwise from top right) Donald Rumsfeld, Al Sharpton, Rush Limbaugh, Kofi Annan, and (above) Dr. Dre contain different techniques, such as dry brush and contour line.



TOTAL CONTROL

In the art world, collaborations between artists can yield spectacular results, but more often, the creative process is a singular one. Basically, as the artist, it is your creation and yours alone. However, in the comic book industry, the creation of a comic book can mirror a car assembly line.

First, the writer produces a script, the penciler gets the script and draws the page, and the inker gets the penciled page and inks over the pencil line, creating a black-and-white image. The letterer then adds all of the word balloons and captions to the inked image. Finally, the colorist colors the final image. During this entire process the editor tries to stay sane while keeping all of these people on schedule to meet the final production deadline.

I described the art portion of this assembly line as having two components: the penciler and the inker. Since creating a comic book is collaborative in nature, it is very common for two people to split the art chores. A penciler will create and draw the images, and the inker will ink over their pencil line, creating depth, weight, and shadow.

Many pencilers prefer to ink their own work, but since most comic books come out every thirty days, there is a monthly schedule to be adhered to. This makes the art of producing comics extremely time sensitive, so many editors prefer to split the art task between two people. Editors believe it speeds up the creative process, and often they are right.

As a penciler, having another person ink over your work can be very interesting and rewarding. Each inker has his or her own distinct style and can bring different qualities to your work, which may enhance the quality of your pencils. Really good inkers are pencilers in their own right. Point blank, they should know how to draw. Knowing how to draw will help an inker understand how to interpret a



Since there is no background in this piece, the emphasis is on the gesture of the figure. With a simple brush sketch (top), I try to capture the gesture of the subject. In the final version (above), I solidify the drawing with more refined lines, but I am always aware of creating contrast within the form itself, smooth line against rough, white against black, etc.



The use of negative space is key in this particular composition. By allowing the shadow areas to "bleed," or extend to the end of the page, I created a more graphic image. This gives the subject additional weight.



When designing characters, capturing their essence is the main goal. The viewer should be able to get a sense of the type of person that character is at first glance. Shadows can be effective in creating a sinister mystique. Here the details and folds of his suit are not relevant to defining his character, so they are left out.

figure or an object the penciler has drawn correctly and understand its form.

The downside to having someone else ink over your work is that many inkers cannot draw. As a result, their inks will degrade your drawing, because they do not understand the forms that they are inking. Also, some inkers do not respect the penciler's work, seeing it instead as a canvas to embellish. They will change the drawings and eliminate details that they might find tedious to ink over. I have been fortunate to work with very talented inkers, and I have also had the displeasure of seeing my work diminished by some bad ones.

Over time, I honed my skills so that I could pencil and ink my own work. I felt the best way to grow as an artist was to have total control of my artwork. Unfortunately, inking over one's own work is not as simple as just tracing the pencil line. It requires another level of thinking beyond just drawing. This extra thought process can eat up time, and it is hard for some pencilers to make the transition to thinking in black and white.

There are many artists who create amazing work when they ink their pencils. Unfortunately, this can slow down their productivity and cause them to miss their deadlines. The last thing you want in an industry as small as the comic book industry is a reputation for blowing deadlines.

On the flip side, when an artist pencils and inks the entire story, it can speed up the entire process and give the artwork a more organic appearance. Many editors prefer this approach. As the sole artist, you can simply suggest a background with a loose drawing or sketch and finish it in the inking stage. This can be applied to the drawing and layout of the entire page as well.

You can take more chances with your artwork when you both pencil and ink. Also, you have more freedom to grow.

Chapter 3

CREATING A MOOD WITH SHADOW AND LIGHT



A simple contour approach is used to establish line weight for the initial drawing (above).

The final piece (opposite) creates depth by applying detail selectively according to the different planes. The background is simple contour. The middle ground has the most visual information and form. The foreground is simple shadow, which allows the viewer's eye to focus on the other two areas.

The great draftsman and illustrator Alex Toth had a great philosophy, among many: "Only draw what you need to."

I thought this was an interesting concept, because when you first learn to draw, you draw what you like. When you are taught to draw by an instructor in an art class, however, you are taught to draw everything. It makes perfect sense: you learn how to draw by drawing every subject in front of you. As you progress in your drawing, your understanding of shape and form grows. You will understand that

when light is projected on a subject, the shadows are not arbitrary but are dictated by its form. Once you understand and can draw the entire form or figure, you can experiment with not drawing every line. You realize that it can be more interesting to suggest the form rather than spelling everything out.



THE POWER OF SUGGESTION

There are artists who are phenomenal that draw everything, and I mean everything. However, it has been my experience in life that a large percentage of people enjoy solving puzzles. They enjoy filling in the blanks.

This applies to art as well.

The impressionist period is such a respected and revolutionary period in art history for this very reason. The artists of that era suggested and implied the forms that they were painting. They did not finish every line or complete every form, which was the accepted style of painting. This form of suggestion can make the image more interesting, because that much more is left to the viewer's imagination.



A truly graphic noir approach is used here. Only the most necessary elements to describe a face are used in this portrait.



Here is a prime example of detail versus solid shape when describing a figure and, more important, conveying a message. In the version on the right, all the details of the figure are drawn in. Which piece do you find more striking as an image?

JUST THE FORM

In addition to creating compositions of black and white with a camera, practice drawing figures in silhouettes.

Do not draw details.

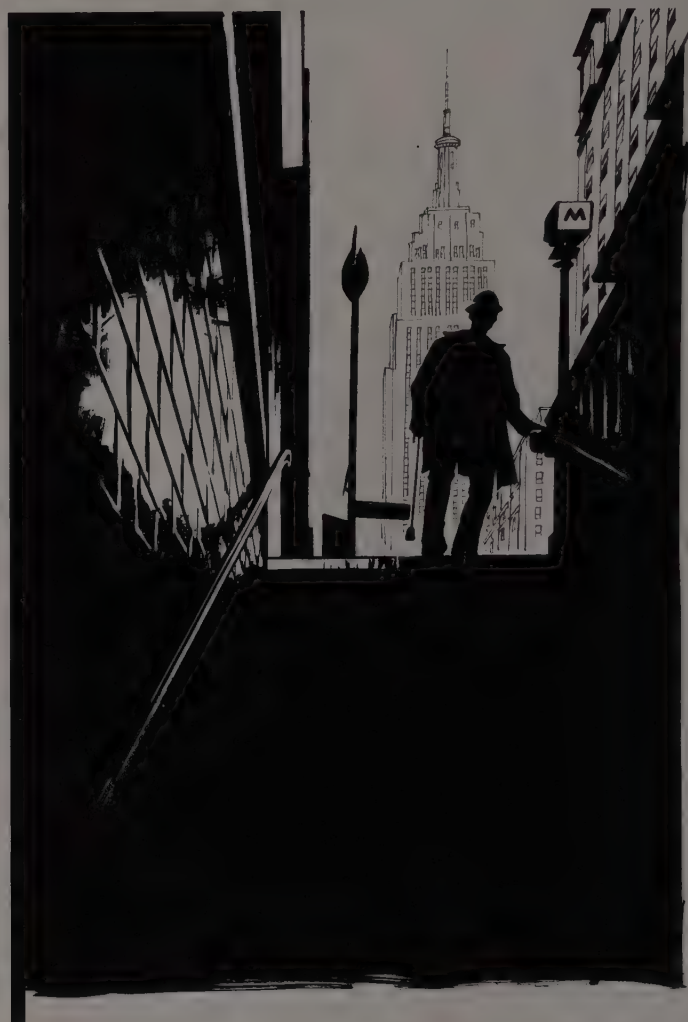
Do not draw facial features or folds in the clothing; just the shape of a person in complete black.

The only place you can apply detail is the background. Draw many studies like this.

In time, it will improve your awareness and sensitivity to shadow and light. You will focus less on detail and more on form. It will also force you to con-

sider the entire image as a composition instead of focusing on just the main subject.

Sometimes the form is more effective in telling a visual story than a detailed drawing. This is especially true if the subject is performing an act or gesture. The form itself will convey the gesture to the viewer, so by silhouetting the image you allow the focus to be placed squarely on that gesture.



In the final illustration (above), the use of a silhouette instantly creates an air of mystery and intrigue. Sometimes an image can have more impact with less detail. Here the areas of detail serve as accents to the primary focus—the figure at the top of the stairs. You can see how closely the final piece followed the initial sketch.

In the simple thumbnail (left), the basic composition is established. The areas of light and dark are sketched in with a simple precise pen and Sharpie marker.



Sometimes the story of the illustration can be told most powerfully in the forms of the figures. In this illustration, all the visual information the viewer needs to see is captured in the gesture of the forms. To break up the silhouette approach, the white of the man's shirt was highlighted. This also provides additional visual information for the viewer.

TEXTURE

Texture is a very important tool in creating a mood. It can be created very effectively in black and white. A dry-brush technique is great for creating the effect of smoke, which is a very moody element in a picture.

A shadowy figure smoking a cigarette is a textbook noir image. The unpredictability of the shape created by drifting smoke from a cigarette is captured well by the random patterns of a brush effect. Adding fine white lines will add more layers to the smoke, creating more realism in the image.

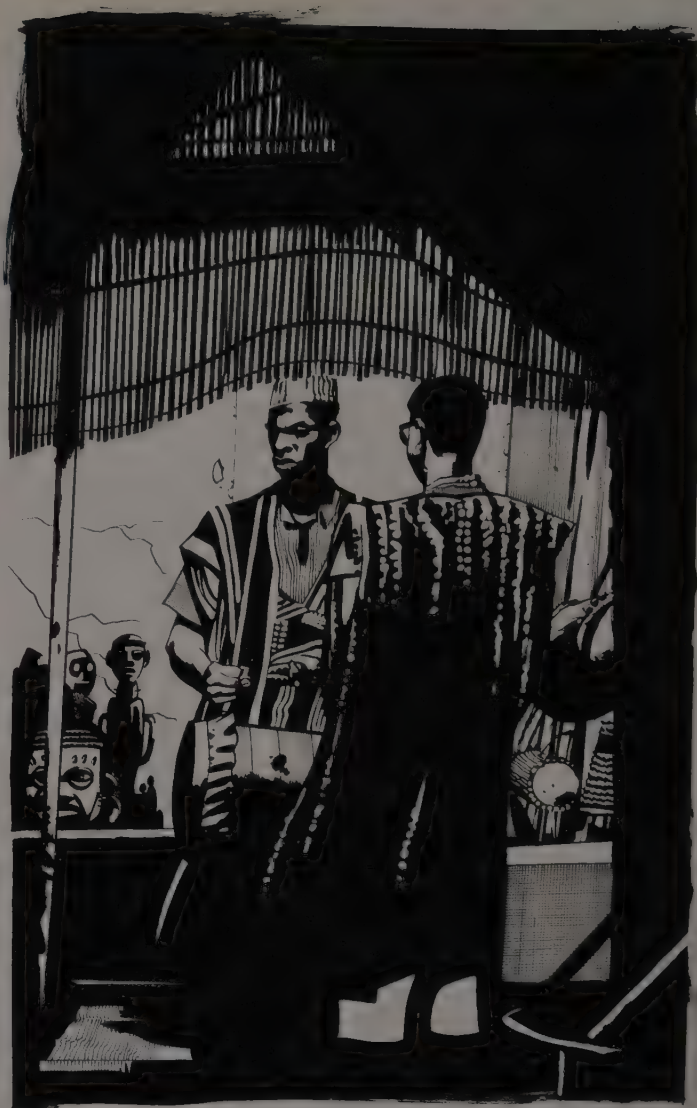
In addition to dry brush, texture can also be created by different types of line patterns. There are many to choose from. When working in black and white, a line pattern like cross-hatching or stripes will create a middle tone. If you squint, this middle tone will appear to be gray.

Now your image has three layers of contrast: black, white, and gray. This gives your image more depth.

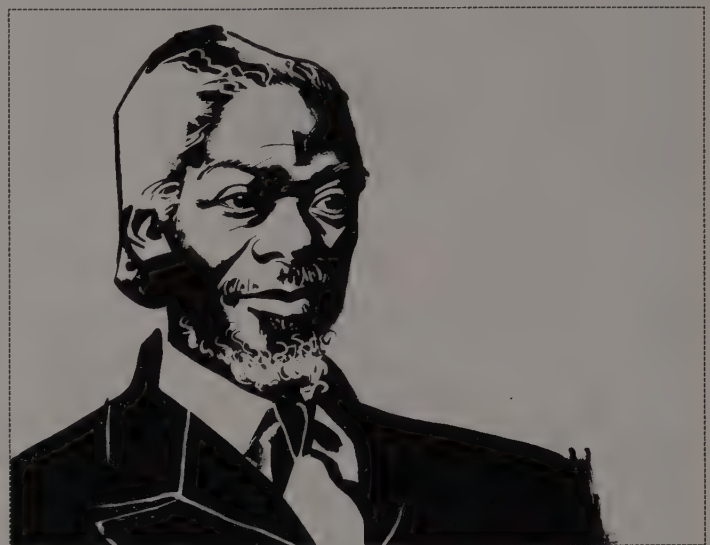
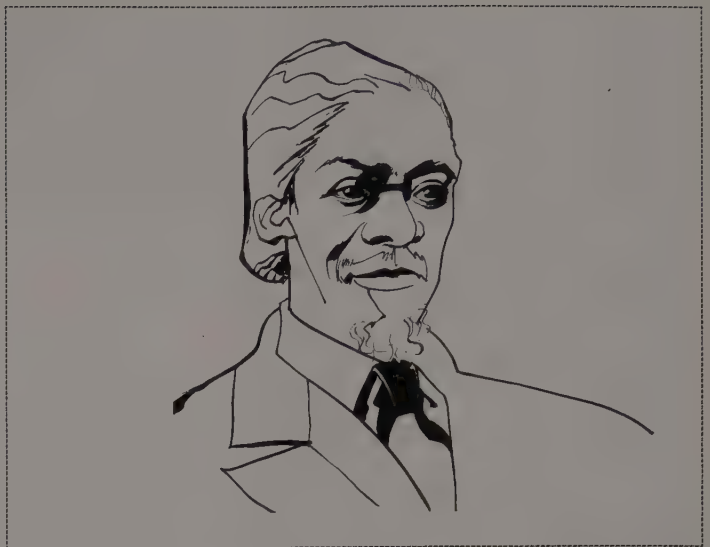
This gray tone can also be used to lower the brightness of a white object without knocking it into shadow.

This piece (top right) is a great example of using different textures and patterns. In addition to contrasting white and black, the use of different line patterns with varying thicknesses creates additional depth in the illustration. Also note the areas of thin line patterns on the forms that contrast against the solid areas of black. On the face in particular, extremely thin lines are used to accent the form against the solid shadows.

In this simple study (bottom right), white dry brush and thin brush lines were used to create the random, unpredictable shapes created by cigarette smoke against the solid black background.



Depicting cloth (below) can be very effective in creating a noir effect. The shadows of the folds create areas of black to be contrasted with white. The figure is also given more emotional weight by the heavy use of black. Her face is nearly enveloped by the high-contrast shadows.



Observe how the use of black creates a sense of richness and texture in these portraits (above).

THREE EXERCISES

AN EXERCISE IN DRAMATIC LIGHT

As an exercise in understanding light, close the blinds in your room and turn on a small light or flashlight. Grab a mirror and shine the light onto your face. As you move toward the light source, pay close attention to how the light strikes your face. Shift your head in different directions and study which areas are illuminated and in shadow. This will help you understand form and the different planes on your face. You can apply this type of dramatic lighting to any subject—a person, a car, a building, etc.—to see how much more interesting it appears. Keep in mind, however, that you cannot draw every scene with dramatic lighting unless the script takes place entirely indoors and at night. Dramatic light always makes a scene more intense, and the application of high-contrast black and white can add significant depth to an image.



Sometimes less is more. The silhouette of a young child holding a gun is more effective when the details of the figure are not added. The simple approach of presenting the foreground as a solid black and the background as a simple contour line immediately creates depth.

THE TWO-SHOT EXERCISE

Draw two figures talking to each other. They can be either gender and whatever ethnic or age group you choose.

However, one figure must be in the foreground and the other in the middle ground. Finally, create a background to establish the location and put the conversation in context.

This exercise will make you conscious of how the three planes—foreground, middle ground, and background—can be applied to the simplest action: a conversation.

Now establish a light source. The light can come from a lamp in the room, a window, a lit cigar—whatever you choose. Keep in mind that everything you draw in the image must be lit from that source. This exercise will make you conscious of keeping your light consistent.

Now add texture to the drawing. Unless your setting is in a futuristic holodeck with a smooth, clean esthetic and both of your characters are hairless, you can find and create texture everywhere.

In this exercise, you have just composed an image that forced you to be aware of:

- Composition
- Lighting
- Texture

Now repeat this over and over again, but create different compositions with different lighting each time.



Pay attention to how different line weights and shadows are added in each stage of this illustration (top two).

You can see the difference that shadows make when you compare the initial contour drawing to the finished version (above). In addition to creating more depth in the form of the figure, shadows also create drama. Eliminating areas of unnecessary detail by placing them in shadow or in black, such as the man's jacket or side profile of the head, draws the viewer's eye to more important elements, like faces.



Even a simple conversation between two characters can be made more dramatic with the addition of a strong light source.

THE LINE AND BRUSH EXERCISE

Trust me, you will appreciate it.

I want you to do a contour drawing now. This time pick a street scene, perhaps a set of buildings or rooftops.

Draw every single object in a contour line.

Pay careful attention to the details.

Do not shade or apply any solid black shapes.

Once you finish, make a photocopy of your drawing. Actually, make several.

Now, decide where your light is coming from.

If you are working from a photo taken for reference, the light source will be apparent. If you used a flash, well, you will have to make up a light source.

Take a brush and block in (fill in) with black ink all of the places that are in shadow. (I know, I know, you feel bad about covering up all of your nice line work, but that is why you took the time to make photocopies of your original drawing.)

Once you have finished, place the contour drawing next to the contour drawing with the shadows. Which one do you find more striking?

This is what we are trying to achieve with a noir style.



Buildings can look far more dramatic when part of their surface is cast in shadow. Being selective in which areas are lit can make cityscapes look more high contrast and noir (above and opposite top).





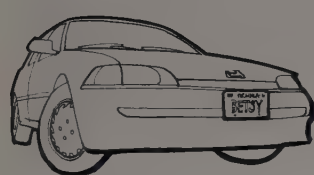
Observe how the addition of light and shadow can create depth even in a simple study (above).

NOIR CARS

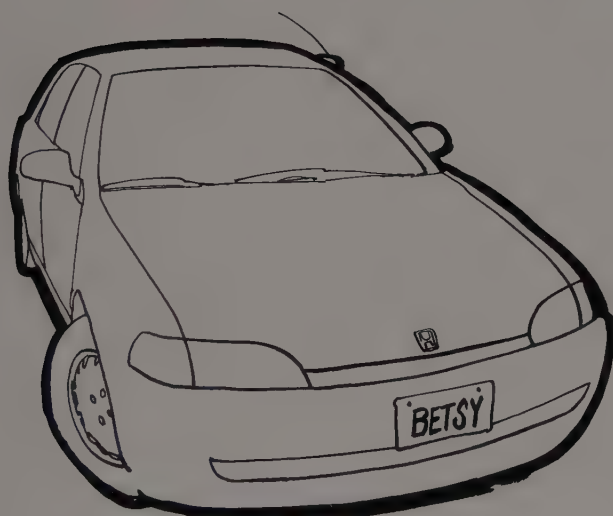
Cars can be intimidating to draw, and adding shadows to them can be a nightmare if you do not understand how to apply them.

Any metal object is reflective, so the shadows formed on cars are simply reflections of whatever is near it. These reflections will conform to the shape of the car.

Cars always look better with shadows on them. Next time you see a car, pay attention to what is causing the shadows.



SCHEIDT



Different objects react to light differently. Cars are made of a reflective material, so any shadows cast on them will come from other objects in the vicinity. Cars look sleek and sexy when shadows are applied to them.



SCHEIDT 10/25/06

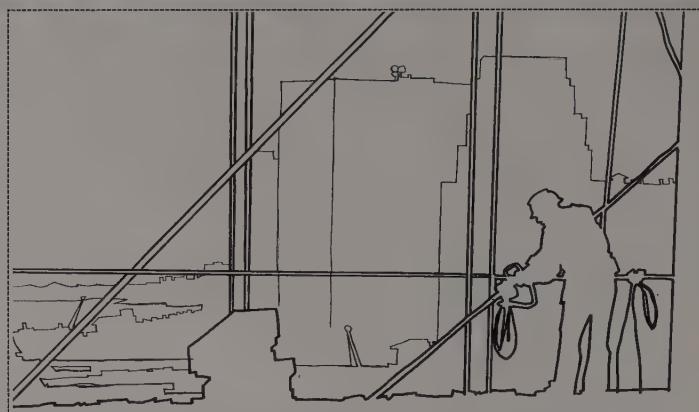
In this piece (opposite, top), the attention to composition is very important in conveying a mood and establishing scale. Even though the figure is in the foreground, he is dwarfed by the size of the background. By placing the figure in shadow, further attention is brought to the detail in the background.

THE IMPORTANCE OF MOOD

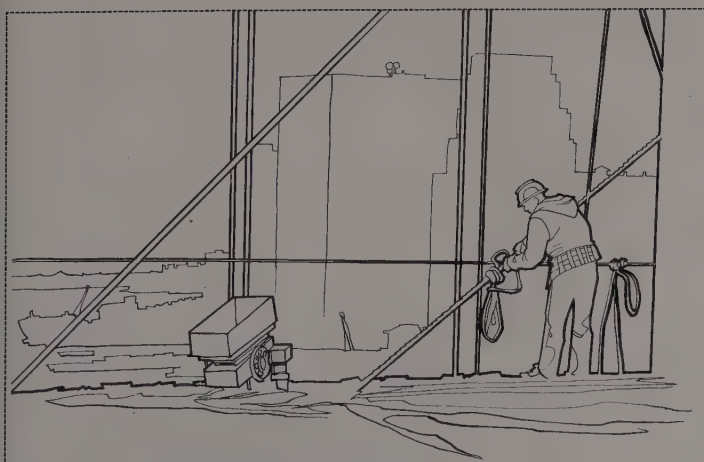


When watching films, I closely analyze the story-telling. The angles, the lighting, and the movement of the camera all work together to create a visual impact. To the amazement of my friends, I really like some of the worst, most cliché films simply because of how they are filmed.

Do not misunderstand me here, I love the classic films that are both beautiful and well written, but I am focusing on any film that creates a striking visual mood.



In the initial drawing, a contour approach is used to establish the shapes.



In this stage, detail is added to the foreground.



In the next, a silhouette approach is applied.

The same holds true for television shows. In 2000, there was a visual revolution in television with the creation of *CSI: Crime Scene Investigation*. This show brought moody, striking film visuals to the small screen. Since then, every new drama looks like a feature film. Audiences clearly responded to the noir style of these shows.

I believe readers respond strongly to comic books with a strong visual style as well. After all, the art is what pulls the reader in. The writer grabs them and keeps them coming back month after month.

Today, the average comic reader is between 25 to 50 years old. Many of these fans like myself grew up reading great stories drawn by amazing artists. Among the long list of artists that inspired me are Alex Toth, Neal Adams, Jose Luis Garcia Lopez,

John Byrne, George Perez, Michael Golden, Frank Miller, Walt Simonson, and Mike Mignola. Believe me, there are many more names on this list, but you get my point.

Despite their varied styles of drawing, all of these artists have one major thing in common: their work creates a mood. When you read one of their stories, it is evident that these artists are not only excellent draftsmen but are also dramatic storytellers.

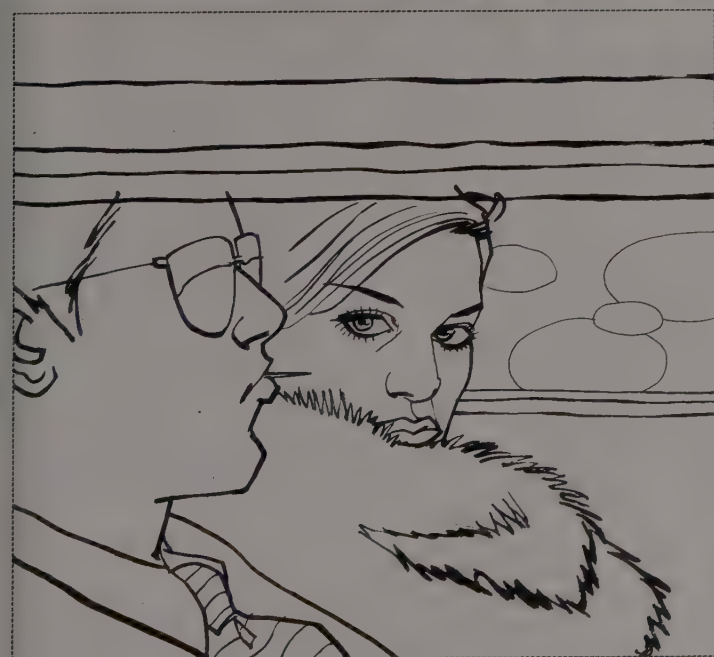
When you get a script, the first thing you should be thinking about is creating the mood of the story.

If you need inspiration, just read a story drawn by any of the greats I just listed.

I do.



Here is a prime example of detail versus solid shape when describing a figure and, more important, conveying a message. Which piece do you find more striking as an image?



This is a study that demonstrates combining different textures and techniques in a single image. If you compare the initial line drawing to the final, you can see how all of the black areas help draw the focus of the piece to the woman's face. Also, the proportions of this illustration closely match the widescreen quality of a film frame.

THE MAKING OF A GRAPHIC NOVEL: HIGH CONTRAST

I approached the story of *The Truce* as a smaller scale, noir-style story. As a result, every panel from a simple conversation to a violent display of action is a study in creating a high-contrast visual.

This wide shot from *The Truce* was designed to convey two things: the attitude and location of the main character. His importance is underscored in the second panel by the huge entourage that follows him across the street. The neon signs also add drama to the scene.



Lighting plays a critical role in highlighting the dialogue in this scene. All of the light falls on the figure of the woman, who is reacting to what is being said. In the third insert panel, the character is dramatically illuminated by the lighting of his cigar.



The final page of the story (below) combines light and shadow to create a dramatic climax.

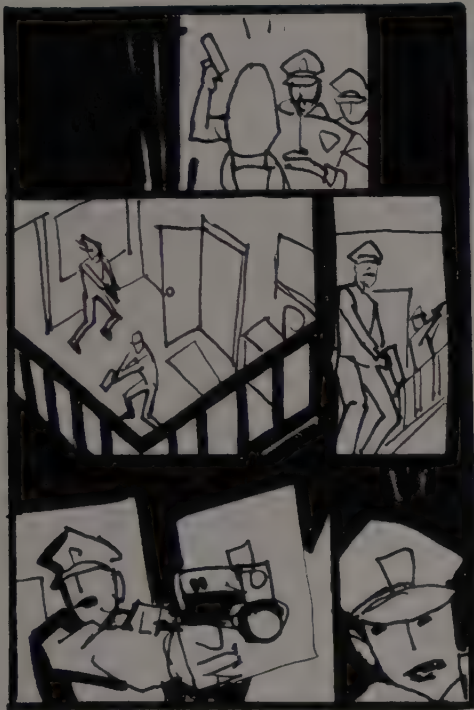


This is an example of only drawing what is important. The gesture and actions of these characters are more pronounced with no background behind them. It underscores the single line of dialogue to be inserted above them.



Chapter 4

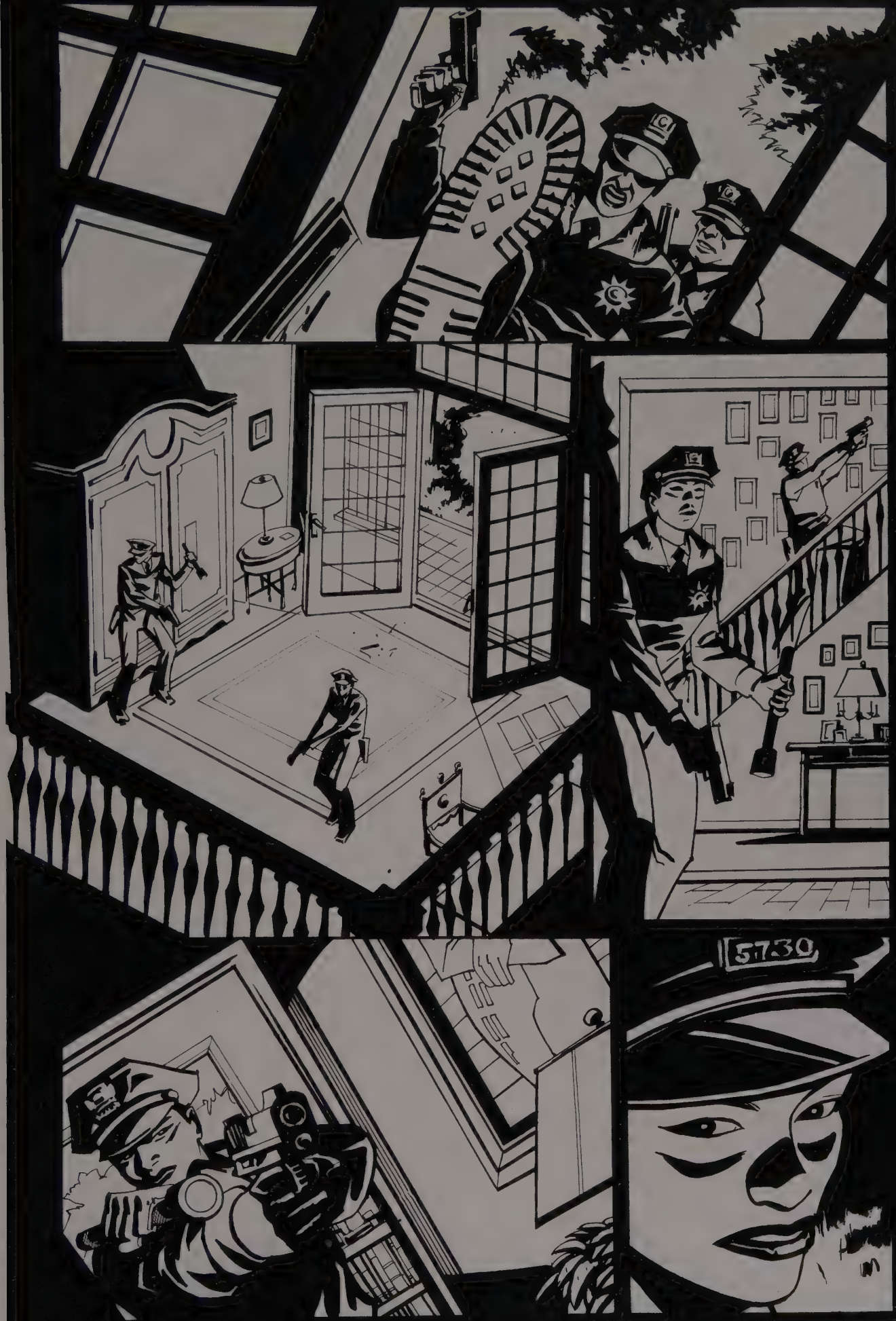
VISUALIZING THE SCRIPT



In this opening scene from *Angeltown* (opposite), different angles and dramatic lighting are used to heighten the intensity of the moment. In the initial page sketch (above), all of the angles have been visualized before proceeding to the final page.

Congratulations! You have been offered your first job in the comics industry! The first thing you will receive from your editor (this is your boss) is the script.

Keep in mind that the editor did not write the script; that is the writer's job. There are hundreds of writers in the comic book industry, and they write in various styles. For example, some write "simple." "Simple" writing to me is minimal yet effective dialogue with limited descriptions of the action from panel to panel. On the other end of the spectrum are the "wordy" writers. These writers tend to write a lot of dialogue for the characters and give very detailed descriptions of what is happening in each panel. Both of these approaches have their positives and negatives, and which type of writer you prefer really comes down to your preference as an artist. The minimal script approach leaves more room for artists to use their imaginations and interpret the script. The detailed script approach functions more like a blueprint for the artist to follow. In this case, there are fewer decisions to be made by the artist.



THE ARTIST/WRITER COLLABORATION

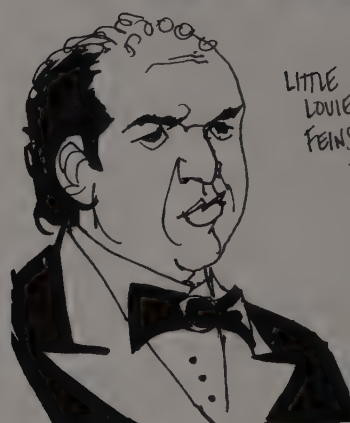
Typically, the more comfortable writers are with your skills as an artist, the more trusting they will be of your storytelling ability. They will not feel the need to be as comprehensive with their script. When you work from a detailed script, it really helps to work with a writer who is experienced in writing comics. Unfortunately, the art of writing comic books tends to be underestimated by many writers inside and outside of the industry. It truly is a collaborative medium, in which the give and take of both the writer and the artist is crucial. The writer needs to have a good understanding of what is possible to convey in a single panel or page. Sometimes a writer can ask for multiple pieces of action to occur in one panel, which might be impossible for the artist to execute. Or, while it may be possible for the artist to do so, it might not be as effective and will undermine the impact of the script.

At times, the artist must serve as an editor and make minor adjustments to the action as described in the script to make it more effective. However, it is always the artist's job to illustrate the script that he or she was commissioned to draw. I have heard many stories about artists changing a writer's script to fit their vision simply because they did not want to draw something or, to be honest, could not draw something.

This is not a good move, and, more important, it is not professional.

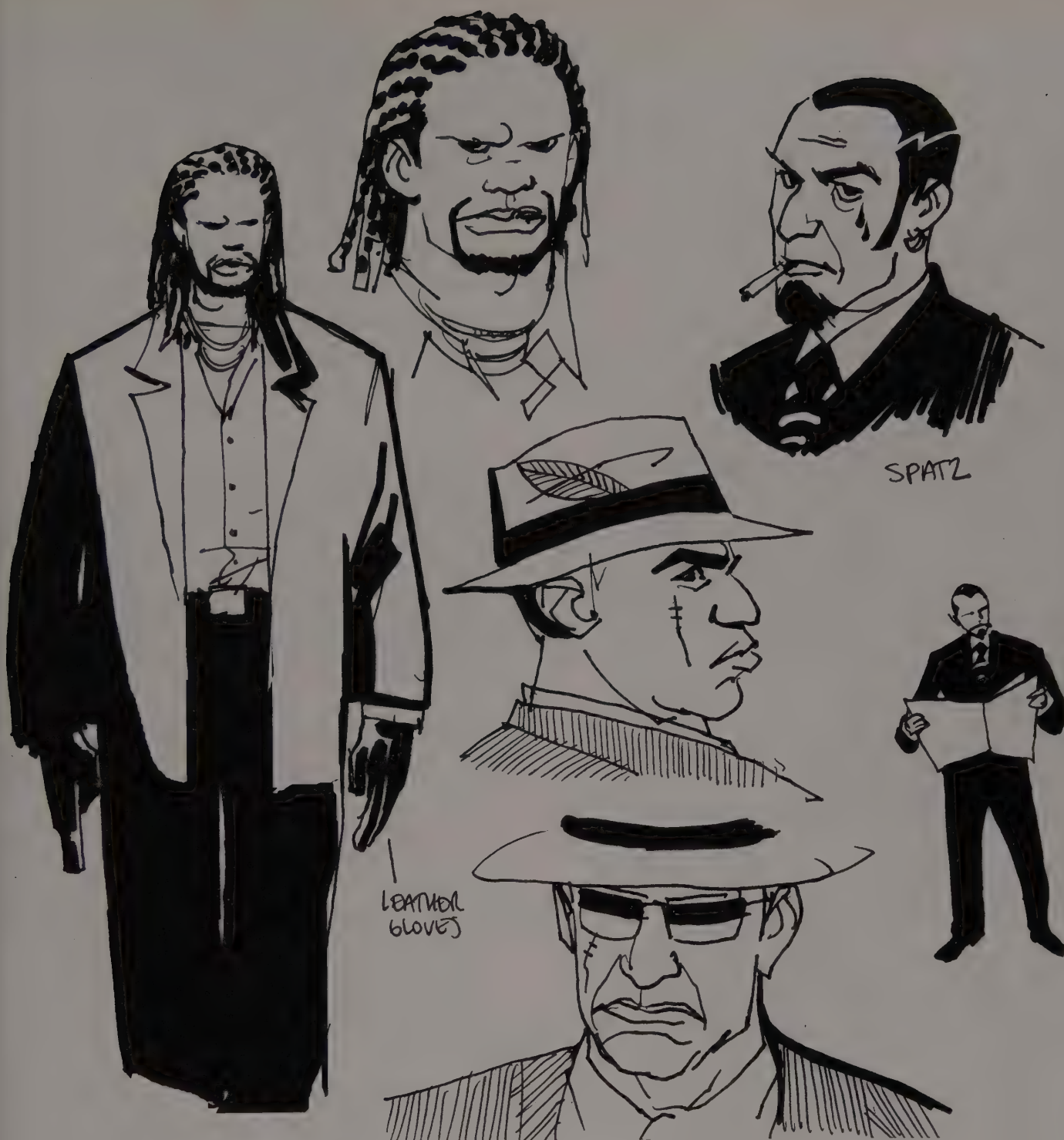
Every time I get a script and read it, I almost always have the same reaction. I look at a blank white art board and say to myself, "I don't know how I'm going to get out of this one."

There is nothing more intimidating than a blank page, especially when you have a deadline to



meet. Fortunately, you are not alone. You have the script to follow. This will be your blueprint for telling the story, but how you visualize it is up to you. Your job as an artist is to choose the most interesting yet appropriate images to tell the story that the writer has created.

I have always found it very similar to filmmaking. As the artist interpreting the script, you are the director. You choose the locations, the actors, the angles, and the lighting. There are numerous choices to make, and you can have lots of fun making them, but your main focus must be the storytelling. The storytelling always comes first. Making sure that the reader can effectively follow the story even if there is no dialogue or any words at all is the challenge.



When visualizing the script, the first thing you must do is visualize the characters. The script you receive should contain character notes and descriptions of the different characters in the story. If you are drawing a Batman story, you do not have to create a look for him. Many aspiring artists think when they are given the job to draw a Batman story, they will have the opportunity to give the caped crusader a makeover. Unfortunately, Batman, like all of the other superheroes we all know and love, has established

In these early character designs for *The Truce*, different looks with distinctive characteristics are explored for the main players in the script. All of the sketches use black and white to describe form and fashion (pp.54-56).



and, more important, approved designs that must be followed. You might be allowed to embellish on minor details like the flow of the cape and the style of the boot, but for the most part you have to stick to his established look. If you do not, chances are, your editor will ask you to re-draw the figure correctly.

Trust me, I have had to re-draw some really minor things, and it can be annoying.

So unless all the characters in your script are preexisting, such as Superman, Batman, or Static Shock, you will need to design all new characters.

USING REFERENCE

Unless you are blessed with having a photographic memory or a very detailed imagination, I recommend using photo reference when you draw. Using reference is very advantageous when creating original characters and designing locations.

To put it very simply, reference makes things look and feel more real.

When I read a script, I make notes based on the character description given to me by the writer. Then I will look through my reference file for photos that might fit the description. I recommend that all artists keep a reference file. I started my file back in high school. It contains categories like "Animals," "Men's fashion," "Stadiums," and "House interiors." Whenever I would see an interesting photo of a subject, I would tear it out of the magazine or newspaper and file it away. Over the years, my reference file has grown, and combined with my local public library, it has given me great resources to choose from. When I select reference photos, they must convey the look of what the writer has described.



DESIGNING CHARACTERS

After sifting through a pile of reference, I choose several pieces with similar styles and do a basic sketch of the character. Sometimes a friend or family member will have the right look, and I will use him or her as a model. I start with a head shot first. Next, I do a sketch of the character in his or her costume. Then I narrow all the various sketches down to one final look for the character. I will use the same approach when designing the “fashion” of a character.

It is always helpful to design characters from multiple angles, since you will be drawing them from more than one view. One of the benefits of doing portraits of people is that it teaches you to notice detail. Details make a character look more distinctive, less generic. There are artists in the industry whose characters all look the same except for eye and hair color. Chances are they are making these characters up from their imagination.

Drawing from life teaches you to observe the differences in faces and people. These differences will make your characters stand out to the reader and be distinguishable from other characters in the story. With each element of the character I design, I am constantly referring to the writer’s vision, which has been established in the script.

Based on the script, you might be required to design more fantastical characters. In these cases, you as the artist have more freedom to create a look. When you are tasked with creating a new look for a superhero, I recommend looking at real-life fashion designers for inspiration instead of previously established comic book heroes. Too often, artists will design outfits that might look cool but do not make much sense in terms of functionality. Also, you want to design a costume that not only looks cool but is easy to draw over and over and over again.

If I am working on a science-fiction-based



The above character designs, along with the drawings to follow, were for a proposed X-Men series that would revamp the classic X-Men adversary, The Hellfire Club, for a contemporary audience. Created by Chris Claremont and John Byrne, the original Hellfire Club was an older, aristocratic group of mutants who were the epitome of social elitism and dressed in turn-of-the-century fashions. In the new series, co-conceived by writer Joseph Phillip Illidge, the twenty-first-century Hellfire Club consisted of wealthy and ultra-trendy twentysomethings. Decadence and sexuality was factored into the design of every character. Note the use of black and white in each.



project, I always try to base my designs in some kind of reality. Books and magazines in the science and technology genre can be very helpful for this. As I said earlier, when compiling your photo reference file, a library card is a must. I will typically take out five or more library books for reference when I start a project. Just remember to return your books on time. Those late fees can add up so quick that in the end it might have been cheaper to for you to simply buy the book.



In addition to being in his twenties, the lead Hellfire character, Ethan Cabot (top left), was described as having a "vampire-like" mutant power. When I started to visualize his character, I chose a musician/rock star approach. Exposing his arms and chest added to his overt sexuality.

This Hellfire character, Lake Forrester (left), was written as possessing mutant powers, which were "emotional" in nature. After an initial sketch, a more conservative yet sexy look was designed for her.

These designs for Bellum (above), another Hellfire member, depict a very masculine and feral aesthetic. Fur, animal prints, leather, and a Mohawk hairstyle all add to his raw sexuality. This approach to visualizing Bellum really typifies the noir black-and-white style.





In this more refined Bellum design, (top left) a more graphic style is used.

The character of Rebecca Caldwell (left) was depicted in the script as being "Ethan's chosen." Taking this into consideration along with the description of her mutant power, a combination of rocker and socialite seemed to be the most effective character treatment. Her sexuality is also very evident.

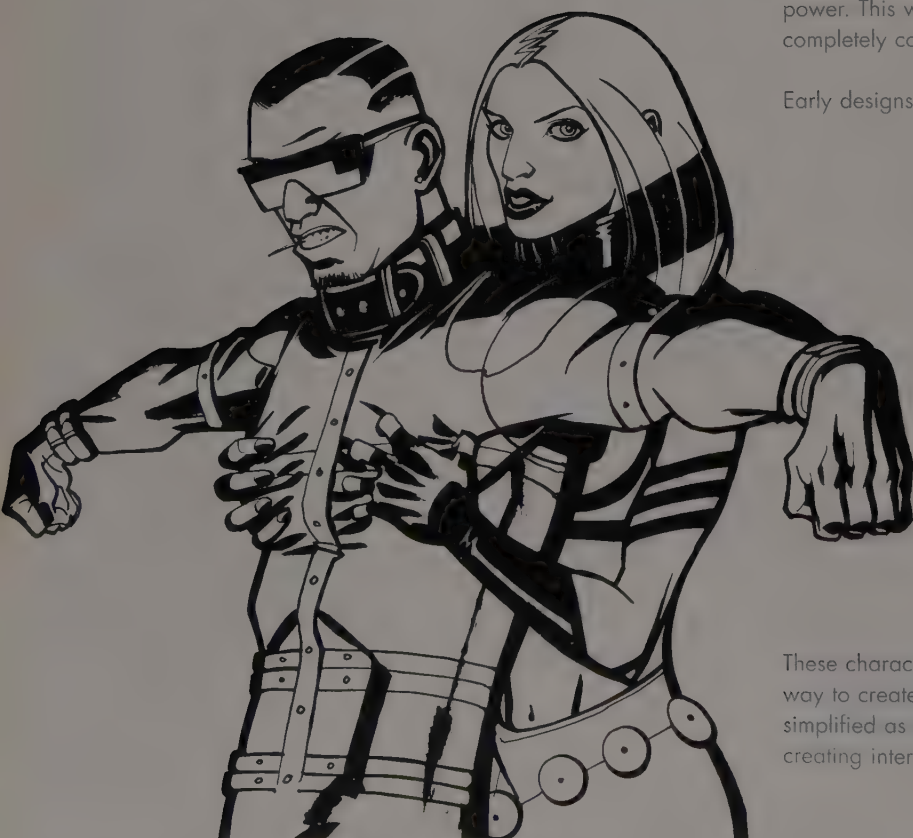
Jeffery Strand (above) was described as Ethan's second-in-command and a bit more cerebral. A more intellectual, simple, and conservative approach was taken when creating his design.



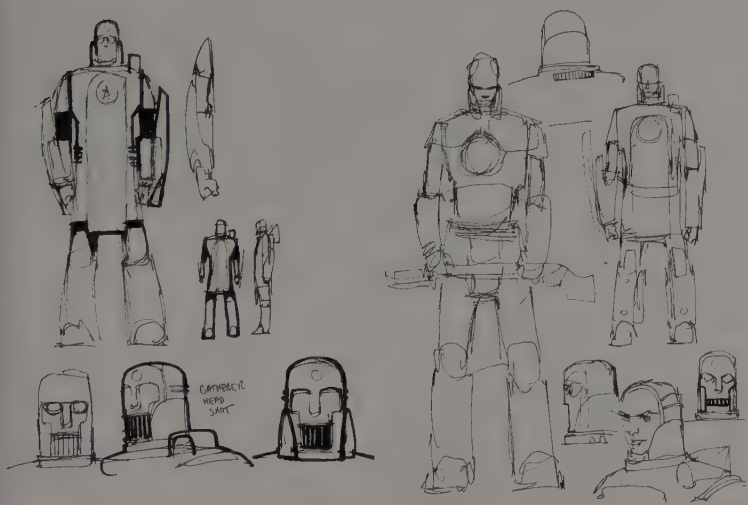
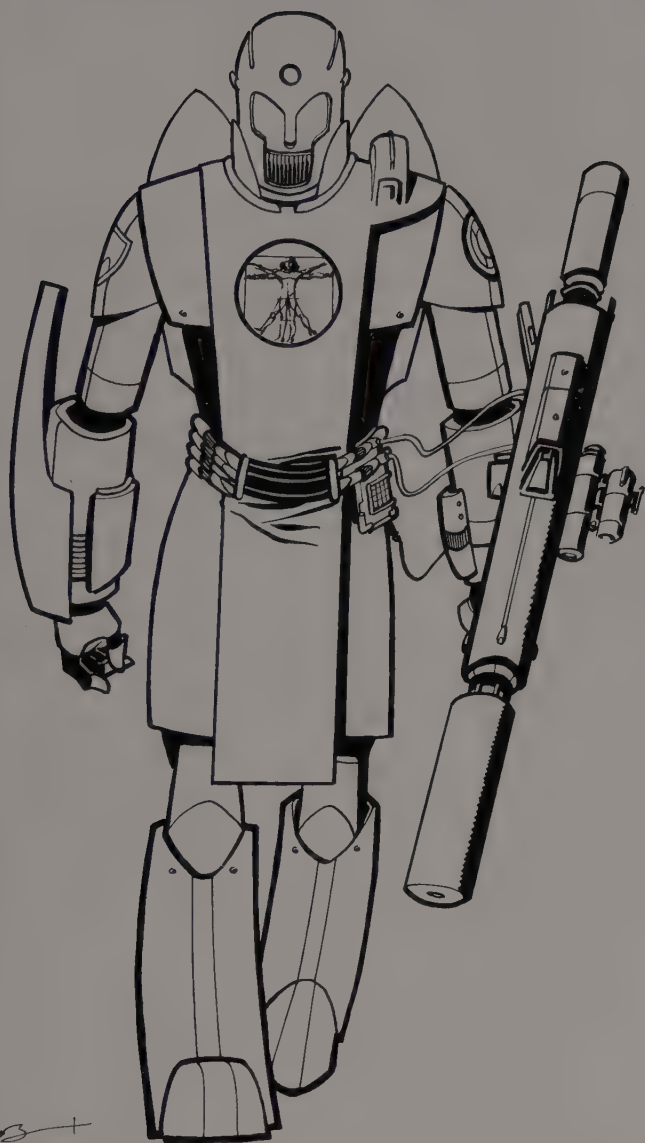
An early design of Bellum possessing long dreadlocks (top left) and a close-up character study of Jeffery Strand (left).

Sometimes a drawing showing a character "in character" is very effective (bottom left). The script described Orwell Keys as a mysophobe, someone with a fear of germs, which also tied into his mutant power. This was taken into account when designing his look of being completely covered in a skin-tight leather outfit.

Early designs for Orwell Keys (above).



These character designs (above) are approached in a more graphic way to create a specific mood. Many areas of potential detail are simplified as solid blacks and contrasting areas of light and dark, creating interesting designs that are easy to draw repeatedly.



In the script, the primary antagonist group was described as a militant, quasi-religious foundation dedicated to "collecting" mutants for experimentation. Their soldiers, which were called "Gatherers," were described as being cybernetic (far left).

This character design (above) from a short story written by Kevin McCarthy for Michael Chabon's *Escapist* series depicts a military soldier with an Asian influence. The design was an attempt to create a timeless yet intimidating look for the fashion of the character.

In the initial sketches (near left), the soldiers were designed to appear as if they were wearing sleek suits of armor.

In the final character drawing (top left), the details of the armor have been streamlined and the helmet design gives the impression of a skull.

DESIGNING LOCATIONS

In addition to creating the looks of the characters in the story, the script will also establish locations in which the action takes place.

For example, the script might say:

Panel 1: Sun rises over a cloudy Washington, DC.

Panel 2: Clay Bertrand leaves his office on Pennsylvania Avenue, NW, newspaper in hand.

Panel 3: With a hurried pace and constantly looking over his shoulder, Clay crosses a busy downtown intersection, narrowly avoiding several taxicabs.

Panel 4: Clay cautiously enters a small coffee shop on a side street.

Unless you live in on Capitol Hill, a section of Washington, DC, and have a photographic memory, you will need to assemble some photographic reference to make this scene look visually authentic. The Washington, DC, skyline; the design of the U.S. Capitol building; and an overall view of downtown, Northwest, DC will all be required to "sell" the reader on the location of this story. If the setting is a popular one like New York's Times Square, you as the artist will have less of an option to make up elements, since people will be very familiar with the locale.

This is where the library can be an asset. The Internet can also be very helpful in obtaining visual images. Sometimes you might be fortunate to work on a script that's set in your hometown. In that case, you can grab a digital camera and not only shoot your own reference but actually compose the appropriate

reference shots for your layouts.

Okay, now that you have your main elements, character designs, and location designs in place, the next step is to translate the panels described in the script into thumbnail sketches and layouts.



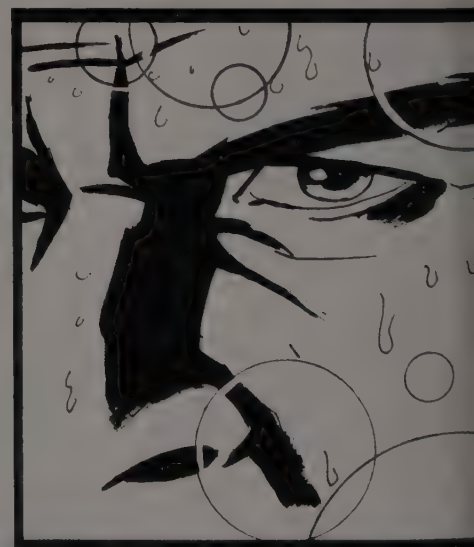


THE MAKING OF A GRAPHIC NOVEL: STORYTELLING

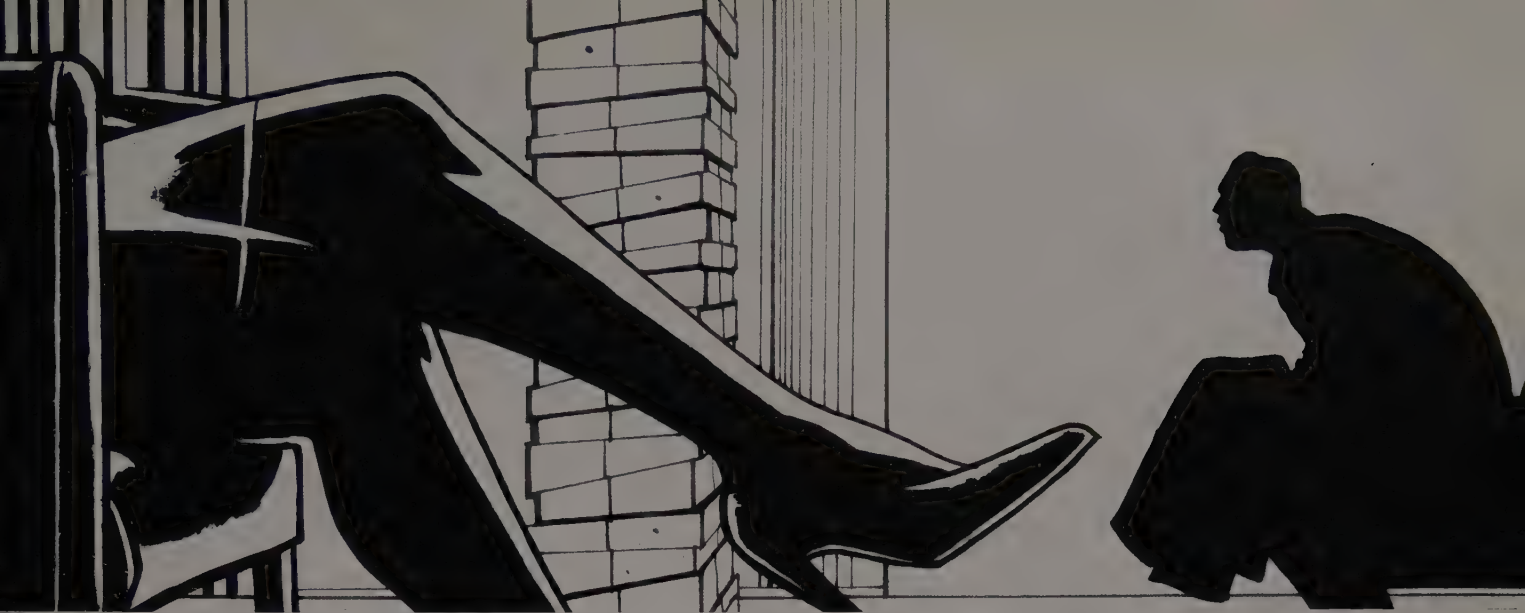
As an artist you must determine the "storytelling point" of every page you are given. In reading the script for *The Truce*, I found that a key emotional scene or dramatic action was emphasized on every page. This set the tone for how the remaining elements on the page were visualized.



This panel uses an inset panel technique to enhance the drama of the scene. The shoulder of the figure in the foreground creates an area of shadow in which to insert the next panel.



In the script, the character suffers an anxiety attack. Three panels, which are all the exact same size, are used to show this. However, within the panels, the angle moves in closer to the subject to heighten the intensity of the scene.



This panel uses a forced perspective to suggest the power of sexuality of one character over another. Note the size difference between the male figure in the background and the female legs in the foreground. When you understand the script you are illustrating, you can use design to further underscore what has been written.



When you visualize your script, always pay attention to how your characters make their entrance into the story. This should reflect the tone of how they are written.

PAGE LAYOUT



In this page from *Angeliown* (opposite), the use of wide angles/establishing shots conveys a sense of space and depth. Above, a quick panel study.

Here is where you must make a series of important decisions, and all of them depend on one thing: telling the story the best way possible. Let's say your story

starts off with two police officers investigating a break-in at a luxurious home in the middle of the night. Your mission: to convey this scene with as much drama and mood as possible. If the page is an action page, then your job is to create the most interesting action sequence you can. After you have read the script, the first thing you need to create is a layout.



THE THUMBNAIL SKETCH

One form of a layout is called a thumbnail sketch. A thumbnail sketch is a tiny loose drawing of what your final image will be. This is a quick method to get your ideas down on paper. I find thumbnails to be extremely helpful in regards to solving visual problems. Often my final pages end up being tighter and larger versions of my thumbnail sketches. Thumbnails are always used for my sequential art and commercial illustrations. I start my thumbnails in pen with a very simple line, and then I use a Sharpie marker to fill in the black areas. If I am working on a thumbnail of a comic book page, I break down all of the information on the script page. Once I have established everything in panel form, the revision process starts. Every panel is edited and revised down to the simplest, most effective way of conveying the action. Sometimes the action described in the script can be condensed or amplified by simplifying it. The angles you choose are very important.

Ever notice when you watch your favorite television drama or see a really great movie that the camera angles change? The angle might be shot from below or above the lead actor. Sometimes close-ups are used and so are long shots, as well as "establishing shots." An establishing shot shows where the action or scene is taking place. It focuses more on the location than the characters, which are usually very small in the frame. All of these and many other types of shots are in your arsenal when you create your comic book page layout, and it is good to use as many of them as you can.



In this page from *Angeltown*, each panel uses high-contrast lighting and dramatic angles to emphasize the intense climax of the story.

Note that the panel design and angles have been changed in the final page from the initial thumbnail layout for more effective and dramatic storytelling.



PANEL DESIGN

Panel design is another element that creates an interesting page layout. Good storytelling is good storytelling, so that will be evident in the most basic page design. However, good panel design can enhance good storytelling.

A popular page design in comics is what I call the "Big Head" layout. This design will focus on a dominant image of a character's head that takes up a large percentage of the page. In my opinion, this makes for a more interest-

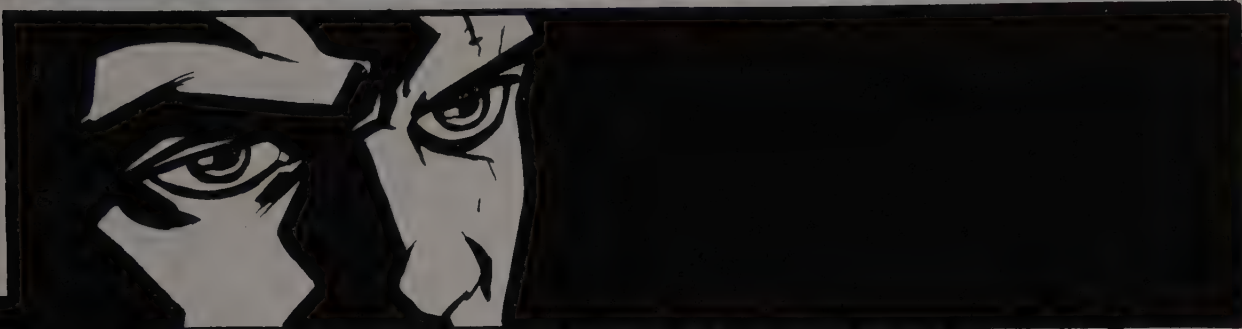
ing design rather than compressive storytelling.

Another interesting technique is panel "bleeding." This is a technique resulting in a panel with no borders, so the image "bleeds" or extends to the end of the page. It breaks the monotony of every panel being an enclosed box. It can also make that panel more dramatic by giving it more weight.



In this page from *The Losers* (opposite), the use of light and dark creates a feeling of mystery.

Even though the basic page design is followed from the thumbnail layout to the finished page, subtle changes have been made to the final drawing (right). Overlapping the middle panel with the first and allowing the last panel to "bleed" beyond the page borders makes the overall page design more interesting. Also note the varying perspectives and use of silhouettes to make the scene more dramatic.



PANEL SIZE

Panel size is another tool for telling the story. The more important and dramatic action should be given a larger panel size. Typically the writer will request a particular panel size in the script—for example, “Panel 2, large panel”—but as a storyteller you should be able to determine which panels are the most important. A basic concept you should use when designing your panels is to “guide the viewer’s eye.” In the United States and in other parts of the world we read from left to right, so your primary goal is to advance the viewer’s eye from left to right as well. Every gesture your character makes, every direction they look, every direction a car drives, every direction a character runs should be designed to lead the viewer to the next panel.



From *The Losers* #8 © 2004 DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



In these pages from *The Losers* (left) and *The Morlocks* (above), written by Geoff Jones, one large panel is used to convey a powerful image or scene.

SPOTTING BLACKS

Once you edit your layouts to maximize the best storytelling possible, the next step is to “spot your blacks.” “Spotting your blacks” is an industry term that refers to deciding what areas in the panel or on the page will be in black. I find it very helpful to establish lighting in my thumbnails. In addition to making it easier once I start drawing the final page, it also allows me to edit my page layout once again before I move to the final drawing.



In the opening scene from *The Seekers*, written by Kevin McCarthy, light and shadow were used to create a serious and dramatic mood. Observe how two elements of action were designed to take place in panels 2 and 3. The camera moves closer to the figure at the work table as the silhouette in the background to the right advances. Note how the areas of black and white are established in the initial thumbnail layout.

When you choose where to apply the blacks on the page, you are also given another opportunity to decide to draw what you need.

By knocking things into shadow, you add more depth and create drama in your work. When you silhouette an object, you emphasize the rest of the information and detail in the panel. You also draw focus to what is really important in the frame. Detail is great and can, at times, be impressive to look at in a panel, but it can also distract. There have been many times that I have spent hours drawing some detailed element only to realize it would be more interesting to make it a solid black shape. As an artist, you constantly have to keep editing yourself to tell the best story possible, especially in the thumbnail/layout stage. Trust me, it will solve many of your problems before you start drawing.

THOSE DAMN WORD BALLOONS

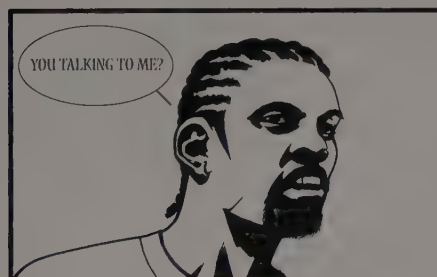
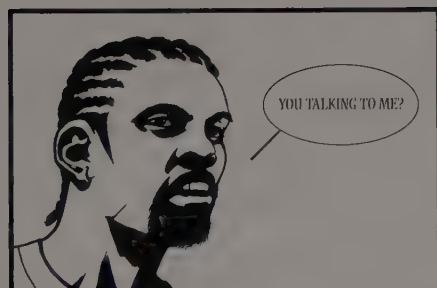
Another element you must consider when you design your panel and page layout is the dialogue. On a comic book page, dialogue is presented in "word balloons" and "caption boxes." When a character speaks, the word balloons are used. When a character thinks, a caption box is used. Caption boxes are also used for exposition. When you compose the images in your panels, you need to leave room, or "negative space," for the words. Negative space is usually vital to any composition if it is created at all.

It is also space in which you would not mind having to place a word balloon or caption.

The word-balloon factor will be very easy or difficult depending on the script that you are illustrating. If there is a lot of dialogue it makes it harder for the artist to leave room in a panel, especially if there are more than four to five panels on the page.

In the old days of comics, the letterer would actually glue the balloons and captions onto the original art. These days lettering is added digitally on a separate layer so your original artwork is returned to you untouched. However, if you spend the time drawing it, you want the drawing to be seen. Remember that panel you spent hours drawing with all of the detail? If you did not leave enough room for the word balloons, chances are that much of it will be covered up. The dialogue is very important, and I can't recall a time when an editor had a writer revise a script because the artist did not leave enough room for the words.

Plan ahead!



MAKING A SPLASH

Nothing beats a splash page for making a strong visual impact on a reader. A splash page is one large panel that takes up the entire page. It is a huge image that should be designed to convey intense action, the scale of a location, or both. When I illustrated this interior of the Batcave, its new redesign had not been clearly shown in the Batman titles. Drawing the different levels, establishing the architecture, and capturing the feel of the Batcave was all done to impress the reader with scale.

Typically, splash pages are not too common in your average comic book story. Splashes look great and make for great single-page illustrations, but they can make telling a story difficult for the writer. Keep in mind, splash pages are designed to emphasize a visual, so word balloons and captions are usually kept to minimum. A splash page means one less full page of text the writer can use to tell the story. In the grand scheme of telling the story, splash pages are usually reserved for key moments. Many times they are saved for the credits page, which is usually the third or fourth page. More often they are used for the last page, with the intention of leaving the reader with a dramatic visual as a cliffhanger until they buy the next issue.

The more splash pages are used in a story, the less of an impact they tend to have.

Sometimes double-page splashes are used. This is one full image extended to two full pages. The same challenges to the writer apply; however, double-page splashes often have several smaller panels incorporated into the design to tell more story.



USING A BLACK BORDER

Using black borders on panels can be a very interesting visual technique. When spotting the blacks on page layout, fill in all of the white area outside the panels with black. This immediately adds an emotional weight to the page.

However, it does add another challenge when designing the lighting schemes within the interior panels. When applying a noir style, your goal is to contrast dark against light. Now you have to create that contrast and be mindful of the constant black border. Any solid black shape inside the panel will bleed into the black border. In essence, the only border on your page is created by the white areas inside the panels. Again, black borders can be very effective in creating drama on your storytelling page, but you must plan ahead when using this technique. It can become very overwhelming.

The use of negative space is very effective in several panels in this page (right) from the miniseries *Angeltown*.

From *Angeltown* #2 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.

This illustration (above) from *Detective Comics* is an example of an effective splash page. The entire page is used to show the expanse of the Batcave.

From *Detective Comics* #761 © 2001 DC Comics. BATMOBILE™ DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



BACKGROUNDS

Backgrounds are a key element to telling a story. For some artists, they are not fun to draw. In fact, drawing backgrounds can be a downright chore, which explains why many artists do not draw them. Ever notice on a comic page that some panels have a character in complete darkness? Or in a cloud of smoke? How about a series of abstract brushstrokes behind a character's head? Sometimes these background visuals can be very effective. Typically, though, the artist will just use them as filler instead of drawing a real background.

When we first learn to draw, we start with a figure or a person. I grew up reading comic books, so I began drawing comic book superheroes. Heroes are the fun part of drawing a comic. After all, who wants to draw boring inanimate things like buildings, hallways, bedrooms, and kitchen appliances? Those are not cool or sexy.

The truth is, you need to draw backgrounds, because they are almost, if not equally, as important as your star characters. Backgrounds establish where your character is in the story, for location is everything.

Imagine if you drew an incredible shot of Superman flying through the air and catching a construction worker who has fallen off of scaffolding on the fifty-fifth floor of the Empire State Building. Now imagine just drawing Superman flying through the air and catching a construction worker and drawing nothing else. Are you missing something? The element

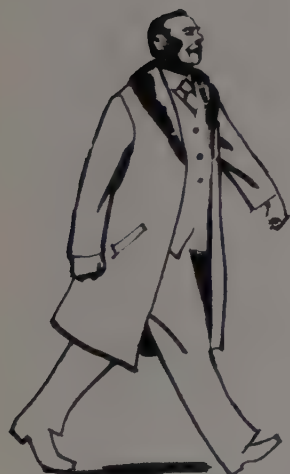
lacking here is context.

The image of Superman's heroic feat would not be as spectacular if you could not see how high the worker is. The Empire State Building and all of the surrounding buildings put the level of danger that the worker was in into context. Think of the background as another major character in the script that you need to draw.

Before I started in the comic book industry, I tricked myself into drawing backgrounds. I developed my understanding of perspective by drawing buildings and cars. I began to take an interest in the various architecture and details of different buildings and homes. After a while, drawing backgrounds became just as interesting to me as drawing the main characters.

When you tell sequential stories, backgrounds are half the battle. There are a number of artists in the comic book industry who do not regularly draw backgrounds and are very popular and successful. However, the comics that are acclaimed and considered classics always contain not only incredible character drawings but amazing backgrounds as well.

Backgrounds are very important in telling a story. See the difference between just drawing the figures versus drawing the figures in an environment?







When visualizing a script, the environments are just as important as the figures. Imagine these panels without their back-grounds.

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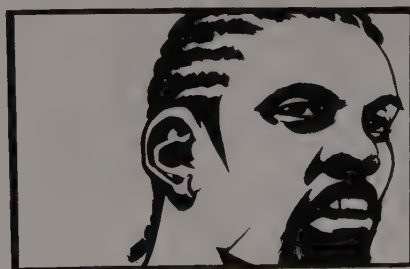
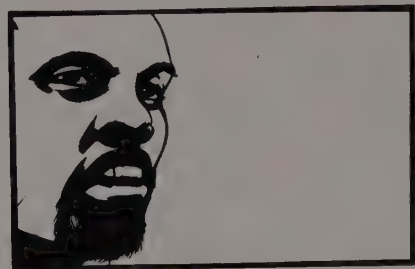
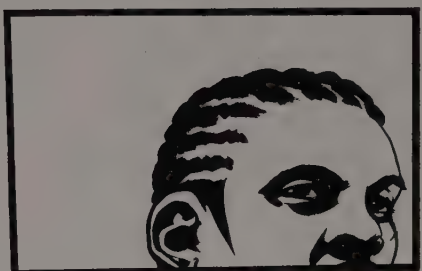
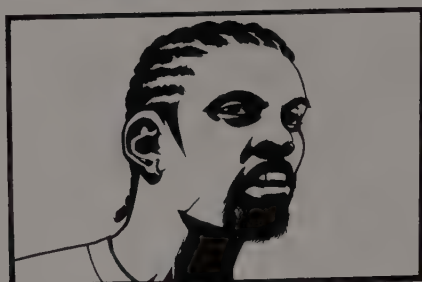
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FRAMING THE FIGURE

How you choose to position your characters in the panel can really enhance a scene. Certain angles will make your character look more heroic or more tragic and larger-than-life. For example, in film, the tendency is shoot a lead actor from below. This forces the viewer to physically, and more important, psychologically look up to the character, creating a subtle visual "nobility." When used in a close-up, this is especially effective. This same approach applies to graphic novel images.

Conversely, if you draw an angle that is looking down at a character, it can make him look smaller in stature. Also, the smaller you draw a character in contrast to his background location, the more diminutive you will cause him to look in comparison.

Once again you have a lot of options to choose from. Remember, you also need to incorporate the word balloons and/or caption boxes into the panel design as well.



Here are some different examples of framing and cropping the figure.



CROPPING THE FIGURE

The term *cropping* refers to when a portion of the subject is cut off by the frame of the panel. You can depict characters in different ways by cropping them. Here are examples of different ways to crop a figure in a panel.

You can see how each panel conveys the character in a different way. In some frames the lower part of the character's face is cropped, revealing only his eyes.

In another frame, his eyes are cropped, which draw the focus to his mouth.

By positioning the subject to one side of the frame, you allow more negative space to be used for the background. Framing the character "off center" can also make the composition more interesting than simply positioning him in the middle of the panel. When you center a subject you draw all of the focus to him. This can create an interesting effect, because the perspective, which affects all background and foreground elements, will help draw everything to the subject. Personally, though, I find it more visually interesting to position subjects off center.

My work is often described as film-like. This is understandable, since one of the major influences on my work is film, and many of my panels are designed to resemble film frames. I typically prefer horizontal frames to vertical ones. Horizontal frames are basically rectangular in nature and allow for more background information. They also allow for more sweeping action within the panel.

Once again the freedom to choose the panels you prefer is contingent on your script. If the writer specifies seven panels, you cannot illustrate them all as horizontal panels and tell the story effectively. When I am given a set number of panels to draw, I improvise and save the horizontal panel for a key moment.



The aim of this scene from *The Seekers* was to establish one of the main characters as being very intellectual and having an overbearing sister. In the thumbnails, a view from above was chosen, which would best show the character in his environment. Panels 2 and 3 use cropping to establish and focus on the personalities and interaction of the two subjects.

THE MAKING OF A GRAPHIC NOVEL: PAGE AND PANEL DESIGN

Since the script for *The Truce* largely focused on characters talking, page layout became especially important in creating an interesting scene. In addition to high-contrast noir lighting, different types of page and panel design were used to make the story as visually stimulating as possible.





The panel design is very important for these pages (above and opposite). Each of the panels depicting the violent ends of the characters above is equal in size and is followed by a close-up of the female character's eyes, punctuating her role in what has just happened in the story. Similarly, on the opposite page, the figure of the woman is placed fairly far back but is followed by a close-up of her face, confirming her dominance in the scene.



The design of this page (above) plays a crucial role. Not only does it establish key characters in the story, it also provides visual information about the relationship between the two main characters, Evelyn and Max. Despite the number of panels, the design still allows for the placement of word balloons.



When the two main characters meet for the first time in the story, this panel uses negative space and perspective to underscore a sense of Max's highly developed attitude.

Chapter 6

STAGING ACTION

This page from *The Escapist* shows how overlapping panel design can mirror the movement of the character.

I said earlier that storytelling in film is a great inspiration for me. I study action sequences in films very closely.

Film is made up of a series of still frames that when linked together create a moving image. A stretch of uncut action is called a shot, and multiple shots are edited together to create a scene. Comic books consist of a series of panels edited into a sequential order to create a scene.

The two seem very similar, do they not? I recommended that copying life is a great learning tool. Unless you plan on creating a ten-car pileup or have a sixth sense as to when the next natural disaster will occur, you will need to draw on your imagination to stage an action scene. Fortunately, you can watch a film on DVD, take notes on how different filmmakers stage action, and not have leave your house. They have spent millions of dollars trying to create artificial chaos that looks real, and it won't cost you more than a rental fee.



PREPARING FOR ACTION

Keep in mind, however, that you should not copy a scene from a movie. Unless your writer has copied a scene from a movie, your script will have its own original and specific action. Hopefully this will give you a number of ideas of how to convey the action in your script. Get them out of your head and down on paper in the form of sketches.

Here is where you will need to use every storytelling tool in your arsenal to grab the reader. Action should be clear and concise with a lot of impact. Prepare for a bit of revising here.

Earlier I discussed panel size, splash pages, and framing and cropping the figure. All of these tools are at your disposal, so use them all to create a great, memorable action scene.

Let's begin.

Following a series of panels with a large borderless panel (below) can be very effective when drawing action, as shown in this fight scene from *Angeltown*.

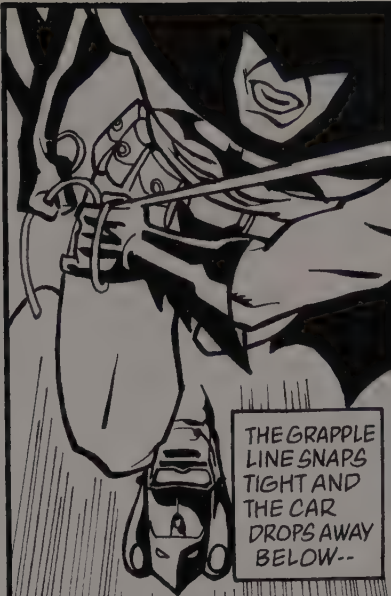
This page from *Detective Comics* (opposite) demonstrates how effective it can be for the subject to dramatically move through space. In the first four panels, Batman leaps from his car and flies through the air. Panel 3 is used to establish where he is headed and serves as a "quiet" moment to emphasize the following large explosive panel in which Batman crashes through the window.

From *Angeltown* #1 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.





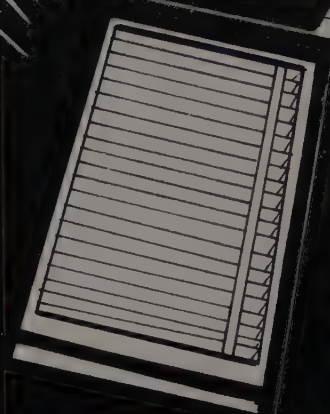
CLOSING ON PEGGY SUTTON'S APARTMENT HIGH-RISE.



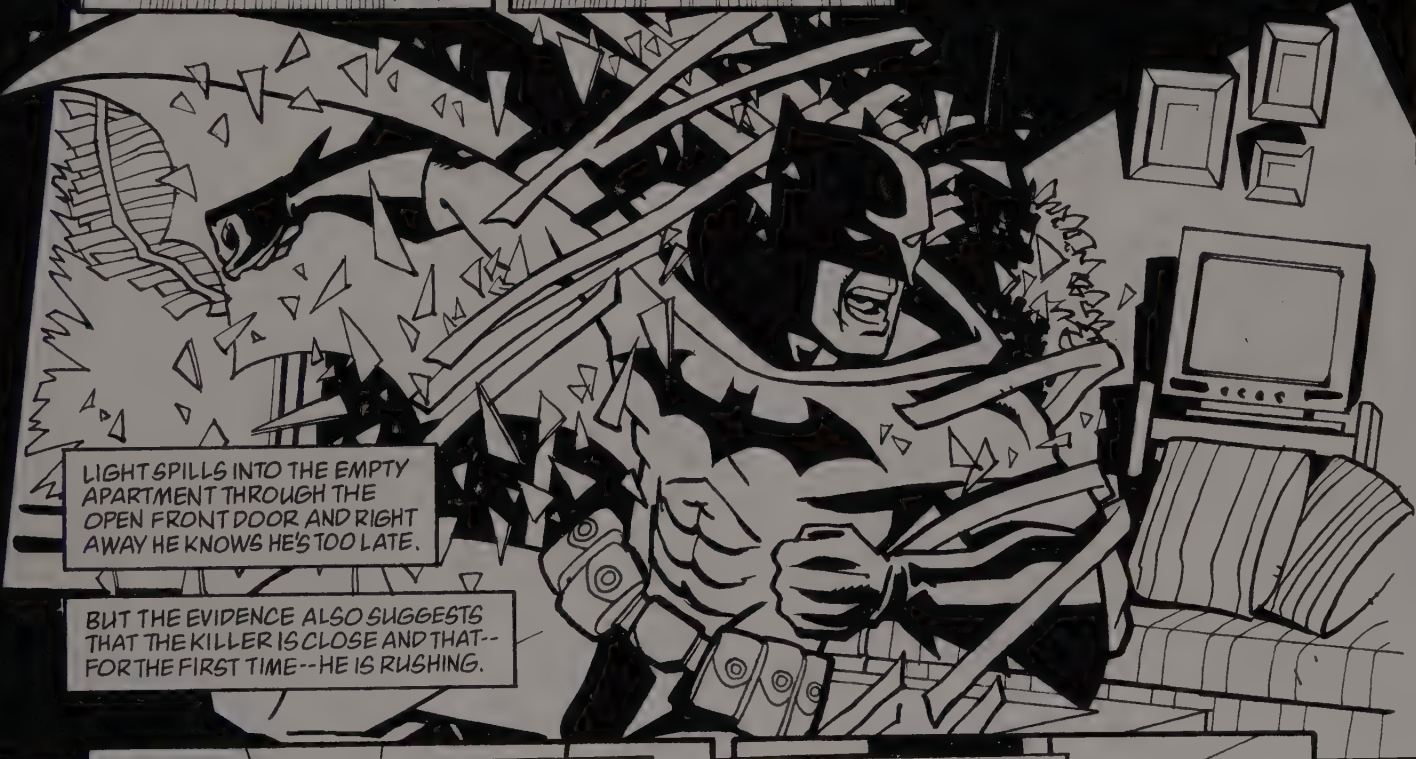
THE GRAPPLE LINE SNAPS TIGHT AND THE CAR DROPS AWAY BELOW--

--BATMAN RECALLS THE BUILDING'S BLUEPRINTS--

--HE COUNTS THE WINDOWS.

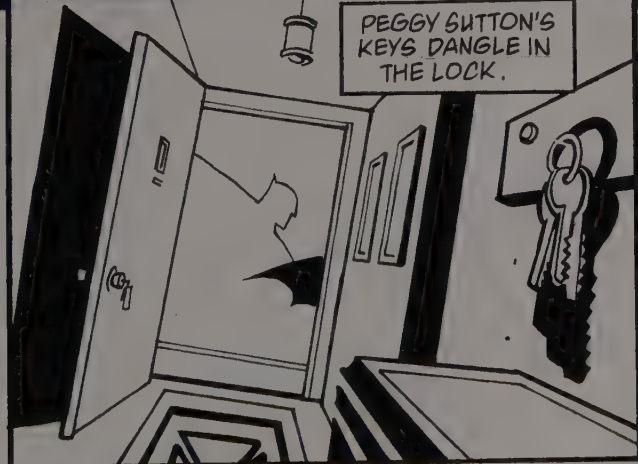


THERE IS NO TIME FOR FINESSE--



LIGHT SPILLS INTO THE EMPTY APARTMENT THROUGH THE OPEN FRONT DOOR AND RIGHT AWAY HE KNOWS HE'S TOO LATE.

BUT THE EVIDENCE ALSO SUGGESTS THAT THE KILLER IS CLOSE AND THAT--FOR THE FIRST TIME--HE IS RUSHING.



PEGGY SUTTON'S KEYS DANGLE IN THE LOCK.



HE FINDS HER DROPPED SHOE IN THE STAIRWELL--

--IT LEADS HIM TO THE ROOF.

THE RHYTHM

I see action as a series of beats.

Think of your favorite song. It can be any genre: classical, rock, pop, jazz, rap, alternative, metal—take your pick. Truly great songs have a rhythm. During the song the rhythm builds to a climax, which is typically the chorus. The chorus will build until the bridge and then explode into the final chorus. This constant shifting of tempo and intensity creates an emotional reaction when you listen to it.



Now apply this thinking when you lay out and stage your action.

I find it very effective to use small panels to build the action and then explode it in a large panel. The large panel can be designed to bleed, making it more dramatic. When you stage your action you must carefully vary the angles you choose. Even if you decide to have each panel on the page the exact same size, you must vary your angles. This will make the scene more visually interesting. After a series of intense shots, it is always good to remind the reader whom they are rooting for in the conflict. A well-placed close-up of the main character, usually in a smaller panel, can achieve this. It can also serve as a

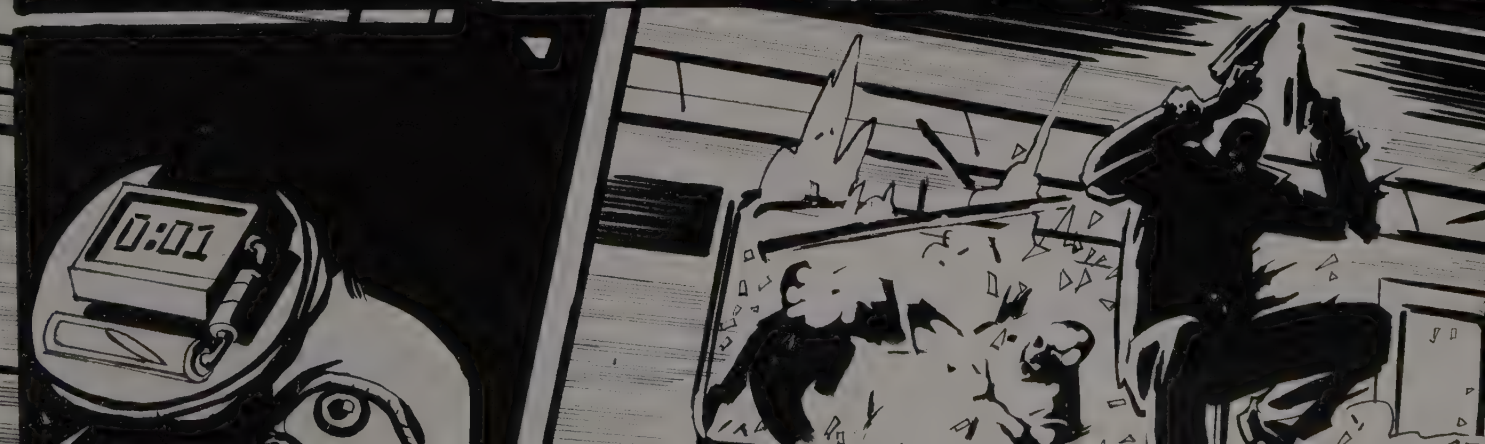
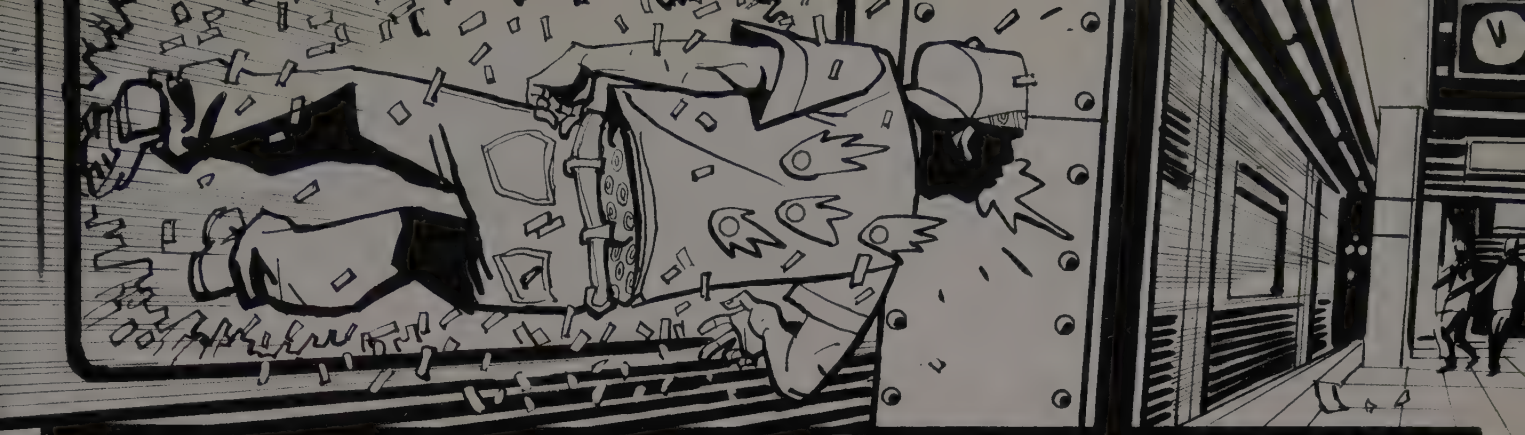
brief resting point for the viewer's eye, since the other larger panels can and should have detailed action occurring in them.

Now, don't get carried away; you still have a blueprint to follow, and that is the writer's script. Often, the writer will describe the action in a very basic way. The important goal of the action will be specific, but the way the action is conceived is left to you, the artist. If the writer trusts your storytelling ability, he or she will defer to you to design the action.

This is an important responsibility, so take it seriously and try to create something visually different.

This page from *Servants and Masters* (left) written by Kris Ex offers a good example of visualizing and creating action as a series of beats. The first panel is a very quiet, simple close-up of the main character's hands and guns. The second is a large panel that explodes in violence and establishes the players and the scene.

In this page from *Servants and Masters* (opposite), we discover that showing the effect of action can sometimes be more interesting than showing the act itself. In panel 1, we can infer that the main character has thrown his adversary out the window, but we do not see him do it. Observe how the angle in the second and fourth panels is moving closer to the smoking man. This piece of movement is intercut with the action, which is more visually interesting for the storytelling.



BACKGROUND, MIDDLE GROUND, AND FOREGROUND

Your attention to foreground, middle ground, and background elements is critical when you stage action. Great action should have something interesting happening on each of the three planes. For example, all of the action in the background and foreground should be affected by the main subject

in the middle ground.

The main subject can be at any distance, so these three areas can be interchanged. This will stimulate the reader's eye and imagination and make your page more engaging. If you choose to create action on three different planes, then it is your responsibility

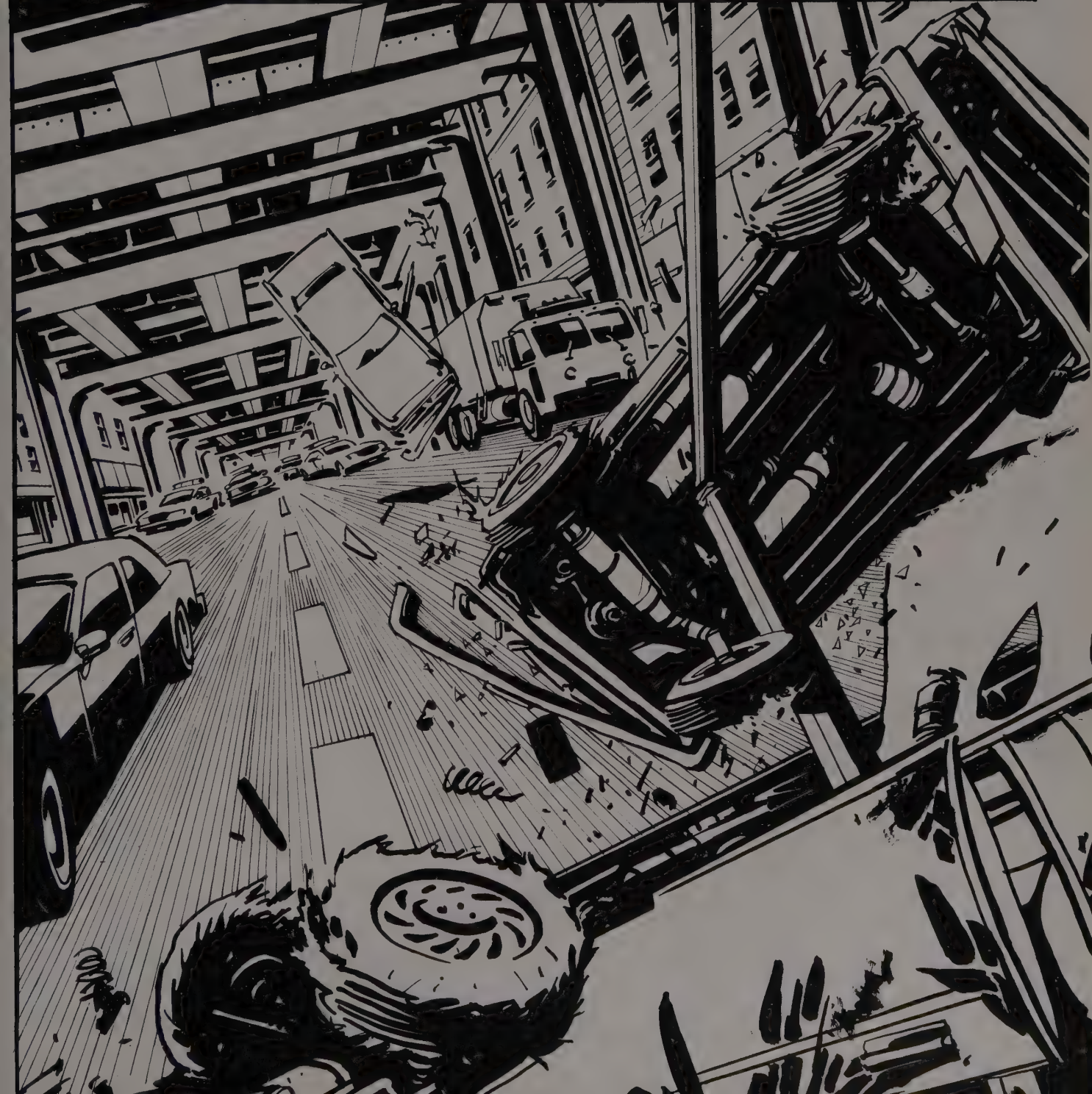
to create depth with your blacks. Things in the background should have less weight and detail than those in the foreground. This can be achieved by using finer lines and making the drawing less comprehensive. Basically, you can go a little looser with your drawing in the background to help draw more interest to what is occurring up front.

Think impressionistic.

This car chase scene from *The Morlocks* (left) shows how speed lines can be used to create movement. In the last panel of this page, the effect of violence can be effectively shown by repeating the sample panel design and adding an additional element. In this case, the additional element is a bullet to the head.

In the resulting car crash (opposite), the background, middle ground, and foreground are all used to maximize the action.





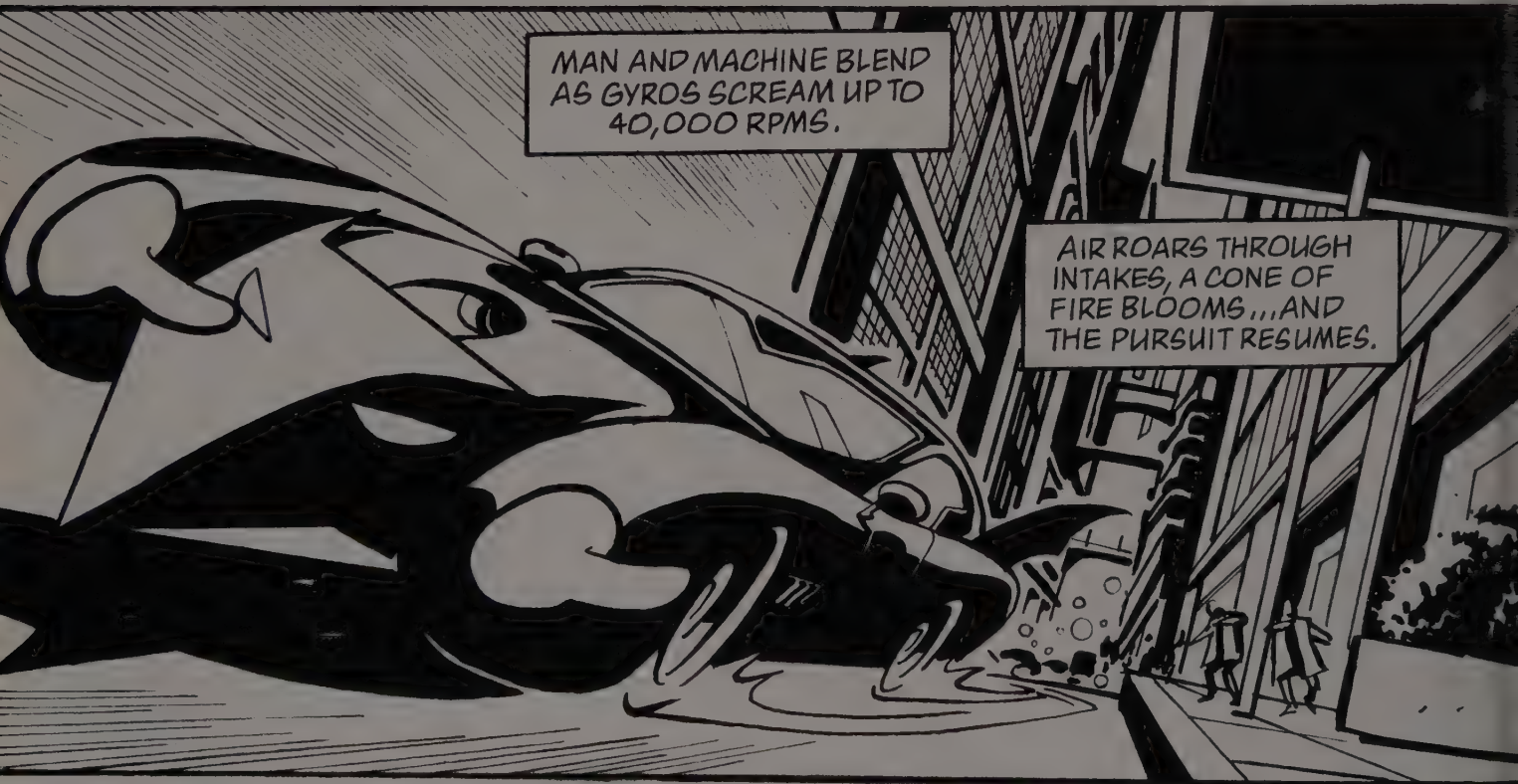
PERSPECTIVE

Being conscious of how the subject moves through space is essential to creating a captivating visual. Making a subject small (far away) in one panel and then big (close) in the next panel produces an interesting effect. It suggests movement between the two panels. Many artists use speed lines to convey movement. I prefer to use them sparingly and solely in the background. Instead I convey movement in the actions of the character and those with whom they are interacting. Remember that all of your subjects' movements and poses should not only be dynamic but should also be designed to advance the reader's eye to the next panel or page.

Perspective is also an amazing tool to use when designing action. Objects coming at the viewer

have more of an impact than those traveling left to right. To have an object coming straight at the viewer engages him and visually puts him in the path of the action.

Imagine going to a movie and watching a freight train coming right at you. This would have more of an effect than if the train were hurtling toward the right side of the screen. When a character or object is coming right at you, the perspective of every element in the background should reinforce its direction. This will draw your eye even more strongly to the subject. If you apply a heavy shadow to that figure or object, it will create weight and make it more dramatic as it comes at the reader.



From *Detective Comics* #783 © 2003 DC Comics. BATMOBILE™ DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



This panel from *Detective Comics* (opposite) uses perspective to create speed and intensity as the Batmobile races down a Gotham street. Observe how the entire panel and all of its elements are drawn on an angle to emphasize the direction of the car.

From *Angeltown* #5 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.

Pay close attention to the rhythm of the action in these two panels from *Angeltown* (above). The first panel draws your eye to the right, while the second panel below directs your eye back to the left. When you design action on a page, it is important to draw the viewer's eye to the action in the next panel.



This panel from *Detective Comics* (left) is an example of a subject starting small in one panel and dramatically filling the frame in the next.

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USING BLACK

The use of black can emphasize action by isolating characters and drawing the reader's attention to a key area.

For example, imagine that your script calls for one character to leap through the air to attack another in an underground sewer system.

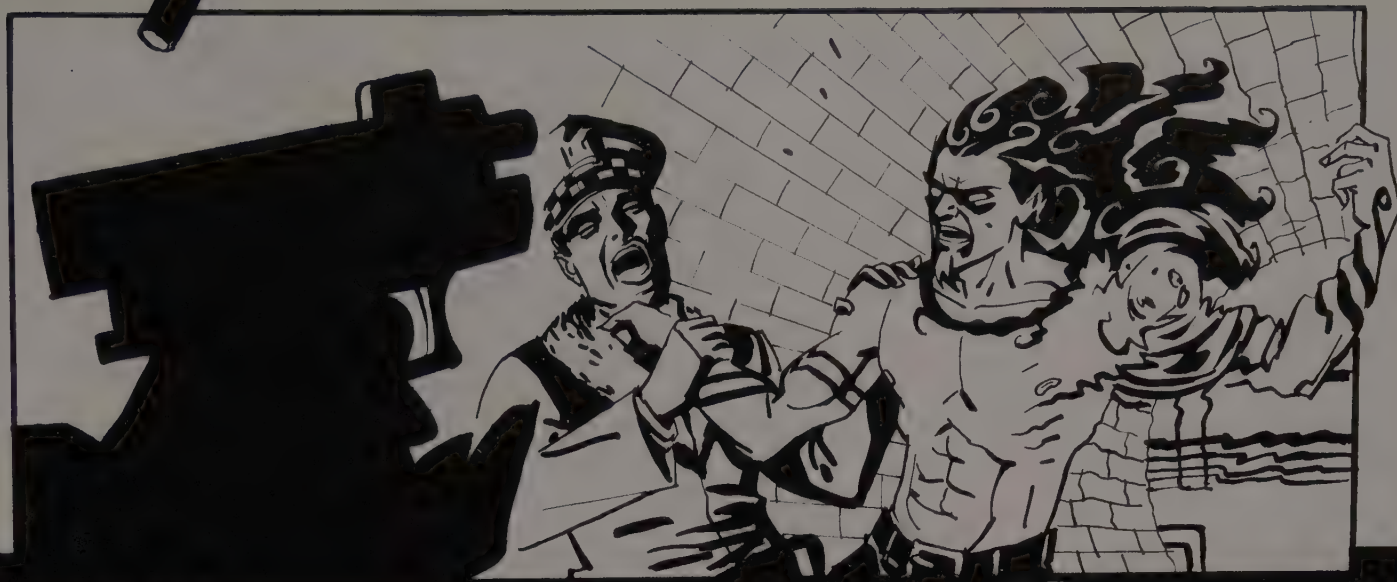
If you drew the character leaping out of complete darkness it would appear more ominous and threatening, since you have not established for the reader the attacker's point of origin. You could then draw the same scene but add a background of rusted pipes and a brick wall. This would be interesting as well but less dramatic, because you are not leaving anything to the viewer's imagination.

Also, backgrounds can remove the focus from what is happening in the foreground. I recommend using black backgrounds sparingly and only if they can be justified with the location in the script you are following. You would be more likely to find shadows in a sewer or a night-time setting than inside of a department store or city bus.

Think of it like this: if you use a black background in panel 1, reward the viewer with detailed backgrounds in panels 2 and 3.

Here are two examples of using various angles and contrasting shadow and light for optimum dramatic effect in this scene from *The Morlocks*. Also note how the action is choreographed and designed in each panel to draw the reader's eye to the next panel.





SILHOUETTES

Silhouettes can be very powerful when used in an action scene.

A silhouette is a drawing that is an outline of an object filled with a solid color. Since we are dealing with applying a noir style here, our two colors are black and white. Silhouettes are typically black because they are created by a strong or intense light source. They have weight, and if they are used to describe a figure with a very expressive gesture, silhouettes can be very dramatic.

If you can frame the silhouette in an interesting way and give it a larger scale in comparison to other objects in the panel, you can create a very exciting visual.



This detail from *The Seekers* (above) offers another example of using silhouette in action to enhance dramatic effect.

A silhouette can be very effective in establishing depth by establishing a foreground element. Since it is a solid black shape without detail, the reader's focus will not be drawn to it instead of to the main subject. However, do not become complacent with drawing a simple black shape. Your goal is to make that shape as convincing as possible. Because a silhouette includes no details to provide interest, the shape itself must be particularly distinct.

This page from *The Morlocks* (opposite) utilizes the silhouette technique very effectively. In addition to emphasizing the reaction of the character being shot, the silhouette also enhances the graphic approach to depicting his hair.



THE MAKING OF A GRAPHIC NOVEL: ACTION

In the script for the *The Truce*, there are limited action scenes, so when they do occur, the action must be dramatic. However, the depiction of violence still fits into the noir aesthetic that has already been established. Silhouettes and high-contrast black-and-white images are used to make a strong visual impact



The facial expression of the character makes this shot convincing. The bullet hole in the forehead combined with the shadow of the shooter are simple details that tell the story.

In this panel, the silhouette of the figure is contrasted against the bright marquee background, which creates a striking visual. The effect of the falling figure is created by his gesture, not speed lines. Below right, the initial sketch.



Chapter 7

CREATING DRAMA

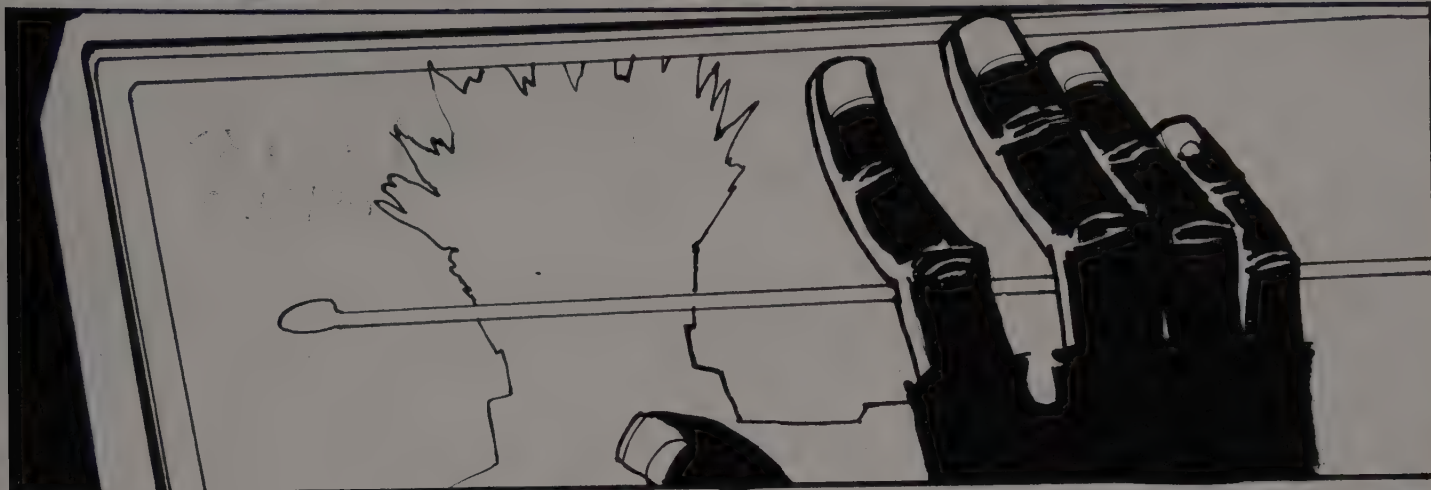
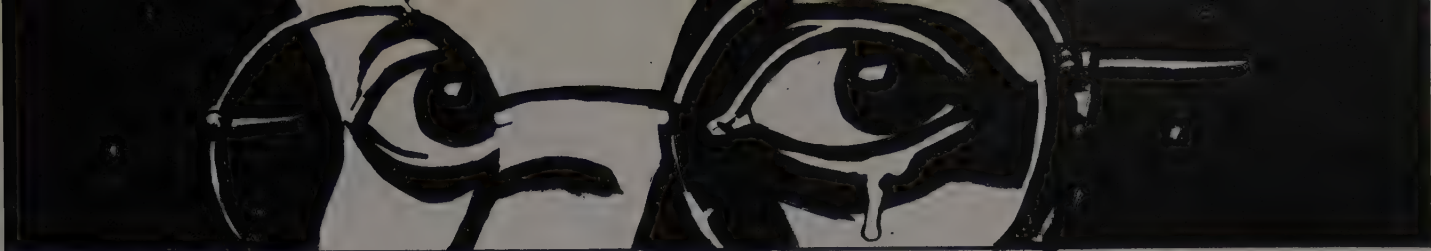


Drama is subtle. Let me clarify that: human drama is subtle.

In a visual medium such as comic book storytelling, which is designed to grab and impress the reader with strong images, creating subtlety can be a challenge.

Often in comics the drama is created by the script, not the artwork. However, I believe that the storytelling of the artist should be able to stand on its own. Based on the script, the drama should come from the way a scene is visually composed.

In this two-page sequence from *The Morlocks*, the main character visits his wife, who has been in a coma for years. The combination of varying angles and dramatic lighting heightens the emotional impact of the script.



SETTING THE STAGE FOR DRAMA

My friend Jim Kirkland once said to me, "In your artwork, the characters act." I was very thankful for the compliment, because this is what I strive for in every scene that I draw. I constantly reread the script as I draw the characters to make sure that I truly capture what the writer intended.

I use the same tools to create drama in the stories I draw that I use to stage action.

Remember my earlier chapter on portraits? Here is where all of your time capturing likenesses and facial details will pay off. Your experience in drawing numerous real faces will make you more adept in creating realistic expressions in your sequential storytelling. It can also help you understand the distinctive differences between ethnic groups, which can also make your storytelling more convincing.

This page from *Batman: The Hill* (below) is an example of using black and white to create atmosphere. From the claustrophobic congestion of Gotham City to the interior of Commissioner Gordon's office, every element is heightened by a dramatic use of shadow. The last panel displays my first attempt at using the "Dive bomb" visual for Batman, in which the caped crusader literally dives out of a window or off a rooftop.

Scale is another tool one can use to create drama. In this page from *The Morlocks*, (opposite) note the difference in size between the characters, which suggests a David versus Goliath scenario. A character triumphing against impossible odds can create intense drama.



From *Batman: The Hill* © 2000 DC Comics. BATMAN™ DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



INTENT

Something I strive to create when I visualize a dramatic scene is intent.

The script may call for a character about to pull a gun on another character, or for a giant robot to attack a group of school children, or a man asking a woman to marry him.

Consider this if you have room when you lay out the script in your thumbnails. I think it is very dramatic if you visually establish that something is about

to happen before your action starts. Think of an image conveying the calm before the storm.

It is as if the reader were watching a piece of action in midstream. I believe that if an image suggests intent, it will cause anticipation in the reader to see what happens next. Apply a strong lighting source and an interesting composition, and you will create a noir mood as well. It gives the image or panel an emotional weight that creates drama.



LIGHTING

Certain ways a face is lit are very indicative of the noir style. To create a dramatic moment, the lighting you choose will be key, as it can express so much of what the character is feeling or experiencing. The writer can write the words, but it is your job as the artist to bring the words to life and beyond. Strong lighting from a single light source can create and enhance a dramatic scene between characters. Remember the staging action chapter, how silhouettes can make a strong visual impact yet allow the viewer to focus on the main subject. You can achieve dramatic results by drawing a conversation between two characters and placing one of them in the foreground and shadow.



From *Angeltown* #5 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.

In this scene from *Angeltown* (above), a simple conversation is made more interesting by using dramatic lighting. The contrasting of black and white makes for a noir image.

These three panels from *Angeltown* (right) are more examples of dramatic, noir lighting enhancing a simple scene.

The image opposite is a prime example of one that shows “intent”—that is, the action depicted in this illustration is about to happen. This creates drama.



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From *Angeltown* #2 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



From *Angeltown* #2 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.

CROPPING FOR EFFECT

If they are made the focus of a panel, the eyes and mouth of a character can dramatically convey his or her emotional state.

Remember the chapter on framing and cropping the figure? Using your knowledge of cropping in on the character's face can achieve a very dramatic effect, especially if you light it dramatically. Hands can be very expressive as well.

The tighter the panel on the figures, the more intense the drama. The cropping around these characters in this panel from *Angeltown* (below) heightens the sexuality of this kiss.



WHY SHADOWS WORK FOR DRAMA

We fear the unknown, which is why we fear the dark. Because of this, the color black is a very important tool in creating drama and establishing a mood. If you draw a panel that is mostly in shadow, the reader's eye will go directly to the area that is illuminated. Why? Because these illuminated areas contain

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details that provide information to the reader. It helps him or her understand what is going on in the panel.

A reader looks for information in every panel, so the more selective you are with giving visual information, the more curiosity you will inspire from the reader. Shadows create drama and suspense for this very reason. They also create depth by adding another dimension to a simple line drawing.

Contrast equals intensity in visual storytelling.



In the previous page from *Detective Comics*, shadows are played to the fullest. The three shadowy figures in the first and largest panel are especially menacing. This makes it even more dramatic when the attacking Batman is revealed by the muzzle flash of the gun in the second panel.

Shadows play an extremely important role in this climactic page from *Angeltown*, opposite, in which the killer is finally revealed. The viewer's eye is drawn to the most important areas. Take note: only in the final, revealing panel are no shadows used.

The original thumbnail layout at right shows the initial design of the *Angeltown* page. The blacks are all worked out in this stage.

In the panel below from *Servants and Masters*, all extraneous information is kept in shadow, so the viewer's eye focuses on what's important: the faces of the two adversaries.





DRAMATIC RAIN

The visual effect of dramatic rain is evident in this page from *Detective Comics* (opposite). Combined with shadows, the heavy downpour produces a very noir-style image.

Rain is another element for creating drama. It can be a cliché to have a dramatic scene in the story taking place during a torrential downpour, but if done right, it can keep the reader on the edge of his seat.

Objects such as clothing become heavier when they get wet, so the artist should draw the characters posture to reflect that. If the characters appear to be weighted down, that can visually add to the moodiness of the scene. Realistically, characters will not be standing up straight during a heavy dose of rain unless the writer has written his scene to be a triumphant “hero moment” in the script. Shadows are a prerequisite for a dramatic noir-style rain scene. They give the artist more chances to create black-and-white contrast by having the rain streaks cut across the objects in the frame.

Combine the elements of rain, shadow, close-ups, and establishing shots, and you have the ingredients of a very dramatic noir-style image.

This scene from *Detective Comics* (opposite) is a prime example of how to use the various elements I previously described to create the noir mood. The constant streaks of white cutting through every form, the figure of Batman appearing weighted down by the downpour, the cropped close-up of Batman eyes, and a dramatic establishing shot all are used to create an ominous mood.



The inevitable aftermath of rain—the puddle—can add to the noir effect of your drawing by reflecting contrasting lights and shadows.



NOTHING UNTIL QRT IS
ON SCENE, UNDERSTOOD?"

33

OLD-FASHIONED
LEGWORK...

...PAYS OFF
IN THE END.

TEC 742

FOUR INSIDE, ALL
WITH ASSAULT
RIFLES.

GORDON MARCHES
IN THERE, IT'S THE
SAME AS SUICIDE.

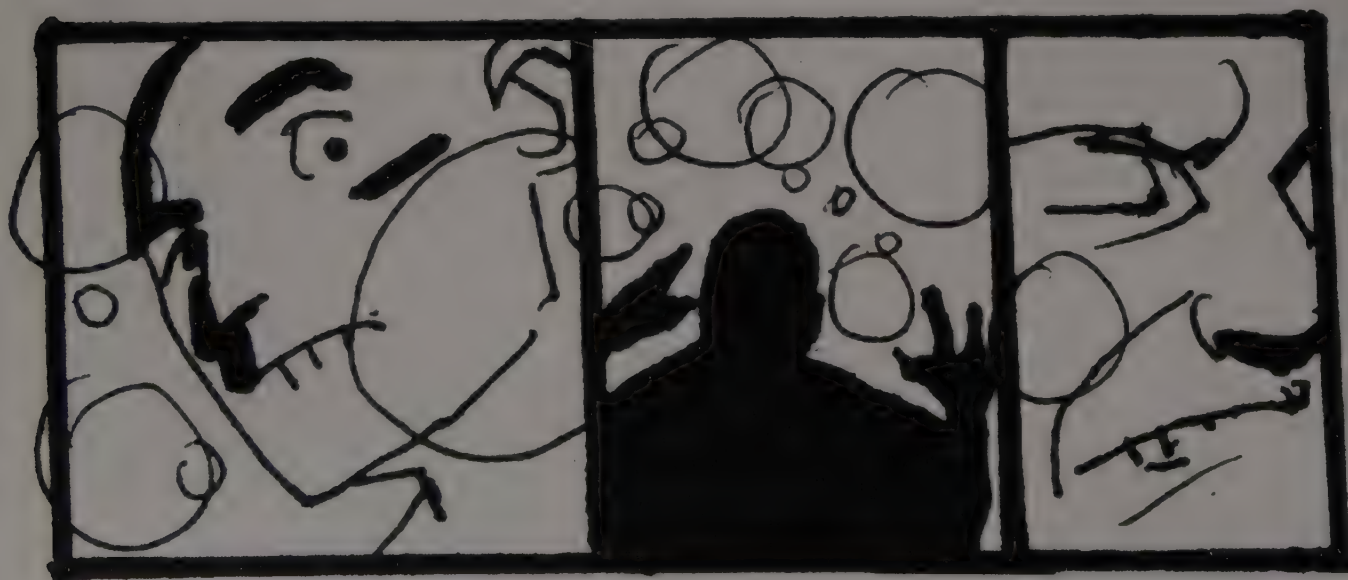
IF HE MARCHES
IN THERE ALONE.

THE MAKING OF A GRAPHIC NOVEL: DRAMA

The plot of *The Truce* centers on the verbal drama between the main two characters. To effectively convey this, close attention was paid to the way the characters "performed" on the page. Every look and gesture was specifically chosen to enhance the words in the script.



This sequence from *The Truce* uses close-ups (another form of cropping) and silhouette to heighten the intensity of a character suffering an anxiety attack. Below, the original sketch.



This panel is an example of using lighting to create a dramatic moment between two characters.



This panel below uses cropping and negative space to emphasize a key character moment. Above, an initial sketch.



Chapter 8

DESIGNING THE COVERS



Here are examples of telling a story in the cover design, in this case for the miniseries *Angeltown*. The main character, the supporting character, the premise, and, particularly important, the tone of the book, are all established in these images (opposite and following page). Above, a thumbnail sketch.

Covers can be a challenge, especially if you are used to telling stories sequentially. Instead of conveying information over a series of small illustrations, now you must condense that information into one large image. Usually you have to summarize the entire twenty-two or forty-eight-page story in a cover.

This can be approached in several different ways:

- You can tell the story with a collage of images of characters and scenes.
- You can illustrate a key scene or moment from the story.
- You can focus on the lead character.

Remember, the more detailed your cover, the harder it becomes to convey a clear message of what the story is about.



SELL IT

Covers must be designed to tell a story. This is what grabs a customer and hopefully persuades him or her to purchase your book instead of the hundreds of other books on the shelf. If you are working on a story that features popular and established characters like Superman or Batman, you are already appealing to a built-in fan base.

This does not let you off the hook as an artist designing the cover. Now you have to get those fans excited about your story.



The graphic quality of the flare was chosen as an interesting design element in this cover for *Angeltown* (opposite). It provides different layers in which to feature the supporting characters, but at the same time it prominently displays the main character.

In the original sketch for the cover (above), the areas of black and white were clearly established before proceeding to the final version.

Angeltown #3 © 2005 Gary Phillips & DC Comics. All Rights Reserved. Used with Permission.



SHAPES AND OVERLAPPING

I find shapes to be interesting elements to use when designing covers. Using rectangles and squares can create mini-sequential panels on a cover. These can be used to display characters and scenes from the story on the cover. Overlapping shapes and figures is a very basic yet effective technique in designing covers. Placing objects in front and behind each other creates depth and establishes prominence among the images.

The size of an object or figure also helps you point out which is more important in regards to the story. Usually the main character will be in the foreground. Their figure will typically overlap all other elements, establishing that it is the most important.

This illustration created for BODOG (below) uses overlapping elements and negative space to create an arresting design. In addition to poker chips, the images of the supporting characters are displayed in rectangles similar to playing cards, creating a mood of high stakes.

More mood than story content is conveyed in this alternate *Angeltown* cover illustration (opposite). The dominance of the main figure is established by its overlaying the other elements.





[Signature] 3/07

USING FACES

Faces grab the reader's attention. Some of the most famous paintings in the world are portraits.

Eyes create a mood very effectively and can tell a story on their own. The subtle details of a face can speak volumes. If you add a strong, dramatic light source, a well-drawn face will leap off the page. A face surrounded by black can be a very striking image.

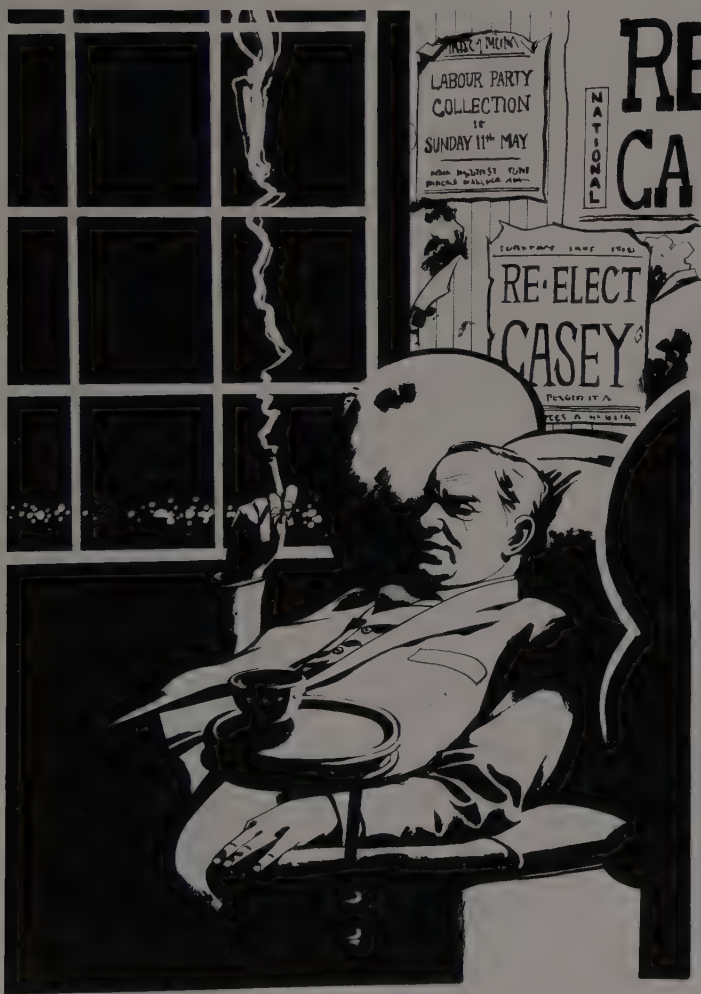
Using a close-up of your main character can make a very effective cover image. Once again, here is another opportunity to capitalize on having practiced drawing portraits.



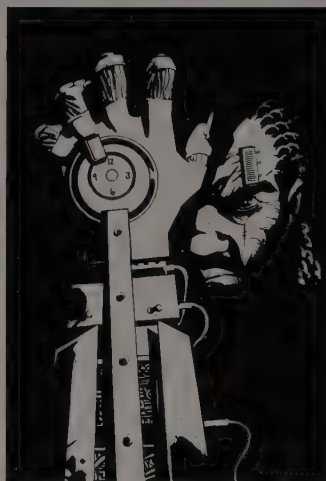
A contour line drawing (above left) establishes the composition.



This version of the drawing (above right) simply identifies the areas of light and dark/black and white for the final illustration.



This cover illustration was inspired by a favorite Norman Rockwell painting. Mood is the focus of this piece. Additional details also suggest a story behind the figure.



Created for the Smithsonian Institution, these two illustrations use a simple design to maximize the drama and focus of the images. The angst of the two faces and the detail of the technology are amplified when set against the solid black background.



The borders of an image can also be used in its design (above left). Not only do the shadows on the figure blend into the black background, but the areas in white merge into the border. The roughness of the border is also suggestive of the character.



This cover illustration (above right) represents a very simple graphic approach. There are no unnecessary details added to the form.

A simple contour line drawing (near right) establishes the figure.

This version (far right) was done with brush to establish line weight. In the final image all lines will be replaced with shapes.



ACTION

Action always grabs a reader's or consumer's attention. Once again, keep in mind the foreground, middle ground, and background when you design an action scene for the cover. The hero or main character should be at the center of the action. He should engage the consumer by his gaze or reaction to something extremely dramatic. The hero or main character does not have to be in the center of the image. I find subjects that are slightly if not completely off center to make for a more interesting composition. Once you have established where your main



subject will be in the image, none of the other elements in the frame should distract from it. I mentioned before that intent is an interesting approach in creating an engaging image, so it can be very effective in creating a cover. If the feeling of intent is conveyed properly, the consumer should be driven to pick up the book to see what happens next based on the cover image. When that occurs, your mission as the cover artist is accomplished.



This cover for a proposed Transformers miniseries written by Milo Stone (above) is another example of a simple graphic approach to cover design. The story features a new breed of Transformers, so their being cast in silhouette is meant to convey an element of danger.

In this concept illustration for an Xbox video game (left) in development, the negative space is a key design element. As the main figure charges toward the viewer, the criminal figures of the underworld are cast in the shadow of his coat.

THE TEXT

The text is a key element to consider when designing the cover. The text will consist of the book title, number, price, and a few other relevant pieces of information for the consumer. In most cases, these elements are mandatory, so it is very effective to design your cover with a substantial amount of negative space to incorporate them. Actually, this design "problem" can turn out to be quite advantageous when applying a noir approach, as shadows can create interesting areas of negative space while producing an overall dramatic image that grabs the consumer.



This illustration (above) is another example of using negative space when designing a cover or single illustration. The stylized Los Angeles skyline is contrasted against the solid black figure of the main character to great effect.



Sometimes a simple approach is most effective when designing an interesting cover (bottom right). A detailed, shadowy figure set against a white background makes for a bold image.



This illustration (top) was created for a proposal for a miniseries called *Eternal Lane*, co-written by Paul Benjamin. The story dealt with supernatural forces in a neighborhood, so the object was to create an ominous mood with minimal detail.

An initial thumbnail sketch for the cover for *Eternal Lane* (left).

Graphic Novel

THE TRUCE

Written and Illustrated by
Shawn Martinbrough

Lettering by
Elbert Or

Editorial Consultant:
Joseph Phillip Illidge



**Barlett
becomes Crime Boss
of city**
Rubs out all competition



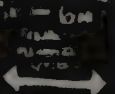
**Mob Wife on
Killer million dollar
Spending spree**





AVE V

NO STANDING



WHAT THE...?
MR. B IS BACK IN THE
NEIGHBORHOOD!

NEVER TRUST A MAN
WHO WALKS LIKE HE HASN'T
GOT A CARE IN THE WORLD.





Prior to five years ago he didn't. Max Barlett was the undisputed crime boss of the city.

Every public official was on his payroll, and despite Max's reputation of violence, the media loved his infamous swagger.

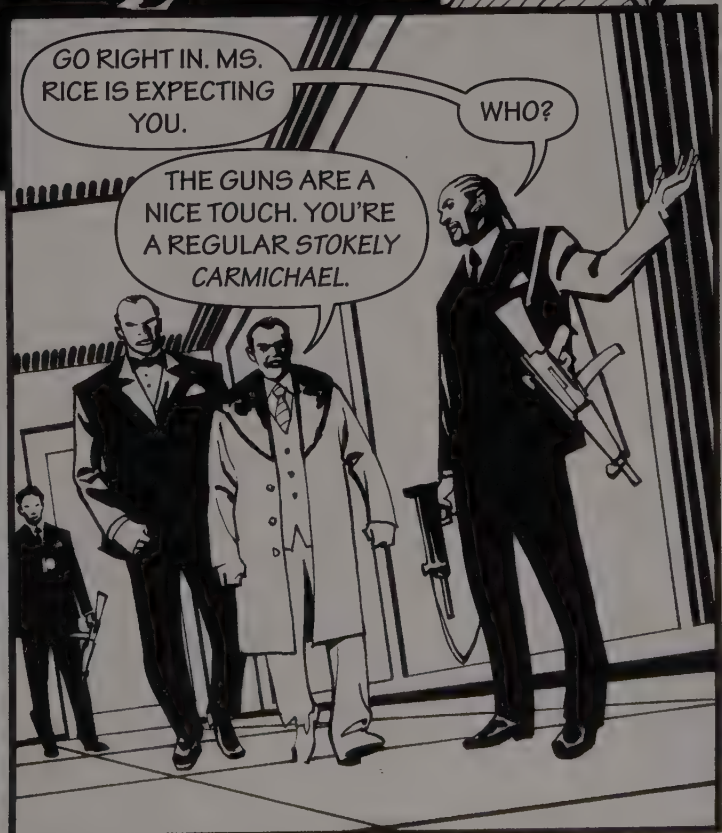
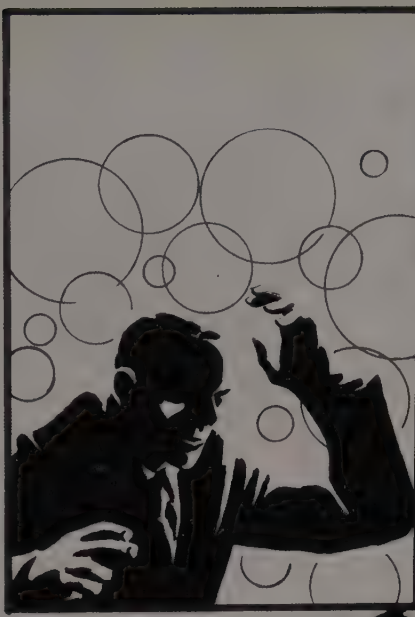
Then he fell in love with Evelyn Rice.

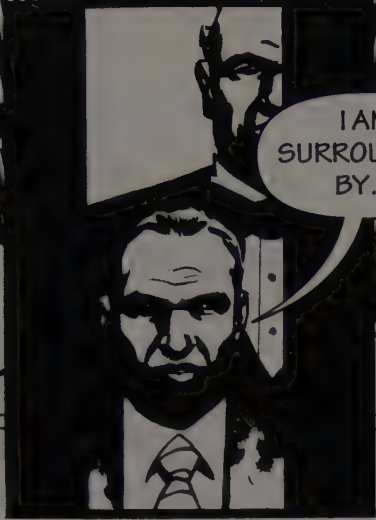
The city has been in chaos ever since.

KEEP UP WITH ME.

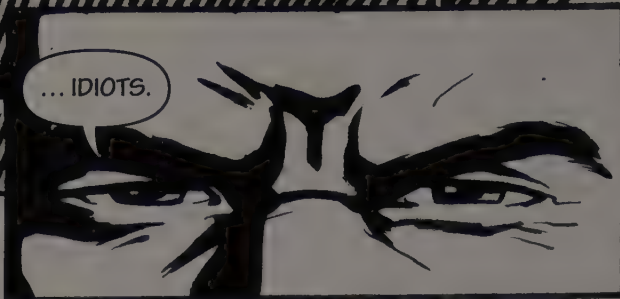
KING







I AM
SURROUNDED
BY...

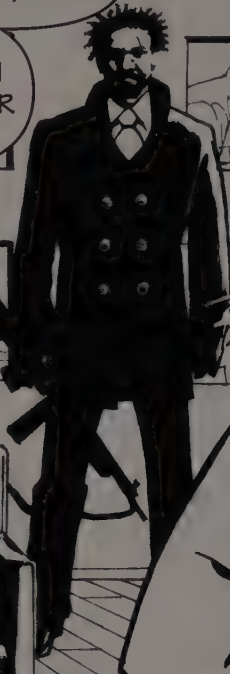
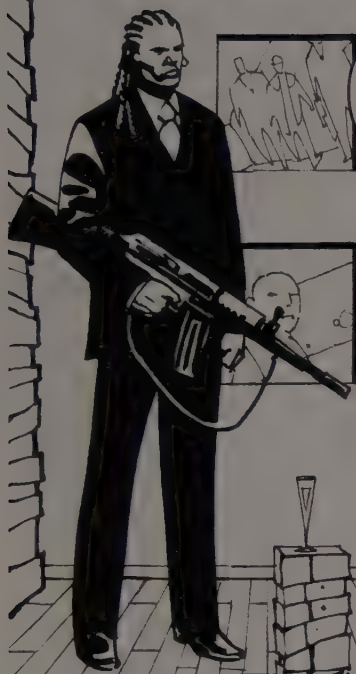


... IDIOTS.

THANK YOU FOR
COMING OUT TO
SEE ME, MAX.

YOU AND YOUR
PEOPLE HAVE BEEN
RATHER ELUSIVE FOR
THE PAST YEAR.

THE STREETS ARE DANGEROUS
THESE DAYS, EVELYN. I'VE BEEN TOLD
THAT YOU'RE OFFERING A TRUCE?



HOW IS
JASPER?

"STILL MY RIGHT-HAND MAN."



"LITTLE LOUIE FEINSTEIN?"

"STILL MY ATTORNEY."



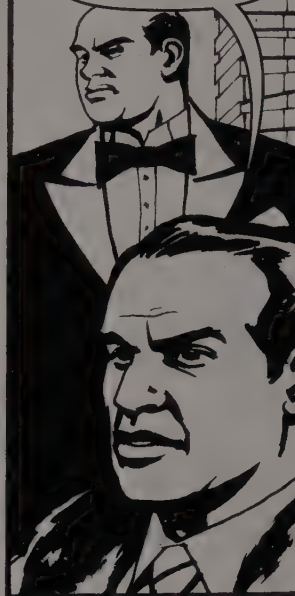
"ARTHUR TASK?"

"STILL CRUNCHING THE NUMBERS."



AND YOU, BIG TONY?

STILL DOING WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE. I'M A BUSY MAN, EVELYN. TALK.



YOU AND I HAVE BEEN AT WAR FOR FIVE YEARS, AND THE CITY HAS SUFFERED FOR IT.

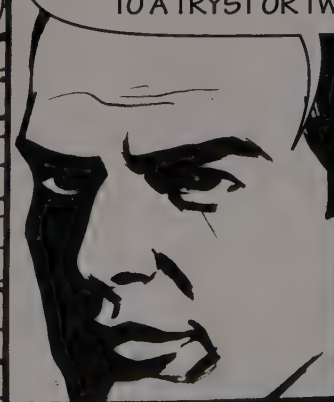
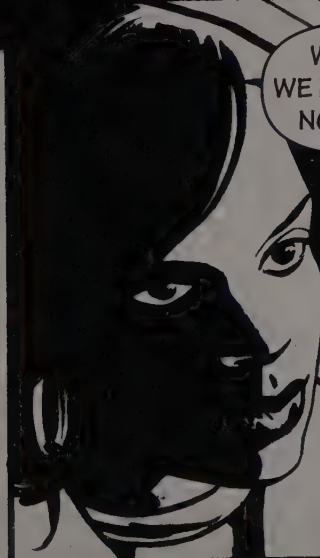
ARE YOU WAVING THE WHITE FLAG?



WHATEVER TRUCE WE BROKER TODAY WILL NOT BE CHEAP, MAX.

YOU BROKE MY HEART, AND THERE'S A COST FOR THAT.

GROW UP, LYNN. I'M A CAPTAIN OF INDUSTRY. WE'RE ENTITLED TO A TRYST OR TWO.



WHAT ABOUT THE
VOWS YOU SPOKE AT
OUR WEDDING?

I VOWED TO GIVE YOU A LIFESTYLE
LITTLE GIRLS DREAM ABOUT, AND TO
LOVE YOU LIKE NO OTHER MAN HAD.

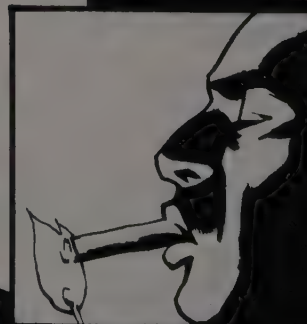
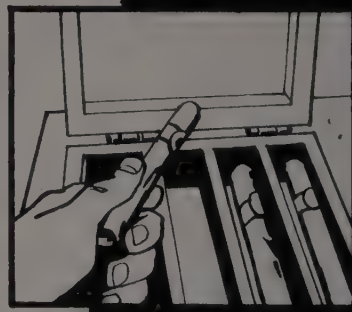
I DELIVERED ON
BOTH FRONTS.

EXPERTS SAY MEN CHEAT
TO COMBAT ISSUES OF
ABANDONMENT. YOU WERE
MAKING SUCH PROGRESS
WITH DR. CARL.

ARE YOU STILL AFRAID
OF BEING ALONE, MAX?

CRY ME A RIVER, SWEETHEART.
YOU WEREN'T THAT SPECIAL.

CIGAR?



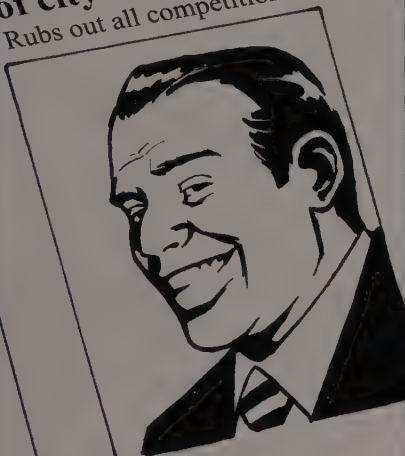
I MUST ADMIT, EVERYTHING
YOU PUT TOGETHER, THIS CLUB,
YOUR WHOLE OPERATION—

YOU SURPRISED ME.

"YOU RAN THIS CITY FOR
TEN YEARS, AND WE WERE
MARRIED FOR FIVE OF THEM."

"I LEARNED A LOT."

**Barlett
becomes Crime Boss
of city**
Rubs out all competition



By Alan Smith

After a very bloody Tuesday, reputed
Barlett seized control of the ten fami
out were Dino Fabrizzo, Emiliano S
Despite the day time m

"I DIDN'T THINK YOU FOUND
THE TIME BETWEEN SHOPPING
TRIPS TO FIFTH AVENUE."

"A SMART WOMAN LEARNS
HOW THE MONEY IS MADE
BEFORE SHE SPENDS IT."

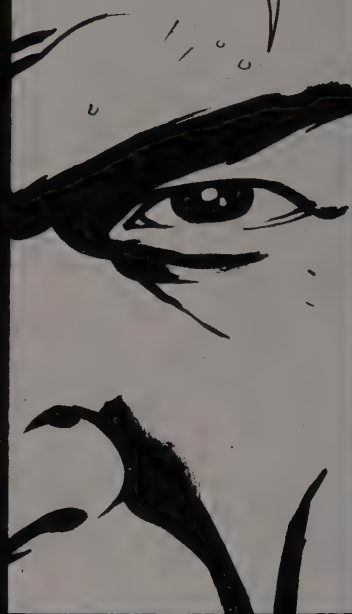
**Mob Wife on
Killer million dollar
Spending spree**

g gross
nce, the
holders
ere fired.
ordered all
nder armed
be forced to
on their face
e required to
a. They would
elligence testing.
d be terminated.

os Angeles where
el Davis, the team
lict massive bodily
e beaten to a bloody
retard and administer
regions multiple times.



WAS IT ALL ABOUT
THE MONEY?



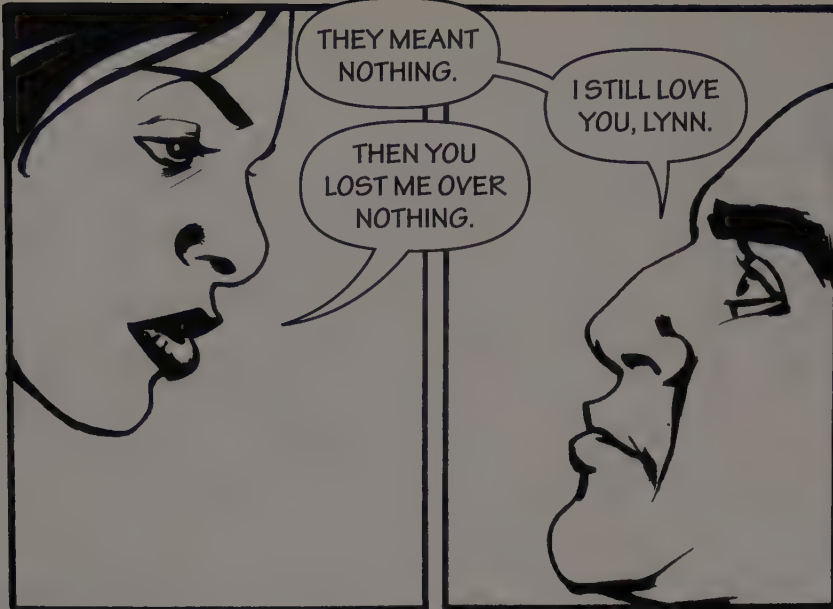
OF COURSE NOT.
I LOVED YOU, MAX.

I WAS A TWENTY-SIX-YEAR-
OLD LOUNGE SINGER FROM
THE SOUTH SIDE WHEN YOU
MET ME. I HAD NOTHING.

YOU LISTENED TO ME.
YOU ADORED ME.

I WOULDN'T ALLOW YOU
TO SHARE THAT WITH
ANOTHER WOMAN.





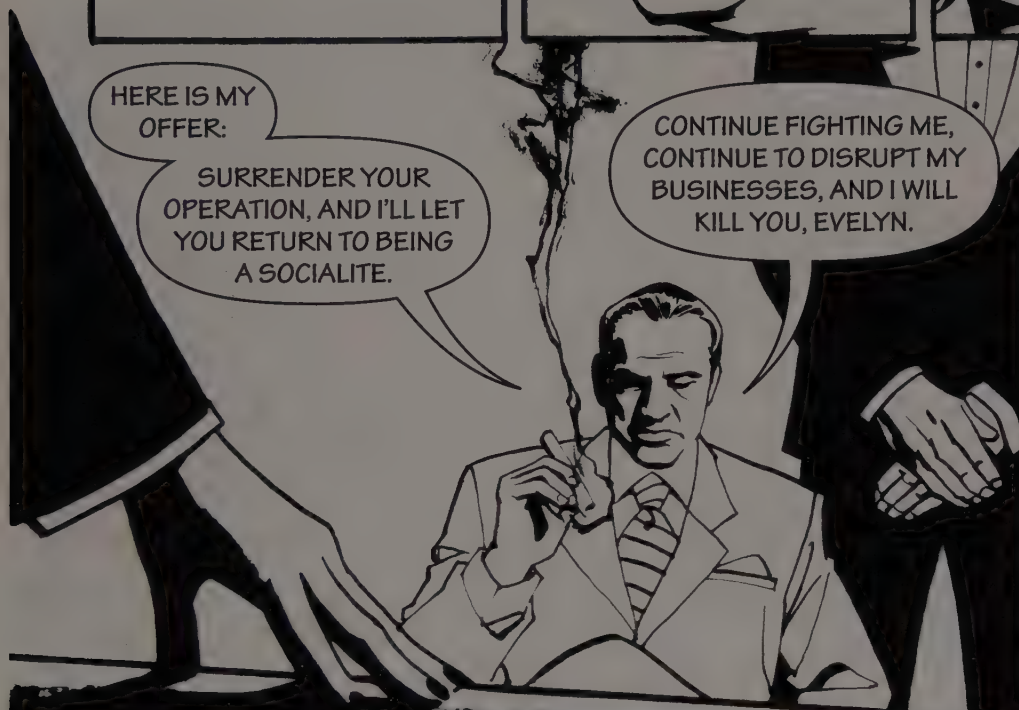
THEY MEANT NOTHING.

I STILL LOVE YOU, LYNN.

THEN YOU LOST ME OVER NOTHING.



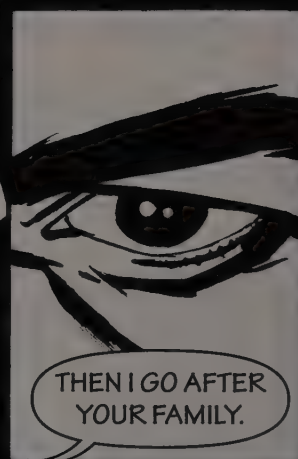
CRY ME A RIVER.



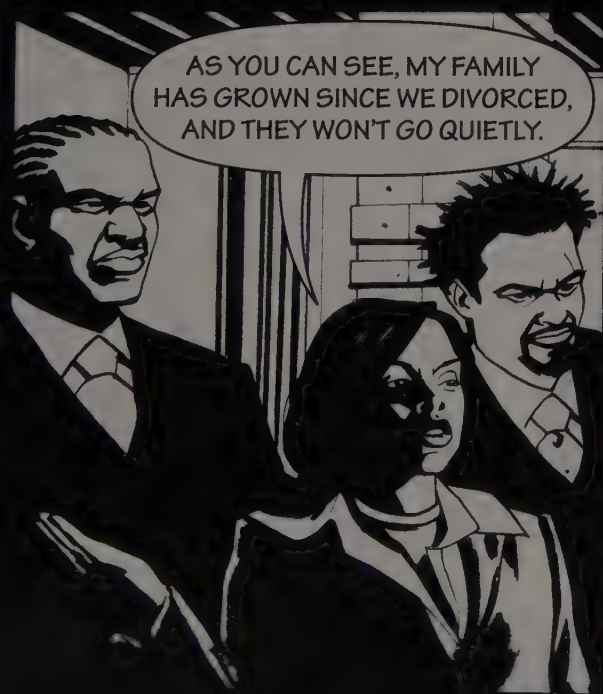
HERE IS MY OFFER:

SURRENDER YOUR OPERATION, AND I'LL LET YOU RETURN TO BEING A SOCIALITE.

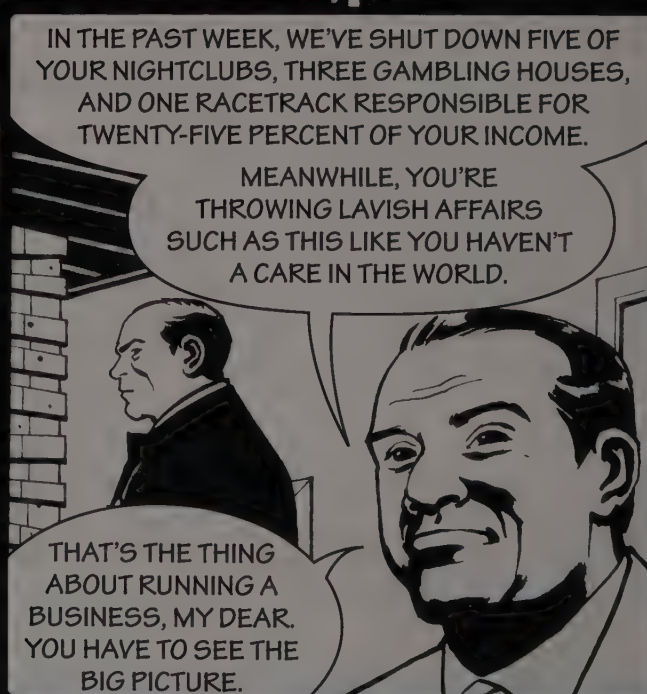
CONTINUE FIGHTING ME, CONTINUE TO DISRUPT MY BUSINESSES, AND I WILL KILL YOU, EVELYN.



THEN I GO AFTER YOUR FAMILY.



AS YOU CAN SEE, MY FAMILY HAS GROWN SINCE WE DIVORCED, AND THEY WON'T GO QUIETLY.



IN THE PAST WEEK, WE'VE SHUT DOWN FIVE OF YOUR NIGHTCLUBS, THREE GAMBLING HOUSES, AND ONE RACETRACK RESPONSIBLE FOR TWENTY-FIVE PERCENT OF YOUR INCOME.

MEANWHILE, YOU'RE THROWING LAVISH AFFAIRS SUCH AS THIS LIKE YOU HAVEN'T A CARE IN THE WORLD.

THAT'S THE THING ABOUT RUNNING A BUSINESS, MY DEAR. YOU HAVE TO SEE THE BIG PICTURE.



YOU INHERITED THE FAMILY
BUSINESS RATHER LATE IN
LIFE, MAX.

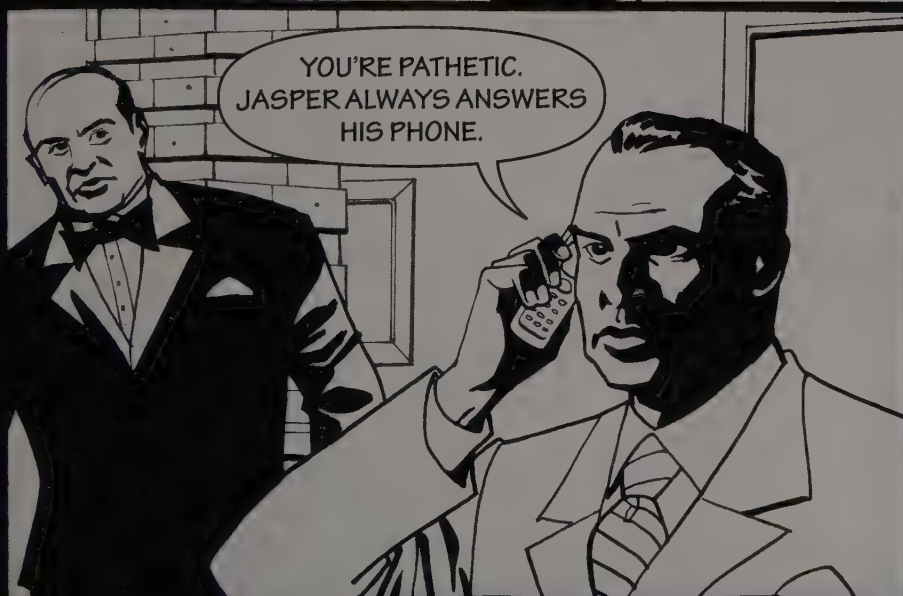
IF IT WASN'T FOR JASPER COHEN STEPPING
IN AND SEEING THE BIG PICTURE, YOU WOULD
HAVE BEEN IN THE GROUND YEARS AGO.



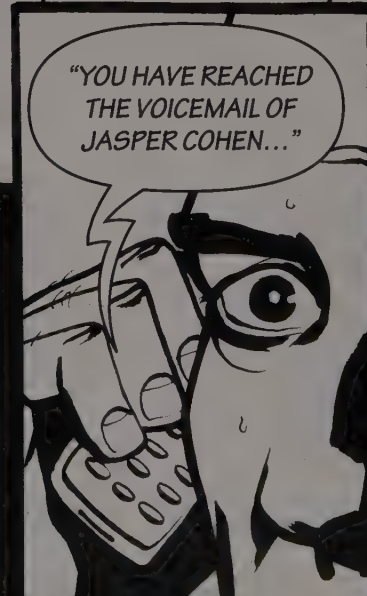
I AM THE DECIDER, EVELYN.
JASPER WORKS FOR ME.



JASPER IS
DEAD, MAX.



YOU'RE PATHETIC.
JASPER ALWAYS ANSWERS
HIS PHONE.



"YOU HAVE REACHED
THE VOICEMAIL OF
JASPER COHEN..."

"HE CHOKED TO DEATH ON A STEAK DINNER IN THE CLUB BALLROOM TWENTY MINUTES AGO."



"LITTLE LOUIE? HE FELL OUT OF A WINDOW ON THE THIRTEENTH FLOOR FIFTEEN MINUTES AGO."



"ARTHUR TASK HUNG HIMSELF IN THE BATHROOM TEN MINUTES AGO."

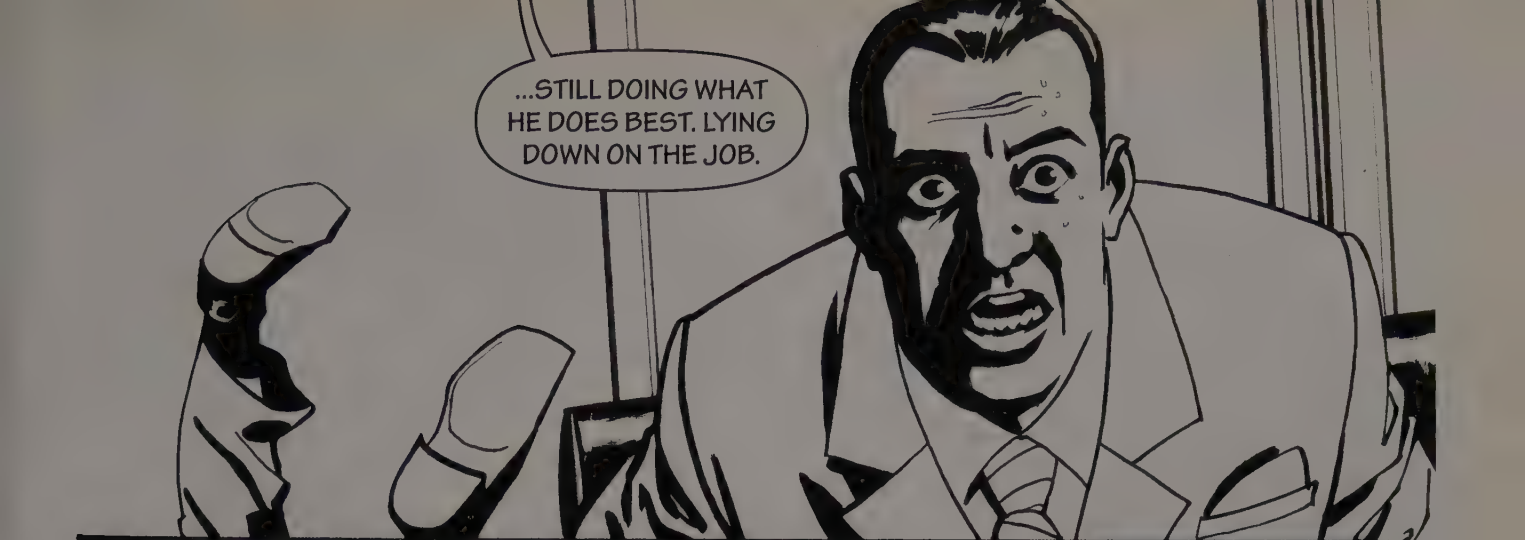


BOSS?



AND BIG TONY...





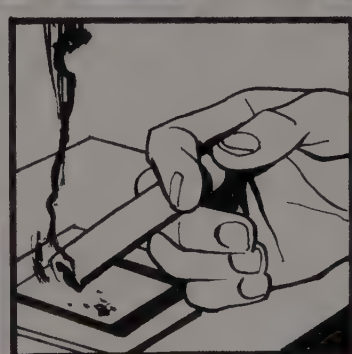
...STILL DOING WHAT
HE DOES BEST. LYING
DOWN ON THE JOB.



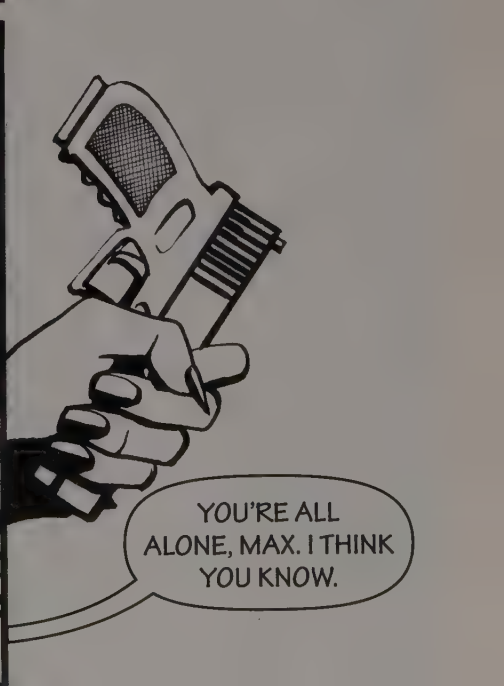
IT'S AMAZING HOW
MUCH EASIER IT IS TO ELIMINATE
ONE'S ENEMIES WHEN THEY'RE
ALL IN ONE PLACE.



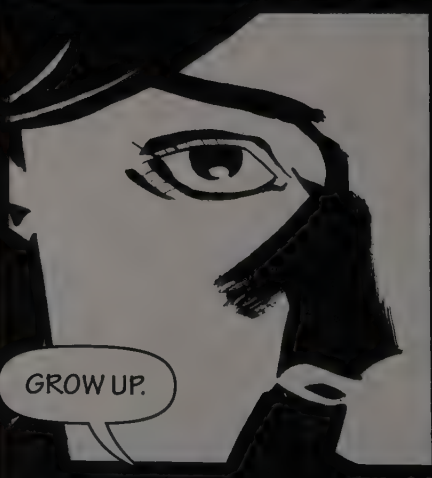
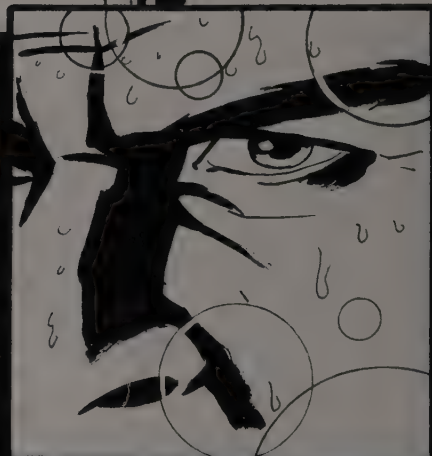
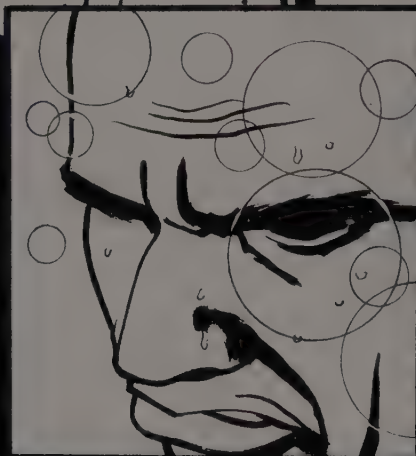
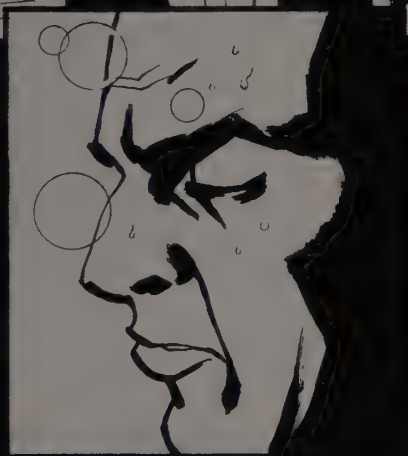
YOU WERE TELLING
ME ABOUT THE BIG
PICTURE, DEAR?



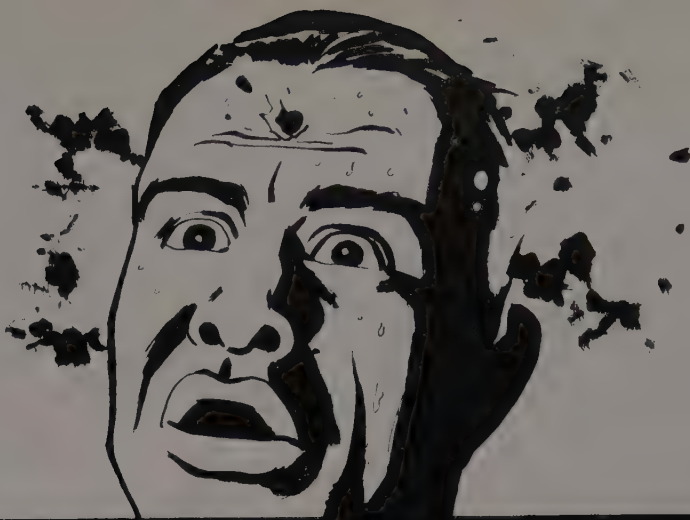
WHAT'S YOUR
OFFER?



YOU'RE ALL
ALONE, MAX. I THINK
YOU KNOW.



BRAKK



SUCKER.



END

EPILOGUE



I hope this book and all of its chapters have been helpful to you.

During my career as an artist thus far, I have had many aspiring and fellow artists ask me about my particular style of using black and white. It is gratifying to be able to channel all of my random and not so random concepts into this instructional text.

As I said before, art is a constantly evolving medium, and hopefully I, as an artist, will evolve with it.

My use of shadow and light is just a way of visualizing the real

world and to somehow capture it on a two-dimensional plane.
If I succeed in creating a mood, drama, or a feeling of motion in just one panel, then I am one step closer to understanding the world around me.

Hopefully, you will, too.

Shawn Martinbrough

Washington, DC

January 2007

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS



To Debra Drodvillo, for her incredible talent as a designer and for managing to pull together the huge amount of artwork and text into a beautiful package.



To my editor, Abigail Wilentz, who tirelessly worked numerous hours to bring this entire project together. I couldn't have asked for a more professional and nicer person to oversee my first instructional book.

To Joseph Phillip Illidge, for being a pal and lending his considerable talents to editing the original 14-page noir story.

To Elbert Or, for the wonderful job bringing my words to life with his great lettering.

Finally, special thanks to Assata Ellis, Kishan Khona, Danny Freeman, Michael Eubanks, and Milo Stone.



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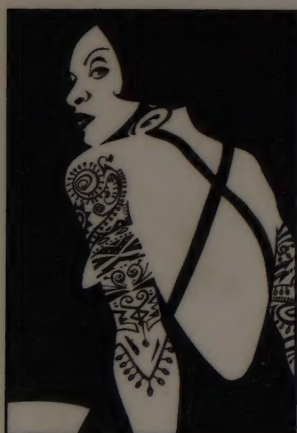
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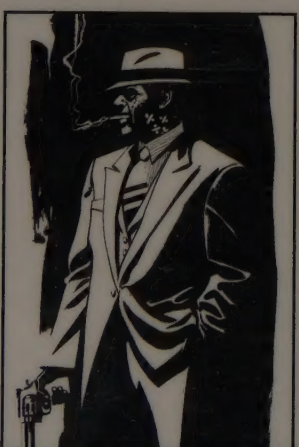
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Learn to capture the dark world of noir, from sinister superpowers to seamy urban grit.



Cover art by
SHAWN MARTINBROUGH
Cover design by
ANDREW DUQUET
Author photo by
TYLER MALLORY

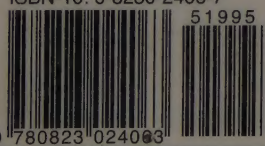


The concept of "noir" immediately brings to mind bleak urban settings; rough, seedy characters; and dim, obscure lighting—the antithesis of all that is cheerful, friendly, and bright. In *How to Draw Noir Comics*, author Shawn Martinbrough illuminates the irresistibly murky universe of gangsters, superheroes, and other creatures of the underworld for all to explore and master. When it comes to drawing noir comics, it's all about the expert use of the "color" black, and Martinbrough shows how to use it to its fullest potential to create shadows, silhouettes, texture, and more. He demonstrates how to set a mood, design characters and locations, stage action, and enhance drama, and he discusses important topics like page layout, panel design, and cover design.

This book also includes an original graphic novel, *The Truce*, which incorporates the many lessons addressed throughout.

SHAWN MARTINBROUGH has illustrated comics for DC Comics, Vertigo, and Marvel Comics, ranging from *Batman*, *Superman*, and *X-Men*, to *King James*, based on superstar athlete LeBron James. His client list also includes LucasArts, Bad Boy Entertainment, *Playboy*, and Penguin Books, and his work can be viewed at www.verge.tv. Martinbrough's work has been covered by *USA Today*, *Architecture Magazine*, *Vibe*, the *Washington Times*, *The Source*, *AintItCoolNews.com*, and Black Entertainment Television, and in 2004 he was named one of "Washington, D.C.'s Best" by the *Washingtonian*. He lives in Washington, D.C.

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